THE ALTERNATIVE SERIES - VOLUME 1

the moment we met was a lie

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KARI WIETHOP

not your typical romance saga

the moment
we met
was a lie

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Chapter 1

The target, a petite blonde in her twenties, walks out the main door of a small office complex. She's dressed in business casual attire, off work for the day. Less than a dozen parked cars are scattered throughout the lot in front of the building. She spots her blue Honda sedan and heads towards it.

The sun has just begun to set, so the parking lot lights have not come on. A thick mix of hedges and palm trees border the lot, providing privacy from a low-traffic road nearby. The target unlocks her Honda and gets inside. Once situated, she tries starting the ignition. The battery's dead. She tries again but gets nothing, not even a click. In sudden frustration, she wrings her hands and fishes her phone out of her purse. She stops when she hears a car approaching.

A silver Porsche Cayenne pulls up and parks in the spot beside her. She looks through her window and sees the driver, a moderately pretty blonde who's roughly five years older and potentially helpful. The target drops her phone back into her purse and scrambles to get out of her car. She goes around to the driver's side door of the Cayenne.

Inside, Shay Fontaine is turning off the ignition. When she opens her door, Shay is greeted by the flustered blonde.

"Hi there. I am so sorry to bother you, but do you have jumper cables by any chance?" She presses her palms together in front of her chest, practically pleading.

"I do, actually."

The target tilts her head back in relief. "Oh, thank you."

Shay gets out of her Cayenne and pops open the back hatch door. As she walks around back with the target at her side, Shay bumps her elbow on the backseat window.

"You okay?"

"Yeah," Shay nods, "just clumsy." They arrive at the back hatch door where Shay takes out a set of jumper cables.

"Great. I'll go pop my hood." The target darts over to her Honda.

"All right." Shay circles back around to the front end of her Cayenne. She peeks into the backseat window before opening the driver's side door. Shay reaches in to tug the hood release lever. She leaves the door open.

"Okay, it's me first, right?" The target props up the hood of her car and meets Shay in front of the Cayenne.

“Right, the red one.” Shay hands her one end of the jumper cables and lifts her hood. “Will they reach?”

The target holds up the cables. “Yes they will.” She hooks the red clamp onto her battery and sees Shay following in suit. “Thanks again, by the way.” The target attaches the black clamp onto a bolt on the engine block and gushes to Shay. “I really appreciate this.”

“It’s okay. It happens.” With a kind smile, Shay goes around to the driver’s side door of her Cayenne. She leans inside to start the engine.

The target gets into her car while Shay lingers nearby, standing between the two vehicles. The Honda’s driver side window is cracked. Shay steps closer to the car. She slips her hand inside the pocket of her hoodie, waiting for an opportunity.

“I left my lights on.” From inside the car, her voice is muffled.

Shay stoops down to the driver’s side window and knocks on it. “What’d you say?”

The target rolls down her window and repeats herself. “I left my lights on.”

“Oh...well, try it out.” Shay suggests and browses the parking lot. She doesn’t see anybody else around. The parking lot lights still haven’t come on. Beside her, the Honda’s engine starts, and the target sighs in relief.

Shay takes her hand out of her pocket. She’s holding a folded white cloth. She reaches inside the window and covers the target’s mouth with the cloth. A muted scream fills her palm as Shay uses her free hand to block the target’s flailing arms. Shay manages to grab the target’s right wrist while pressing the cloth into her face. She looks down at the frantic brown eyes staring up at her.

Stomping her feet on the floor mat, the target tries to push Shay’s hand off her mouth, but the anesthetic effects take hold of her. Weaker by the second, she can only manage to cling onto Shay’s forearm, and even that is short lived. Her turbulence subsides.

Shay repositions her fingers on the target’s right wrist to track her pulse. The target’s left arm droops down into her lap. Her eyelids flutter shut. Shay leaves the cloth over her mouth a couple seconds longer for good measure. She kicks out her leg and thumps the rear door of the Cayenne a couple times with her boot.

Diligent, Shay opens the car door and shoves the white cloth back into her pocket. The target’s body is slumped over towards her center console. Shay locates the seat adjustment controls and wiggles the toe of her boot under the lever. The seat begins to recline.

Trip gets out of the backseat of the Cayenne. Following the game plan, he walks around to the rear passenger side of the Honda and climbs into the

backseat. He pushes the front passenger seat forward to open up some room. The driver's seat, holding the target's limp body, reaches its fully reclined position. Shay pulls her foot out of the car and shuts the driver's side door. She heads off to remove the jumper cables and stow them back away in her Cayenne.

From the backseat, Trip slips his hands under the unconscious target's arms. With a grunt, he drags the upper half of her body over the headrest. Her wilted arm slides down the side of the driver's seat. Trip shifts forward, bracing himself on the backside of the passenger seat. He ducks down to grab the backs of the target's knees, tugs up on her legs and rolls her body into the backseat. She lands on her side with her knees bent.

Shay closes the hood and gets in behind the wheel of the Honda. She feels around for the adjustment lever and raises the seat back up. In back, Trip takes a moment to catch his breath and survey the unconscious blonde. She's his age, mid-twenties.

Shay reaches over the center console to push the passenger seat upright. "Make it look like she's taking a nap." She glances at Trip in the rearview mirror.

"It already looks like she's taking a nap." He chuckles. Trip arranges her arms more naturally, bending her elbows in front of her chest.

"You know what I mean." Shay smiles at him. "Make it look like she's passed out, in case I get pulled over or anything."

"I think this is as good as I can do." Trip gets out of the Honda.

"All right, I'll see you later." Shay waits for him to close the door and head over to her idling Cayenne. She backs out of the stall and drives out of the parking lot. On her way, she passes by the office complex. There's a lit window on the ground floor.

***

Inside that lit office on the ground floor, on matching cream-colored couches, Becky Martin sits across from a middle-aged, homely therapist. Thriving plants fill the windowsills. Onyx rugs cover the polished oak floor. The balance of contemporary décor rooted by earthy elements creates a comfortable office setting.

"It's nice meeting you, too." Becky tucks a strand of golden blonde hair behind her ear with a French-manicured nail. She acts completely impartial about her therapy session.

"So Becky, tell me why you're here today." The therapist has a notepad resting on the arm of her couch and a shiny silver pen in her hand.

“My mother was in town for a short visit last week and thought I seemed,” she finishes her sentence with a trivializing shrug, “disconnected, was how she put it.”

“But you don’t agree?”

“Nobody except for my mother would look at my life and think, ‘yeah, that girl needs therapy’.”

“Why do you say that?”

“Well because, I have a steady job and I live in a decent place. Which isn’t always easy to do in L.A.” She contends. “I don’t have a criminal record or any addictions, nothing like that. I’m not depressed.”

“What are you?”

“If anything, I’m bored.”

The therapist nods, touching the tip of her pen to the notepad. “What did your mother notice that made her think you needed to talk to somebody?”

“It’s really nothing new.” Her focus drifts over to the woodgrain essential oil diffuser dispersing a lavender mist on the other side of the room. “It’s the fact that she still sees me the same way she did a decade ago, when I went off to college. And I’m not the same person anymore.”

“Was there something more specific, for her to ask you to come here?”

“My general attitude towards life, I guess. My boyfriend, Brian, is a complete jackass. Just to give you the most recent example, he was supposed to come over for dinner last night, right? Dinner was made, candles were lit, and what does he do?”

“What?”

“He gets too drunk to drive over, which I don’t find out about until I call to ask him why he’s late.” Becky frowns as she goes on. “He’s a shallow, self-centered drunk with Peter Pan syndrome and it’s really just a matter of time, to be honest.”

“What keeps you in the relationship with Brian?”

“That’s a good question. As bad as it sounds, I’m probably waiting to move on, when I have someone to move on to.” Her gaze travels to the plants in the windowsill. “You really don’t have to tell me how insecure and wrong that is. I already know. It makes me sound as shallow as him.”

“We can revisit that relationship later. Tell me what else is going on.”

“Okay, I’m twenty-nine, so naturally I’m at that stage where everyone I know is either getting married or having babies. That can be annoying.”

“Annoying how?” the therapist asks while making a note.

“Like my co-worker Jackie inviting me over for ‘sangria and centerpieces’ because half of her bridesmaids are totally unreliable. Don’t get me wrong, I

love Jackie, but I'm not one of her bridesmaids."

"So did you go?"

"It's happening right now, so no, I don't plan to. Actually, I'm glad you had an appointment open up so that I could come take care of this tonight."

"So, I understand you're frustrated with several of your relationships right now, but was there a specific catalyst that alarmed your mother last week?"

"It was the dream. I don't even know why I told her about it." Shaking her head, Becky reaches for the coffee table between them. "Won't make that mistake again." She picks up her open bottle of water and has a sip.

"The dream?"

"I've been having this bizarre, recurring dream. It makes absolutely no sense to me, but it's very vivid."

"Can you tell me about it?"

Becky sets the water back down on the coffee table and warns her. "It's weird."

"I understand."

Becky takes a deep breath, lifting her brows. She unfurls in a relaxed manner. "I wake up in this cellar..."

Thick metal shackles are bolted to the curved brick wall, down in the bowels of the circular underground cellar. Becky is stripped down to her underwear, cuffed to the wall. It's so dim down there that only her silhouette and movements are fully visible. She thrashes her arms around, fruitless. Grunts of anger spill out of her mouth as she attempts to break the chains.

There's a stone staircase directly across from her. It leads up to a candlelit balcony level, once used for seating at wine tastings. Between clashes of metal against brick, Becky hears something. She stops moving, her breath is a pant.

Up above on the balcony, two indistinguishable men appear. They stand at the wrought iron railing.

Becky looks up at them. "This is enough! You stop this, right now!" She grabs the chains and throws them against the brick wall behind her. Her voice is hoarse from screaming. "You're on my territory. This is MY kingdom!" As the echo of her voice dies down, Becky hears the distinct sound of a fly being unzipped. Her eyes widen in horror. "Oh, no you don't. Don't you dare!" she screams out. The reverberations of her cry grow weak...

"I know. It's weird." Becky holds her hands up to the therapist.

"Dreams often are." She jots down notes. "Do you know who these two men are?"

"No, that's the thing. I never see their faces. Dreams are funny like that. Sometimes you know that you're dreaming about a certain person, but it doesn't

look like that person, you know?”

“Yeah.” She nods at Becky.

“Well, not only are their faces a blur, but I have no idea who they’re supposed to be. But in the dream, I definitely know who they are.”

“Not all dreams involve people you know, even though they do come from the subconscious.”

“Right.” Becky uncrosses and re-crosses her legs in an antsy gesture but maintains her unruffled façade. “So what do you think?”

“It sounds a bit to me like your subconscious is struggling with a loss of control. Like, you’re fighting to hang on amid the internal battles you’re dealing with.”

Becky teeters her head in consideration of the therapist’s observation.

***

Shay drives the Honda down a seemingly deserted road. When she comes up onto a slight hill, a cluster of trees appears on her left. She digs her phone out of the pocket of her hoodie and makes a call. “Hey, I’m pulling in.” She ends the brief call and immediately makes another one. Shay’s inflection on the second call is notably more commanding. “I’m almost there. Get ready to take the car. I’ll leave the key in there. You have the address, correct?” Satisfied, Shay ends the second call and slips her phone back into her pocket.

She turns into the long driveway leading up to the palatial Mercer Estate. Shay follows the curve around to the side of the house, which is illuminated by landscape ground lighting.

Two men walk out of the side entrance door, Reno and Random. They’re both of average height and athletic build, both attractive, but Reno has a particular appeal. Random is carrying a lightweight stretcher under his arm. He is the picture of composure; he’s calm, assuming and in complete control.

Shay reels back in her seat, blown away at the sight of Random outside to fetch the target. She pulls the car up next to them and shuts off the engine. When Shay gets out of the car, Reno and Random approach the passenger side.

Reno glimpses overtop the car at Shay while she pushes the door shut. “Where are we taking her?” he asks and peers down into the window at the blonde target’s body in the backseat. “Is this number seven?” He opens the rear door.

“Yup, number seven.” Shay’s normal gregarious demeanor emerges. She walks around the car towards them, still astonished to see Random doing grunt work. “Wow, I got you two to unload?”

Random sets the stretcher on the ground.

“And to stage.” Reno informs her. Random stands across from Reno in front of the open car door.

“How generous of you,” Shay says specifically to the head honcho, Random. She leans against the side of the car and watches them.

They each take a leg and begin pulling the unconscious body out of the car.

“How’d you drain the car battery in the first place?” Reno asks her. They get the bottom half of the target’s body slid out far enough, and then both reach inside to grab one of her arms.

“Oh, we didn’t.” Shay explains. Hanging by her arms and legs, the blonde is carefully lowered down onto the stretcher. “He stopped there himself after lunch and turned on her headlights and interiors. He has a key, obviously.”

“That makes sense.” Reno nods. He and Random grip the handles on either end of the stretcher. They pick it up and start carrying it towards the house with Reno leading the way. Shay pushes herself off the car and hustles ahead of them to get the door. She opens the side entrance door for them. They pass by her, going down a set of concrete steps. Reno and Random move steadily down the staircase with the stretcher.

Random glances up over his shoulder at Shay in the doorway. “I trust there were no problems.”

“Of course not.” Shay steps inside and pulls the heavy door shut behind her. She follows them down the stairs. The unadorned basement corridor has numbered doors on both sides. “Her suitor is supposed to be here in about a half hour if someone can babysit.”

“I can do that.” Reno offers. When they reach the bottom of the steps, he keeps backing up until Random has enough room to turn the stretcher down the quiet corridor.

Shay jogs ahead to a metal door that has the number 7 on it. “And Trip’s at her apartment waiting for her car to be dropped off.” She turns the handle and opens it for them. Random and Reno rotate the stretcher in front of the door and head inside.

“Are you going, or are you sending someone?” Random asks as he passes by Shay. He walks through the doorway.

“Hell no, I’m not going. My job here is all but done.”

Chamber 7 is small and simple with eroded cinderblock walls and cement floors. Two thick chains dangle from a large eyehook bolted into the wall. Candle sconces cast a faint glow around the dank little dungeon. There’s a purple velvet chair in the corner.

Next to the purple chair is a rolling cart that holds an arranged row of items: a coil of rope, a flogger, a ball gag, a paddle and a handful of clothespins. A wooden stock sits in the middle of the chamber. The handmade detention unit is a hinged stock, to trap the neck and wrists, which connects to a sturdy pillory frame with a horizontal kneeling board.

Shay walks inside just when Reno and Random are setting down the stretcher. She spots the ominous wood device. “Perfect, you remembered the stock.”

“Did you think I’d forget?” Reno has an offended crinkle in the corner of his eyes. “That’s the equivalent of me asking if you remembered to get the contract signed.”

“Fair enough.” Shay notices his sexy sneer.

Random stays out of their banter. Crouched over the target’s body, he and Reno begin removing her clothes. Reno takes off her sandals while Random unbuttons her thin cardigan sweater.

Shay stands near the doorway. “What’s on the menu tonight?” She pats her stomach through her hoodie. “I’m starving.”

“It smelled like Mexican fare.” Reno tosses the sandals aside and starts a clothing pile. He moves up her body to the waistband of her linen pants.

“That works for me.” Shay watches Random open the front of the thin cardigan. “I’m sure you know what to do from here.”

“All under control.” Random bends the target’s elbow. He pulls her arm out of the sleeve of the cardigan. Across from him, Reno is unbuttoning her linen pants.

“I’ll be upstairs, then.” Shay exits the chamber. She sets off down the basement hallway, breezing by the numbered metal doors, 5...3...1. She passes by the staircase that leads up to the side entrance door and continues into an eerily dim, open area where she approaches an elevator. Her phone rings. She pulls it out of her pocket and answers the call. “Why hello. Yes, she’s almost ready for you.” Shay punches the ‘up’ button on the elevator. “Okay then, enjoy your evening.” She smiles. “Oh, I’m sure you will, too.”

The elevator doors open.

***

“Do you think you need to start seeing me on a regular basis? Or anyone for that matter?” the therapist asks Becky, who shakes her head. Their session is wrapping up, signaled by the timer on the essential oil diffuser across the room turning the unit off.

“No, not to be rude, but I don’t. I just don’t think therapy is what I need.”

“What do you think you need?”

Becky hesitates before answering, “An alternative. I don’t want to just do what everybody else is doing.”

“Do you know what sort of alternative?” She touches the tip of her shiny silver pen to her notepad.

“Not yet, but I’ve got my eyes open.”

Becky’s obscure comeback prompts a more direct final question from the therapist. “So, what are you doing currently to cope with your feelings about where you’re at in life?”

***

White wine flows from the bottle into an empty glass. At her townhouse, standing in her galley kitchen, Becky sets down the bottle and picks up the wineglass. She snatches a torch lighter off the end of the quartz counter and walks into her dark living room.

A laptop computer screen casts its subtle light across a neatly kept desk. Becky uses the torch lighter to light a couple of pillar candles on her computer desk. Her laptop chimes with an incoming message. She smiles and says to herself, “I knew it.” Becky settles into her desk chair and opens the chat message from a user named Stillborn. She slides her glass of wine onto the desk and reads the message.

Stillborn: Have you rethought the cam request?

Becky, who’s signed onto the screenname HelloKitty69, types her reply.

HelloKitty69: still thinkin bout it, k?

She clicks ‘send’ and tenses up. Almost in a panic, Becky begins typing a new message.

HelloKitty69: But plz dont go. Havent heard from u lately n rly wanna talk to u.

Becky picks up the glass of wine and rocks back in her desk chair, riveted on the screen. The computer chimes. She reaches forward to hit the ‘mute’ button on her keyboard.

Stillborn: Ok. This time. My patience is running thin.

“Good.” She takes a small sip of wine and sets the glass back down. Hands on her keyboard, Becky starts typing.

HelloKitty69: I know and I promise soon.

Stillborn: What do you want to talk about? And type in real words so I don’t feel like I’m talking to a teenager.

HelloKitty69: Deal. Last week, my mom asked me to make a therapy appt, right? Because that's where honesty gets you, sent to therapy.

Stillborn: Only in your world

Becky huffs before she continues typing.

HelloKitty69: So the appt was tonight and it went fine cos I followed ur advice

Stillborn: TYPE IN REAL WORDS. THIS IS WHY I'M ASKING FOR THE CAM.

HelloKitty69: Sorry. So the point is, I never got mad. Mom was just worried, now it's done. I didn't attach any emotion to the event.

Stillborn: Oh, so you're finally reading the lame articles I've been sending you.

For the past two months, ever since Becky signed up on this adult site and started talking to this Stillborn character, he's been sending her the occasional introspective article.

HelloKitty69: I've been reading them at work. I never said they were lame.

Stillborn: You definitely did.

Becky smiles. She tucks a strand of hair behind her ear and resumes typing.

HelloKitty69: Maybe the first time. I was probably a little drunk. Anyway, I didn't just read them. I understood them and even applied them.

Stillborn: And they worked. It's just about changing the way you think.

HelloKitty69: Yeah, something about you makes sense finally.

"For once." Becky sips her wine, and the computer screen flashes. She locks in on the incoming message on her monitor.

Stillborn: I guess it's time to change tactics then, before you figure me out.

HelloKitty69: That's it? That's all you have to say?

Stillborn: You expect praise for taking good advice?

The doorbell rings. Becky gasps in surprise. She minimizes the chat window on her computer screen and sees the time. It's 11:20. When Becky stands up from her desk chair, the doorbell rings again. She spins around and rushes over to the window. It's Brian. He's out on the front porch making a funny face at her through the glass. Becky rolls her eyes and opens the door.

A clean-cut guy with a charming grin, Brian walks into the shadowy living room and closes the door behind him. "Why's it so dark in here?"

"What are you doing here?"

"Rob dropped me off." Brian points over his shoulder at the door.

"Okay, but why?"

"Cause I wanted to see you." He wraps his arms around Becky's waist, looking past her at the computer screen. He's drunk and giddy, but still coherent.

“What, are you busy or something?”

“No, but it’s almost eleven-thirty, and we have to work tomorrow.” Becky catches a whiff of the alcohol on his breath. “And you are trashed.” She wiggles out of Brian’s hold and backs away from him.

“So what?” He can see the wineglass on her desk. “Like you’re not?”

“I’m not, actually.” She glances over at her monitor. A new message notification flashes in the lower corner of her screen. “But it’s still late.”

“So we’ll go to sleep together. What’s wrong with that?”

“Listen Brian, at least go brush your teeth. Feel free to take a shower too, but the teeth are mandatory.”

“You’re selfish today.”

“*I’m* self...” Becky cocks her head while Brian stumbles along into the bathroom. She hurries back over to her computer, clicks on the new message and types a reply.

HelloKitty69: My idiot boyfriend just staggered in. Sorry.

She deliberates for a moment before clicking ‘send’. Becky closes out the chat window. She hears Brian gargling in the background. Becky swivels her chair and yells towards the bathroom. “It’s truly amazing that you make it into work every day!”

“I’m amazing.”

With a grumble, Becky leans back in her desk chair and begins rocking.

***

The sound of canned laughter rings out from a TV mounted on the wall above an unlit stone fireplace. The TV is the only light source in Black’s spacious master bedroom, his sanctuary in his suite within the Mercer Estate. A tan wingchair sits in the corner next to the fireplace, near a large window covered with chocolate brown drapes.

On the wall across from the fireplace is a rich four-poster bed with 12”x12” fluted square wood posts. Black is lying on the bed, propped up against the padded headboard. Comfortably dressed, he has dark eyes and a stoic face. He sets his laptop aside on the bed. He’s holding a lit joint between his fingers. A phone and remote control are sitting on the nightstand by his bed. The phone vibrates, so he picks it up and answers the call. “Shay.”

“What are you doing? Are you here?” she asks.

“Yeah, I’m here.”

“So he just left here to take her home. How do you feel about tackling chamber cleanup?”

“Which one?” He takes a hit of the joint.

“Seven, it’ll be super easy.”

“I guess I could do that for you.” Black’s apathetic tone harmonizes with his facial expression.

“I would appreciate it. I’ve done like, eight of these scenarios in the past two weeks.”

“You’ll owe me one.”

“You know I’m good for it.” Shay avows.

“I know.”

“Thank you, Black. I’m calling it a night.”

“Okay.” He ends the call and snuffs his joint out in a white porcelain ashtray that’s sitting on the bed beside him. He moves the ashtray over to the nightstand before rolling off the bed.

Black walks out of his bedroom and turns the corner into a quiet living room area. A floor lamp softly lights the room. The TV screen on the far wall is off. Plush taupe drapes are drawn over the two tall, narrow windows on either side of the screen. A modern, steel grey sectional faces the TV, filling the center of the living room. Black cuts across the dark-stained hardwood floor to the front door of his suite. He slips on a pair of shoes, opens the door and heads out.

He steps into the wide penthouse corridor. With décor-free beige walls and stylish light sconces, it resembles a hotel hallway. Black pulls his door shut behind him. The word ‘Entropy’ is mounted on the outside of his door in routed, gold leaf letters.

“Hey Black!” Trip calls out to him from further down the corridor.

Black pauses and waits for Trip to catch up with him.

“Have you tried out the new strain?”

“I just did.” He nods at Trip. “Literally.” The two of them go on down the hall towards the elevator, centrally located in the long corridor.

“I’m on my way down now. How is it?”

“Well, I let Shay pass off chamber cleanup to me, so...”

“Ah, okay.” Trip smiles. “That’s a good sign.” They arrive at the elevator where Trip bends forward to punch the ‘down’ arrow. He vacates the elevator on the first floor.

When the elevator doors open to the basement level, Black comes out alone. The doors slide closed behind him. He walks through the underground corridor of chambers, passing the numbered metal doors. On his way, he pulls his phone out of his pocket and makes a call.

Black reaches for the knob and opens the door to chamber 7. He steps inside the doorway, holding his phone up to his ear. “Grab a couple people for a

cleanup in number seven." Black visually assesses the post-scene situation. The wooden stock is in the middle of the dank chamber. There are no spills, no trash to collect, and the play items on the rolling cart by the purple velvet chair appear to be unused. "It's not bad. Just put the gear away, wipe down the stock, move it back to the arsenal and mop the floor." Black scans the chamber. "Yeah, that's it." He glances over at the purple chair. "Oh, and check the chair cushion, just in case."

***

The next morning, Brian is at his desk, working on his laptop. Though it's a modest-sized office, he does have a window behind him that overlooks the WPC courtyard area down below. Brian's co-worker and friend walks into his office and sits down in a chair across the desk from him.

"Hey." Rob is an easygoing, average Joe. "How was your night?"

Brian continues typing as he talks to Rob. "Meh, boring."

"Boring?"

"Becky was being a bitch, like I interrupted something." He blows it off. "I don't know. I just crashed, honestly." Brian stops to pick up his coffee mug and take a sip. He sets the mug back down and resumes typing. He's been doing this job long enough that he can seamlessly type a detailed quote while carrying on a conversation.

"Let's cut early for lunch." Rob suggests.

"Sure, let me just finish this bid." He furrows his brow. "I seriously need to find something different."

"What do you mean?"

"Well, it's like... How long have I been seeing Becky, anyway?"

"Uh, about six months, maybe. Don't you know?"

"That seems right."

"Here we go again." With a knowing groan, Rob leans his head back on the wall behind him.

"No, see, that's just it. I don't want to keep doing the same thing, because I keep winding up bored at the six-month mark."

"I've noticed that pattern. I think everyone around here has."

"I'm almost done with this." Brian scrolls back up to skim through his work. "Anyway, I know that I do not want to keep cycling through co-workers, here."

"Right." Rob sounds jaded.

"No, I'm serious. But I don't know whether to wait it out with Becky while I look for something else, because I'm not really sure what I'm looking for yet."

“So just wait it out. Becky’s not that bad, in my opinion.”

“That’s only because you see ‘happy drunk Becky’.”

“I see Becky every day.” Rob motions down the hallway. “She works right down the hall.” He thumbs out the doorway towards the WPC reception area...

The front reception area is open and tidy, with an oak receptionist desk situated in the center. The WPC logo is mounted on the wall behind the desk. A hallway runs straight down each end of the reception desk. Potted floor plants border the entrances to each hallway.

Brian’s open office door is visible from the reception desk where Becky stands talking to Jackie, who’s wearing a headset and sorting through a stack of mail.

“How’d sangria and centerpieces go?” Becky asks her.

“I’m a little hungover, but we got them done.”

“That’s good news. I’m sorry I couldn’t make it.”

“Oh, it all worked out.” Jackie reassures her with a wave. She’s a young and bubbly Hispanic who, fortunately for Becky, does not hold grudges. Jackie is to Becky what Rob is to Brian, a friend as much as a co-worker. The multi-line phone blinks with an incoming call. Jackie reaches to answer it.

“I’ll catch you at lunch.” Becky pats her hand on the counter and heads for the hallway to her office. When she hears Brian talking, she stops and lurks behind one of the tall potted plants at the end of the hallway.

“I just don’t know if I can do it,” Brian says.

“Do what, exactly?”

“I don’t know if I can wait for the Becky thing to run its course, or not.” Brian and Rob arrive at the end of the hallway. They don’t notice Becky step out from behind the floor plant. “I need to break the cycle.” Brian freezes in mid-step when he sees Becky standing in front of him. Rob’s jaw slacks.

“That makes two of us.” Becky notifies him, projecting her patent resolution.

Though clearly caught off guard, Brian makes no effort to retract his statement.

Becky folds her arms. “If I find anything of yours at my house, I’ll bring it in to work.”

“I’ll do the same.”

“Great. Well, good luck. God knows you need it.” Becky twirls away from Brian and walks off down the hallway to her office.

“That was really rude, man,” Rob says quietly.

“Me or her?”

Rob frowns at him. “You.”

***

Becky and Jackie are sitting at a picnic table eating their lunch in the WPC building's courtyard area. It's a mild and sunny day, typical of May weather in southern California. Jackie is halfway through a sandwich. Becky stabs a fork into a container of pasta salad.

"Have you ever had a dream that's so vivid, you wake up thinking it actually just happened?" she asks Jackie.

"Yeah, but I don't remember any of them now."

"Well, I've been having this dream that I'm being tortured by these two guys." Becky has a bite of her pasta salad. Jackie crinkles her nose.

"What two guys?"

Becky shrugs. "I don't recognize them." She proceeds to tell Jackie about being chained to the brick wall and how the two men come inside and stand above her on the balcony that runs all around the inside of the round cellar.

"Sounds more like a dungeon."

"It is like a dungeon. So anyway, they come in." Becky waves her fork around, animating her story. "And I start yelling at them to stop, and that it's my kingdom."

"Your kingdom?"

"Yeah, I don't know what it means. Then they," Becky trails off, "they do something, and I wake up."

"What do they do?" Jackie picks up her can of soda and takes a drink.

Through a laugh, Becky says, "I'm pretty sure they're gonna start pissing on me, but I don't stick around for that part."

"Oh, sick!" She sets her soda can down on the table with a thud of disgust.

"I know. It's driving me crazy."

"Let's talk about something else, then. What was going on with Brian earlier? I heard you guys talking."

Becky takes a cleansing breath as she prepares to spill the story. "I heard him tell Rob that he didn't think he could, 'wait for the Becky thing to run its course'."

Appalled, Jackie's eyes bulge. "No."

"Yes."

"What? What the– why did you not *open* with this?"

"I haven't exactly been excited to talk about it." Becky sheepishly looks down at her pasta salad. "It wasn't a pleasant thing to hear, you know?"

"I know, but you went on with your nightmare about being pissed on and never thought to mention that you and Brian broke up?"

“It was gonna happen sooner or later. It’s not that big of a surprise.”

“Yes it is. You were supposed to be the one who ended it.”

Becky stiffens at Jackie’s words. “Ouch, I know. I’m not saying that I’m not upset, but still.” She mechanically pokes her fork around inside the container.

“Oh my God.” Jackie whispers in a daze. “I cannot believe he said that.”

“He obviously wasn’t too concerned. He knows I could’ve heard him. If he cared–” Becky stops herself midsentence. “But of course, he doesn’t care.” She stabs her fork into the cold pasta with heightened aggression.

“It never ceases to amaze me how big of an ass he can be.”

“And how people just, put up with it. That’s what amazes me.”

“Uh-huh.” After an awkward silence Jackie asks, “So, are you still meeting up at Tiger’s after work tonight?”

Becky answers with a flat, “No.” She tilts her head. “Are you being serious?”

“Well, we’re your friends, too. I mean, just because Brian’ll be there doesn’t mean you can’t come.”

“It means I don’t want to.” Becky rebuts irritably. She rests her fork down inside the plastic container. “I realize that Brian’s escapades are common knowledge around here, but I’m not gonna just accept it and hang out with everybody like nothing’s wrong.”

Jackie begins collecting her things. “I just don’t see why you have to be the one who avoids social situations.”

“It’s by choice.”

“I guess that’s up to you, then.” She swings her purse over her shoulder. “Hey listen, I have to call my mom on my way back in.”

“Okay.”

Jackie gets up from the table. “And seriously Becky, good riddance.”

Becky nods at Jackie and watches her leave the courtyard area before spying up at Brian’s office window in the WPC building. Since the situation with him has thrown a wrench into Becky’s normal Thursday night plans, she picks up her phone to search for something else to do.

***

A small, spring Arts & Crafts Festival is being held in the downtown area. Food vendors line the street, which is barricaded off from traffic. A savory mix of spices and grill smoke float through the air. Colorful tents are intermixed throughout, most with goods for sale. Paintings, pottery, soaps and jewelry are all available for purchase. Off to the side of the main drag is a bright red fortune teller tent.

Inside that tent, Becky is seated across from a psychic, an older woman whose mousy brown hair is piled up on top of her head. She's dressed in a flowing jade-colored robe. Tapestries line the inside walls of the tent. The mismatched lamps in the corners add a soft mystique.

"I can't help but notice you have a tense aura. Did something happen to you today?"

"It was a stressful day." Becky admits." I broke up with my boyfriend." Tarot cards are arranged on the round, cloth-covered table between them.

"Oh, is that why you're here?"

"No, it really wasn't serious. I'll get over that. I'm here to find out what's going to happen."

"Well, this is present day." With a pearly fingernail, the psychic taps the Four of Cups tarot card. "The Four of Cups generally indicates discontent."

"That's appropriate." Becky centers on the next card in the sequence. "What does The Magician represent, then?"

"This is someone in your life, who you may or may not already know. This person will show you a new direction."

Becky looks up at the psychic, intrigued by her words. "*Really?*"

"Could this be someone you already know?"

"It could be."

"Who do you think this person is?"

"It's kind of a long story." Becky's focus reverts to the cards. "So do I go in the new direction?"

The psychic nods. "Looking ahead, it seems as though you do take this new path."

"Oh great," Becky mutters when she sees the next card in line, The Hanged Man. "And then I'm doomed."

"I don't think that you're doomed, as much as you're changing your perspective from here to here." The psychic taps her fingernail between the Magician and the Hanged Man. The Temperance card is in-between these two. "This jump indicates that your outlook has changed significantly. Once you arrive here to the Hanged Man, you're simply suspended. Where you go from here is too ambiguous right now. This will be a rebirth of some kind, further down the road."

"Can we back up a little? I'm wondering why this jump even happened." Becky points at the Temperance card, sequentially before the Hanged Man. "Because Temperance doesn't seem too bad. That just means I need to like, moderate my behavior, right?"

“It means more than that, Becky.” The psychic hovers her hand over the Temperance card. “It means this is a time when you will try and blend opposites that may not mix. I suspect your efforts will lead to the change in perspective that follows.”

“So while I’m trying to mix oil and water there, I’m going to be punished for my actions here.” Becky refers to the Hanged Man card.

“Punished, stopped, redirected. The synthesis you will try to achieve will not work, because your goal or ambition is not realistic.”

Becky’s forehead wrinkles in a palpable attempt to wrap her mind around the premonition.

***

Later that evening, Becky runs on her treadmill in the bedroom of her townhouse. Her hair is pulled up into a ponytail, and her skin shines with light perspiration. She runs to clear her head, but the perplexed glower on her face depicts that it’s not working.

The bedroom is a decent size. It comfortably fits her queen bed and nightstands, in addition to two dressers and of course the treadmill, which is on the wall across from the door. A TV sits on the shorter dresser across from Becky’s bed. The mini blinds on her windows are drawn closed, blocking out the night sky.

Becky hops onto the side rails of the treadmill and turns it off. She pulls a water bottle out of the front holder and wipes off her face with a small towel before stepping off the machine. Becky walks out of her bedroom into the living room and over to her computer desk. She glances down at the open chat message to Stillborn on her laptop screen.

HelloKitty69: It’s finally over with Brian. Hope to catch you.

There’s no response to her message. She sets her water bottle on her desk, slumps down into her desk chair and sighs in frustration.

“Oh, come on magician. Please have nothing better to do tonight.” She reaches for her keyboard and fires up a card game to distract herself while she waits. The Hello Kitty clock on the wall above Becky’s desk reads 9:40 p.m.

***

Black’s windowless office in his suite at the Mercer Estate is pitch dark except for the glow of his laptop sitting on the desk. He steps inside and looks down at the screen. After a contemplative beat, Black makes a phone call. He stands in

the doorway of his office with his phone to his ear. “Hey, are you busy right now? Then would you mind stopping by so I can get your opinion on something?” He nods. “Yeah, I’ll have a Jameson neat. Thanks.” Black walks out of his office and through the low-lit living room to the front door of his suite. He slips his phone into his pocket and opens up the door. A distant conversation is taking place out in the penthouse corridor. The voices grow faint. A few moments pass by.

Random appears in Black’s doorway. “So you have something to run by me?” He steps inside the suite, carrying a distinct air of prominence along with two glasses of whiskey.

“Yeah.”

***

Still planted in front of her computer, Becky mindlessly plays her card game in the dark living room. Finally, she hears the chime of an incoming message. She minimizes the game and zeroes in on the chat message box on her screen.

Stillborn: Congratulations. You’re through the phase. Go to this link and turn on your cam.

“Really?” She begins typing a response.

HelloKitty69: Don’t you want to know what happened?

Stillborn: Not really. Go to the link.

HelloKitty69: Gimme a minute.

“Oh no.” Becky stands up from the desk chair, rigid and frazzled. She dashes into her bathroom and flips on the light. The mirror reflects her wiped-away makeup and disheveled hair. “So not prepared for this.” She tears off a section of toilet paper and blots her face. It’s no less blotchy than it was before. Becky tosses aside the toilet paper and starts running her fingers through her tousled hair. Painfully dissatisfied, she proceeds to pull her hair back, combing it smooth with her fingers. She picks up a hairband and hears the distant chime of an incoming message. Becky drops the hairband on the bathroom counter. She rushes back into the living room.

The glow from the computer screen illuminates Becky when she sits down at her desk. She reads his most recent message.

Stillborn: I’m through messing around.

“Okay.” Becky scrolls further up in the chat message window and finds the link he sent. She clicks on it. Two windows open on her screen. One displays a live feed of Becky’s face and the other, Black’s. She takes in her first sight of the broody dark-haired man and his compelling energy.

Her image is in color, while Black's is in black and white. But Becky doesn't notice this right away. She fixates on Black's deep, intense brown eyes...quietly studying her. Becky vacillates between nervousness and anticipation.

"Hi." She sinks back in her chair and smiles.

"Turn on your mic."

Becky flinches at the sound of his low, imposing tone. "Oh." She reaches forward to turn her mic on.

"That's a good *kitty*." Black smirks at her.

Laughing self-consciously, she looks up at her Hello Kitty clock on the wall, the artless inspiration for her handle. "I know. It's a dumb name." Becky concedes to him on the screen. She finally notices that his image isn't in color. "How come you're in black and white?"

"That's just my theme. It's a little esoteric."

"Oh," Becky tosses her head back in bemusement, "so you actually do talk like that?"

"Like what?"

"In riddles!"

"Does that surprise you?" he asks with a shrug.

Becky fidgets with the hem of her flannel shorts. The reality of seeing the Magician's face for the first time brings the situation to a new level. "You know," her gaze wafts down in reluctance, "I realize this isn't that big of a deal and all." Becky glances back up at the screen and signals to her image timidly. "But I've never done anything like this before. I honestly don't do this."

"Then why do you have a camera?"

"It's built into my monitor. But I've never really used it, because–"

Black cuts her off. "Because you're not that type of person, right? Discretion and common sense are the main things I like about you Becky, but we're still just online."

"Right." Becky's pang of apprehension recedes. "I know." She acknowledges his point. "And I do appreciate your patience with me." She squints. "I guess." As she talks to him, Becky eases into the moment. "I mean, I know there's no way that all of this is just about getting laid."

Black scoffs at the absurdity of Becky's statement. "If I were just looking to get laid, I would've shelved *you* two months ago. I want to meet you because I can show you something a lot more interesting than what you've been doing." He speaks with natural confidence and a smooth stride. "I also think you know that life has a lot more to offer, don't you?" He questions Becky to break her out of her spacey stare.

She nods at him, concentrating on his attentiveness.

“And you want to see what that is.” He confirms.

Becky marvels at Black’s persuasion. A curious twitch pulls at the corner of her mouth. “I really think I do. Against my better judgment, as it very much is.” She clarifies for him as if it’s necessary. “Because you know that nothing you’ve ever said about your life makes any sense.”

“But something makes you trust me.”

“Something does.” She agrees and sees his mischievous glint. “Or maybe I’m just going through some period of insanity.”

“No, insanity is doing the same thing over again and expecting different results.” He gives his slightly altered version of Einstein’s definition.

“I’ve heard that one before.” She confesses, shying away from the debate.

“So I guess something I’ve said makes sense.”

Becky glimpses up at his calm face. “Something definitely makes me interested, which I’m sure you can tell.”

“Well,” Black says nonchalantly, “you’d always wonder what you missed out on. If you never take the chance.”

“You’re probably right. I just wonder if, whatever this is, might be more than I can juggle into my life.”

“Trust me. I won’t leave any questions unanswered. But some answers will have to come with time.” Black speaks his cryptic words with upmost certainty. “And I’ll roll the dice that the day will come, when you thank me for coming into your life.”

Becky arches her brows at his bold claim. She mulls for a moment before replying. “It’s crazy. I believe you, and I can’t believe half the words coming out of my *own* mouth, lately. But for some reason, I believe you.” She relaxes into a smile.

“It’s the chance for real freedom. I have it, and you want to see what it’s about. So you listen to me, in spite of your conditioned reservations.” He asserts. “Just admit it and agree to meet me.”

“When?”

“Check your email from home at exactly three o’clock tomorrow.”

Becky scrutinizes Black, waiting for him to continue. “That’s it?” She grimaces. “You’re not gonna tell me where we’re going or anything?”

“Kitty, this marks the beginning of the tricks I’m teaching you. So no, I’m not telling you anything except to check your messages tomorrow at three.”

With that, Black disappears from the window on Becky’s monitor...

In his office within his suite at the Mercer Estate, a still shot of Becky’s bewildered face is visible on Black’s laptop screen.

“Why do you bother with her?” Random asks, severely underwhelmed.

“I know she seems like a challenge.” Black turns away from the laptop. He’s in his black leather desk chair. Wall lamps softly light the long, narrow office. “But I’ve got a gut feeling.”

“Really?” Random has been sitting behind Black on a tall barstool, eavesdropping on him and Becky. He reaches for his whiskey on the round pub table beside him. “You’ve been dicking around with her for two months already and just finally talked her into getting on camera.” Random shakes his head. “I’ll put money on it she backs out before you even get her to a party.” He sips his whiskey.

“Not a chance.” Black retorts, thoroughly self-assured. “Mark my words. Becky Martin’s gonna take it all the way.”

“You really think so?” Random’s skepticism is pronounced.

Black motions over his shoulder at Becky’s image on the monitor. “You saw her cave.”

“Yes, but with unyielding resistance, right up to the end when she bitched about not knowing where she’s going tomorrow.”

“That’s the spirit I’m after.” Black bares a surreptitious smile.

“So then...” Random discerningly connects the dots. “You’re not looking for a sub.”

“At first, of course. And I think she’ll do okay at the bottom if I keep promising her more. But once she starts thinking for herself–”

“Aha.” Random interjects, containing his enthusiasm. “That’s when she’ll launch.” He huffs at Black. “Well, that changes everything. I obviously didn’t know your intentions because this one’s a worthless sub recruit.” He scans Becky’s image with newfound appeal.

“Oh, I agree completely. She’s way too aggressive.”

“What’s your plan?” Random asks.

Black reaches for his drink on the desk, which sits against a brick wall in the dimly lit office. Further down the lengthy desk is a pair of additional monitors. “Well, she’s expecting a sex game of some kind.” One of the extra monitors displays a split-screen divided into four sections. Each section shows a black and white feed from each of Black’s subordinate quarters, basic bedrooms. “So I’ll play along with that, initially.”

“Sure.” Random nods in forgone conclusion.

In one of the four sections on the monitor, a pair of blonde twins (Marsa & Minya) watches television in a queen-size bed. Another section shows a younger woman (Kayleigh) wrapped in a towel, combing out her wet hair. In the third one, is the back of a woman’s head (Kaime). She’s seated at a corner desk, picking up a glass of red wine. The fourth section is empty.

“And I’ll start breaking the impatience, immediately.” Black affirms. “She’ll be a quick study.” He takes a small drink of his Jameson, which he’s barely made a dent in.

“What all does she know at this point?” Random’s attention wanders down to the far end of the office. Hanging on the wall is an abstract erotic painting of a woman’s bare torso on the back end of a panther, done on a black velvet canvas.

“Very little, I’ve kept the conversation light,” Black answers.

“Where’d you meet her, again?”

“She signed up on one of the kink sites, claiming she was bored.”

“Hmm.” Random hums pensively. “She’s cagey.” He glances up. Along the ceiling border of the office’s brick walls, a quote is painted in white letters. It reads, ‘The mind of the party is collective and immortal’ with a credit to George Orwell below it.

“But she’s persistent.” Black counters Random’s remark.

“True, and you’ve gotten her this far along. She does want to meet you.”

Black smiles. “Boredom really brings out the best in people.”

Random shrugs in concurrence before asking, “So you’re doing a job tonight, aren’t you?”

“Yeah, leaving for it shortly.”

“I’ll let you get to it.” Random slides off of the barstool and picks up his empty glass. He casually adds, “If you need my help with anything.” He gestures to the image of Becky on Black’s laptop screen. “Just let me know.”

“Okay.” Both surprised and interested, Black follows Random out of the office.

“I wouldn’t mind getting a closer look and interacting with her myself, you know?” Random heads for the front door.

“I might take you up on that sooner than later, actually.” Black steps ahead of him to pull the door open.

“Sure, let me know.”

“I will. Boredom really does bring out the best in people.” Black quips.

Vaguely amused, Random leaves the suite.

Black turns away from the door, leaving it open. The TV is on in his living room, but the volume is down low. Black walks from the front door to his steel grey sectional. His phone rings in his pocket. He pulls it out and answers the call. “Hannah.”

“Are you all set for tonight?” Her bossiness rings through the phone. “Any questions or anything?”

“Well yeah.”

“What?”

“Do you have supplies for me?” Black has a seat on the sectional, facing the TV.

“Reno’s loading you a backpack. He should be there any minute. Other than that, you’re all set?”

“Just waiting to leave. If all goes well, it should be a quick in and out. Twenty minutes tops, plus drive time.” He skims the TV in front of him.

“Right, when there’s no abduction involved, they’re a piece of cake.”

“Usually.” Black ruminates. “I’d feel a lot better if I had a copy of her key, though.”

“I know. Like I said, Joe has the key to her individual apartment, but not for the main door. And you obviously can’t have her buzz you in.”

“I don’t like the alternative of going through the patio door in the first place, especially with no key.”

“At least it’s ground level.” She snaps back with tenacious optimism.

“And locked.” Undoubtedly conflicted about this detail, Black sets his phone on the coffee table in front of him and puts it on speaker.

“I know. Joe said he could not get a key to the patio door.”

“That’s unfortunate.”

“Trust me, I agree. But in a way, it’ll make it more believable.”

“Okay.” Black chortles.

“Anybody in here order a break-in kit?” Reno enters the open doorway into the living room. He’s carrying a black backpack.

“There he is.” Hannah’s voice booms out of Black’s phone.

Reno walks around to the front of the sectional and hands the backpack to Black, who sets it down on the floor between his feet.

“I put all the lock picking stuff in the front pocket.” Reno relaxes into the couch. He lights a cigarette and tosses his pack down on the coffee table.

“Reno, could you reassure Black that patio doors are not that hard to get into.”

“Depends on the door, but it shouldn’t be too bad based on the picture of it Joe sent.” Reno takes a drag of his cigarette. He watches Black unzip the front pouch of the backpack and rifle around inside. “I put all kinds of stuff in there.”

“Yeah, I see that.” Black zips the front pouch closed.

“Nothing to worry about.” Hannah pipes in.

“Goodbye Hannah.” He reaches forward and ends the call.

Behind Black, out in the penthouse corridor, Trip passes by the open door. Upon hearing Black inside, Trip backs up and stands in the doorway. “Hey, I just stopped down and had Ankh roll me one.” He holds up a Dutch style, cone-shaped joint.

“Bring it in.” Black raises his arm, inviting Trip to come inside. “Want something to drink?”

“What do you have in here?”

“I don’t know.” Black directs him to the kitchen. “Have a look.” He does not typically stock his suite’s food and beverages.

“So what are you guys doing?” Trip walks past the sectional into the kitchen.

“Checking out my supplies for a break-in,” Black answers.

“You’re doing a scenario tonight?” he asks and opens the refrigerator.

“I am.” Black leans back down over the backpack. He unzips the top to rummage around inside the main compartment.

“It’s all in there.” Reno ensures him and flicks his cigarette into the white porcelain ashtray on the coffee table.

***

The target’s apartment complex is a three-story brick complex in a middle-class neighborhood. Black is hunched over the handle of a glass patio door. The backpack is slung over his shoulder. He’s wiggling a pick into the keyhole but can’t find the release. He crouches down to get a better angle, tries again, and hears the ‘tick’ he’s waiting for.

Black stands back up and slips the pick into the front pocket of the backpack. He cautiously slides the patio door open, steps inside the apartment and slides the door shut behind him. While walking into the dark living room, he pulls a black ski mask down over his face. Paired with his leather jacket, Black is looking pretty menacing tonight. He creeps into the hallway and notices the TV on inside the bedroom.

He stands outside the bedroom door and listens. Upon hearing the heavy breathing of sleep, he pushes the door open and walks in. The target, Michelle, a brunette in her early thirties, is fast asleep under a down comforter. She’s lying on her side with her back to Black. He takes the backpack off his shoulder and slowly unzips it. He feels around inside and withdraws a roll of duct tape. Black calmly pulls out a strip, tears it off and sticks it to the sleeve of his jacket.

After setting aside the roll of duct tape, Black digs into the backpack for a coiled rope. He finds an end and circles around to the side of the bed, facing Michelle.

She has one arm splayed out on the bed in front of her. The other is tucked under her pillow. Black bends down to slide the end of the rope under Michelle’s available wrist. He carefully pulls the rope through and ties a slipknot.

Assuming that Michelle will wake up when he goes for her other wrist, Black takes the strip of duct tape off of his sleeve. He wraps the tape over Michelle's mouth, which results in her eyes blinking open. Before she has a chance to process the situation, Black reaches under her pillow and grabs her other arm. He loops the rope around her wrist, binding her hands together.

Michelle lets out a stifled squeal. She tries to roll away from him. Black jumps onto the bed and straddles her squirming body, pinning her down. He pauses upon hearing the distinct sound of the patio door opening in the living room.

"Oh shit..."

Michelle stops squealing. Black drops the rope and leaps off of her bed. He pushes the ski mask up over his forehead and backs away from the bed, where Michelle is wrestling her wrists out of the rope.

A stocky forty-something guy in sweatpants storms into the bedroom, holding a gun aimed at Black.

Chapter 2

The guy in sweatpants flips on the bedroom light and points the gun at Black's chest.

Black raises his arms, showing his empty hands in surrender. "This is not what it looks like, I promise you."

"Hmph!" Michelle waves at the guy to stop as she peels the duct tape off of her mouth. "Barry, it's okay. He's getting paid to do this."

Taken aback, Black stares down at her. "Do you know me?"

"Well, no, but I think I know what's going on." Michelle rubs her face where the tape was. "It's not my first time."

Mystified by this chain of events, Barry gradually lowers the gun. "What?" he asks incredulously.

"I'm fine, really." Michelle looks him straight in the eye. "There's no need to involve the cops, or anything like that." She professes to him.

The concern fades from Barry's face. "If you're sure."

"I am."

"That's probably good, it's not like I have a license for this." Barry admits and slips the gun into the waistband of his sweatpants.

"Go on back home. And thanks for watching out for me, and everything. I'm sorry for all this." She sends Barry a warm smile.

"No, I'm just glad everything's okay." Barry turns to leave the bedroom.

After a lull, Michelle peers up at Black. "So do you want to call Joe, or should I?"

"Please." Black extends his open arms to her. "Be my guest. He's just parked down the street."

"Oh, okay." She nods. "Wow, sorry that got so messed up, there." Michelle starts looping the rope up around her hand.

Still distraught, Black bends down to pick up the backpack. He circles back around her bed to the bedroom door. "I'm gonna leave through the front door." He firmly states.

"Sure, sure." Michelle holds out the rope. "Did you want this back, or anything?"

Standing in the doorway, Black glances back at her. "Keep it." He exits the bedroom.

***

Later, Black walks into his bedroom and peels off the leather jacket. He fishes his phone out of the pocket before tossing his jacket down onto the floor. On his way over to his four-poster bed, Black pulls up a contact on his phone, SAM - AMS. He calls her.

Black sits down on the edge of his bed and holds the phone up to his ear. He hears her cranky morning-voice on the other end of the line.

“What?”

In a droll monotone he replies, “Good morning dear.”

“Good morning Black.” She sounds groggy.

“Did I wake you?” he asks...

“Not really.” Sam is sprawled out on an off-white couch in the living room of her Amsterdam flat with her phone to her ear. Morning sun seeps through the closed blinds in a paned window behind the couch. She’s a brunette in her late twenties with engaging eyes and a naturally pretty face. Sam clears her throat. “This is just the first time I’ve talked today.” Her trim figure is hidden beneath a Sherpa throw. She reaches for a cappuccino sitting on the coffee table in front of her. “So what do you want?”

“I had a close call tonight.” Black relays impassively.

“What do you mean by that?”

“I could’ve got shot.”

“What?” Instantly alarmed, Sam sets her cappuccino back down on the coffee table. “What happened?”

“It was a scenario, a break-in gone bad.”

“A break-in gone bad?” She reiterates.

“Yeah, a neighbor saw me break into the patio door of an apartment, and he came over with a gun.”

“Oh my God.” Sam raises her hand up to her cheek with a twinge of distress.

“Right away, I showed him I didn’t have a weapon. Then the target figured out that it was a scenario, and she backed him off.” Black gives her the condensed version.

“You’re kidding me.” Sam thrusts out her hand in disbelief then drops it down into her lap.

“No. Luckily I didn’t have her bound yet.”

“When did this happen?”

“I just got home a little bit ago.”

“How are you doing? I mean, you’re okay, right?” she asks.

“I’m fine.”

“Why were you breaking into a visible location?”

“It’s a long story.”

“I’m not busy.” She settles back into the couch cushion and gets comfortable, but Black doesn’t respond. Sam’s face softens in acute awareness of the fact that he called her for comic banter, a distraction from his night’s events. “I actually think you could’ve dodged that bullet. And it’s not often that I say that literally.”

“That’s true.” He lets out a short laugh. “I missed my chance to personify that phrase.”

“I know. It’s a shame, but there’ll be other turns of phrases.” Sam encourages him. “Just be patient. Another will come.” She picks at the tufts of her Sherpa throw.

“I’m sure you’re right.”

“When am I *not*?” She wards off the smile tugging at the corners of her mouth.

“The third Tuesday of every other month.”

Sam clutches the throw as she gasps theatrically. “How did you find out?” she asks in an exaggerated whisper.

“How do you think?”

“But, I killed that birdie.”

“Bird murder? You’re a disturbing one, Sam.”

“I know. And I don’t even do scenarios these days.”

“Boring.”

“Boring? Try torture.” Sam blasts out a reminiscent sigh. “I can remember the last time I held someone at knifepoint like it was yesterday.” Inhaling through flared nostrils, she adds, “Memories.”

“I don’t know how you get by.” Black’s droll monotone from the beginning of the phone call resurfaces.

“It’s a dull existence. I hope my misery makes you feel better in some small way.”

“It does, thank you.”

Sam sits up and reaches for her cappuccino. “On a serious note, I will want to hear about this someday. I’m sure you know that.”

“You will. Do me a favor, though. Don’t go out of your way to mention this to Random or anybody.”

“Random doesn’t know?”

“Nobody knows. I just got home.” He reminds her.

“Okay, well, I’m glad you’re alive!” She sips her cappuccino.

“Thanks, me too. Enjoy your day.”

“Good night Black.”

***

Friday morning, an exuberant Becky steps out of her office at WPC into the hallway. In a lighthearted gait, she turns the corner towards reception and spots Brian up ahead. She looks right at him with indifference. Becky continues into the front reception area, past Jackie behind the desk and breezes by Brian.

She stops at an office door that's just around the corner from the reception desk. The lettering on the door reads, 'Gary Baxter, Operations Manager'. Becky stands in the doorway, catching the attention of her boss.

Seated at his desk, Gary sets down the handful of papers he's holding. "Good morning Becky."

"Good morning. Hey, I need to leave a couple hours early this afternoon for a dentist appointment."

"Okay."

"I'm sorry it's so last minute, but they had a cancellation and called me this morning."

"Yes, that's fine Becky. You have plenty of PTO."

"Thanks." She backs out of his doorway and returns to her office. On the way, she passes back by the reception desk and smiles at Jackie, who waves at her to hold on. Jackie transfers a call and inspects Becky.

"You're in a good mood today."

"I am." She chirps. "I think unloading the Brian burden was exactly what I needed." Becky rests her elbows on the counter.

"If it helps any, everybody was ripping him bad at the bar last night. About what he said to you, you know?"

"Yes, I remember what he said." Becky succinctly informs her.

"Everybody was giving him a hard time." Jackie repeats in a show of camaraderie towards her friend.

"I'm sure he took it all in stride." She replies with airy supposition.

The multi-line phone in front of Jackie blinks with an incoming call. "See you at lunch?" she asks Becky.

"Actually, I can't today. I have to leave early, so I'm working through lunch." Even with ample PTO, Becky's still new in her department and behind on her workload.

"Oh, well if I don't see you before you leave, have a good weekend." Jackie answers the blinking phone.

"You too." Becky slides her arms off of the counter and drops Jackie a parting smile. She goes down the hallway and passes by Brian's office on the way to her own.

He's in there, standing over a file cabinet. He catches a glimpse of Becky when she walks past. Brian shoves a manila folder into the file, pushes the

drawer closed and sits down at his desk. He dials Rob's extension.

"I guess you lost that bet." Rob rags him on the other line. "Becky definitely didn't call in sick today."

"I saw that. Are we still on for tonight, because I have an idea." Brian reaches for his coffee mug on the desk.

"Sure, when do you want me to pick you up?"

***

Black is submerged in the Mercer Estate hot tub with Cade, whose arms are leisurely stretched out along the edge of the tub. Cade is a bit shorter and thicker than Black. Aside from them both being in their mid-thirties, they have little in common. That however, has never been a problem over the years. Cade's a relaxed and affable guy with an intelligence level high enough to get along with Black.

The jets hum in the sunken outdoor hot tub, which is partially shaded by tall shrubbery. A full glass of fresh-squeezed orange juice sits behind the empty spot in the tub to Black's right.

"I'm surprised Hannah's not here yet." Black is reading a news article on his phone.

"Here she comes." Cade moons at the sight of Hannah Sedgwick, a stunning blonde with piercing blue eyes and bronze skin, approaching them.

She has a thick white towel wrapped around her body. Her pretty face is twisted in a discouraged scowl.

"What's the matter with you?" Cade asks her.

Black briefly glances up from his phone at Hannah.

"I'm frustrated," she answers.

"Hey, me too. Get in."

"Why are you frustrated?"

"Ladies first." Cade offers.

"Well, isn't it obvious?" Hannah removes her towel and drops it down on the limestone decking around the edge of the tub. She has her phone in one hand and a banana in her other. There's a comfortable vibe between the three of them, convening in the hot tub for their daily late morning ritual. Cade looks on with admiration at how Hannah fills out her white string bikini.

Black, on the other hand, remains indifferent. He keeps reading the article on his screen. "If it's not happening in his suite, it's not obvious to him," he tells Hannah.

“Hey, I know what she’s talking about.” Cade insists to Black. “You mean because your new guy bolted. Right?”

Hannah nods at him while she steps down into the hot tub.

“It’s not the first time.” Cade adds.

“I know. That’s why I’m frustrated.”

“You’re picking the wrong types.”

“How would you know?” Hannah gets situated in the tub and sets her phone down on her towel, which is next to the glass of orange juice. “You’ve never had this problem, Cade.”

“So maybe I’m doing something right.”

“It’s irrelevant. It’s just one more thing on my to-do list, now.” She begins peeling her banana. “Anyway, what’s your problem?” Her eyes flit over to Cade.

“I’m trying to plan out an abduction scenario for myself. It’s a lot different doing it for yourself, you know?”

“No,” Hannah says plainly. She takes a bite of the banana.

“It could be if you’ve never done it before.” Black explains to her. His dismissive connotation sets Cade off.

“I wouldn’t go bragging.” He prods at Black, who’s still immersed in his phone. “What have you done, ‘one’ personal one?”

“We’re not talking about me.”

“But still, you have to admit, a personal recruit is a lot different from a paid scenario.”

“Not really.” Black shrugs. “A potential sub is gonna react the same way as a target does. You’re dealing with the same unsuspecting mentality, either way.”

Hannah swallows her bite of banana. “Right, a scene is a scene. You just want to make sure it’s good.”

“Good doesn’t cut it. It has to be perfect.” Cade illustrates for her.

“Why?” she asks. “Who are you talking about, anyway?”

Black laughs softly; he’s already aware of who Cade’s target is.

Cade drums his fingers on the edge of the hot tub. “I’m interested in somebody, but it’s a tricky one. And since I’ve never done this for myself, I’m nervous.”

“Wait, back up.” Hannah crunches her nose. “Like, tricky how?”

“For instance, I can’t just sedate her.” He relays pragmatically. Even with obtaining her medical records, that option needs to be omitted from the contracted invitation.

“Okay, physical restraint, so?” Her question hangs on a prosaic note.

“So it’s gonna be more complex.”

Hannah flashes him a brisk sneer. “Your problem sounds easy. No offense.”

“We have the same problem. We’re both in pursuit.”

“Except you know who your target is. I don’t. Different problems.” She holds her banana up to her full lips, glides it in between them and sinks her teeth into the flesh.

Relishing the vision, Cade says, “I love watching you eat your morning banana.”

Hannah frowns and splashes water at him. “Just shut up.”

Without looking up, Black lifts his free hand to shield his phone from the splashing water. “How could anyone find you hard to live with?”

“I don’t even want to hear it from you.” Hannah shoots Black a warning glare.

“Well, I don’t want to hear it from *you*.” He fires back. “Shay’s on her way down here, by the way.” Black finishes up with his phone and shuts off the screen. To his left, Cade is fetching his towel to dry the splash of water off his face.

“Shay? What for?” Hannah picks up her glass of orange juice.

“I want to fill her in on last night.” Black sets his phone down on top of his towel behind him.

“How’d everything go?” She curiously probes Black.

“Did you have a job last night or something?” Cade asks him.

“Yeah, quick in and out, we thought.” Black directs his vexed remark at Hannah. “I told you I didn’t want to go through the damn patio door.”

Hannah grows solemn. She swallows a bite of banana and flings the peel over her shoulder.

Behind Black, Shay approaches the sunken hot tub at a quick pace. “Hi guys. Don’t mean to crash your morning ritual, but Black said he had a story.”

“Have a seat, Shay.” Black welcomes her.

“It’s not crashing when you’re invited.” Cade tosses his towel back behind him. Shay walks around to the opposite end of the tub, across from Black, in an unoccupied spot. She sits down cross-legged facing him.

Black proceeds to set the scene for Shay and Cade, detailing the plan to enter the target’s apartment through a patio door that faces an open courtyard area, in what is evidently a tightknit complex. As he recaps, Hannah dips down further and further into the warm water. By the time Black gets to the part about the hero neighbor showing up with a gun, Hannah’s eyes are closed, and the surface of the rippling water is touching her bottom lip.

Shay covers her mouth, eyes popped open. “Oh. My. God.” She clinches her hands together in her lap.

“I’m usually the one who’s pulling a weapon, you know?”

“Yeah,” Cade says to Black with a short chuckle. “So what happened then?”

“Unbelievably, the target figured out that it was a scene and called the guy off of me.”

“The target saved your ass?” Cade bobs his head in amazement. “That’s incredible.”

“I know.”

A puzzled pout comes over Shay’s face. “How on earth were you supposed to get her out of the apartment, then?”

“I wasn’t. I was just supposed to tie her up and ransack the place, to make her think I was ripping her off. Then he was gonna switch places with me and, you know.”

“Oh, I see.” Shay pieces it together. “You were just doing an offsite stage, essentially.”

“That’s exactly what it was.”

“Who was this for?” she asks him.

“Good ‘ol Joe,” Black answers with an impish smile.

“Joe Parrish.” Shay aims her finger at him. “No wonder it didn’t route through me.”

“Yup, Joe’s one of Hannah’s fans.” Cade chimes in.

“Speaking of Hannah.” Black’s focus shifts to Hannah, who acts inconspicuous, dunked down in the bubbling water. “You’re uncharacteristically quiet over there.”

Disconcerted by his story, Hannah shakes her head. “Yeah, I-I mean, thank God it was Joe, and she figured out it was a scenario and all.” Her rationalization is riddled with guilt.

“I’ve heard of somebody getting the cops called on them,” Cade reflects, “but that’s it.”

Hannah gropes around for her towel on the limestone decking behind her.

“I told you, three times, I did not want to go through that patio door.” Black reminds her, and she pulls her towel across her face to hide her mortification.

“Stop!” The towel muffles Hannah’s angst. She raises it up over her hairline.

“Forget the key, just pick the lock. Made it more ‘believable’, isn’t that what you said?” Black asks Hannah, whose groan is absorbed by the thick towel. He continues prodding at her. “In fact, it was so incredibly realistic that a neighbor showed up to attack me. So, good thing I didn’t get shot for the sake of realism or anything, right Hannah?” Chagrined, he caps it off with, “*At least it all worked out*.”

Hannah removes the towel from her face and composes herself. “In my defense, IF there is any room for that...” she hesitates, glancing around, “I may

have taken some liberty with this one considering it was Michelle. I knew that you could've told her you were a friend of Joe's in case of any emergency."

Shay sticks her arms out at Black and criticizes Hannah. "But what if he didn't have the luxury of time to explain? What if the guy would've just attacked him immediately?"

"I know!" Hannah holds her palms up in defense. "Trust me, I realize I should've just told Joe we couldn't do it without a key. Poorly planned. That one's all on me, there." She drops her hands back into the water.

"To wrap this up, Hannah. Next time something doesn't feel right, I'm just telling you 'no'. And that's it." Black states.

"I don't blame you one bit. I would too. And I clearly owe you one."

"Owe me one?" He scoffs at her. "You should be my bitch."

Hannah motions back and forth between Black and Shay. She asks them, "Can we maybe try not to mention this one to Random, by chance?"

***

Random's suite, like everyone else's, is located on the second floor, penthouse level of the Mercer Estate. Across from the doorway of his private office within the suite, an executive desk with square recessed corners sits in front of a large picture window. Late morning sun casts a shadow onto the bookshelf, which is on the wall to the right of his office door. The shelves are filled with Random's repertoire of books.

To the left of the door, an oversized custom couch with a tall, padded back is against the wall straight across from the bookshelf. Sitting in the middle of that couch, Random is engrossed in Ernest Hemingway's *A Moveable Feast*. His phone is beside him on the couch cushion. Random turns the page in his book.

His phone begins to ring. He looks down at the image on his screen: a picture of Sam, in a specific pose from a painting at Cat Lady's place in *A Clockwork Orange*. Wearing knee-high purple boots, Sam is on her knees with her calves crossed. Her right hand is resting on her left ankle. Her left hand is reaching for her rear end. She's looking back at the camera. Unlike the painting, Sam is unexposed, dressed in a white tank and shorts.

Random smiles, setting the book aside to answer his phone. "Hi Sam."

"Hi, how are you?"

"I'm good, you?"

"Are you busy?" Sam's voice on the other line is warm but steadfast.

"No, what's going on?"

"I wanted to tell you first. It's official."

A gleam of anticipation flares in Random's eyes. "You're coming back. When?"

"It'll be a little while, yet. I have a few things to tie up."

"No, yeah, I understand." He stands up from the couch and begins pacing around his office.

"But like I said, I wanted you to be the first one to know."

"I appreciate that. I'm sure Rayne is up at the top of that list, too." Random passes by the bookshelf, walking to his desk.

"She is, but I don't want to start spreading the news until I have a better idea of my ETA."

"What are you projecting?" He takes a seat at his desk and opens his laptop.

"I'm thinking a month, mid-June."

Random contains himself outwardly. "Okay, that gives me some idea, then."

"Idea for what?"

"Of when to expect you. Your homecoming, it's been a work in progress."

"Is that so?"

"It is," he says wholeheartedly.

***

In her office at WPC, Becky is seated at her desk. She blinks at her monitor, struggling to concentrate on work. Distracted by her phone lying out on the desk, she needlessly picks it up to check the time and then reverts back to her monitor. Becky refrains from opening her messages for as long as possible.

She has an interior office, so no windows. It's pretty plain, beige walls and grey Berber carpet. There's a framed inspirational poster on the wall behind her that reads, 'If you've already reached your goals, you didn't aim high enough'.

A mere two weeks ago, she was trudging along like she was half dead. Now today, she can hardly cork her adrenaline. Becky leans back in her chair and relents to picking up her phone. She delves into her inbox. A Thursday evening email from Stillborn is at the top of the list. Becky opens it. She reads the short message telling her to check out a link called, Nihilist's Paradigm.

With a snort of humor, Becky opens the link. It takes her to an article titled, *Therapy: A Business? A Pathetic Fallacy? Both?*

Becky's work phone rings. She sets her own phone down and picks up the receiver. "Becky Martin," she answers.

"Hi honey." It's her mother.

"Hi mom." Noticeably confused, Becky asks, "You're calling me at work?"

"Well, we're getting ready to leave town in a little bit."

She slouches down in her chair with a jaw drop of dread. It does not convey in her cheery response. “Oh? Where to?”

“We’re going to visit your aunt and uncle in Houston. Uncle Gene just got out of the hospital last night.”

“Right,” Becky murmurs in recollection, “I remember you telling me that.” Her wince of paranoia diminishes. She curls a finger through the handle of the coffee mug on her desk.

“I wanted to get in touch with you before we leave. I got your email about the therapy appointment. How’d that go?”

“Like I told you in the email, it went fine. I got some things talked out, so it was productive.”

“Did you make another appointment?”

“No.” Becky peeks at the Nihilists Paradigm article that’s open on her phone. She taps her fingernail on the ceramic coffee mug. “I mean, it was good to talk to somebody, but we both agreed I didn’t need to schedule another visit.”

“So you’re feeling better, then?” Mrs. Martin sounds unconvinced.

“Yes. I wasn’t really that messed up in the first place,” Becky says with an awkward laugh.

“But you just weren’t yourself when I saw you.”

“Right, but we went over that. I was just having a bad week.”

“It’s hard for me to know though, since I don’t see you every day.”

“I understand.” Becky’s patient pose strains, but she keeps her cool. “And it did help to vent. It did.”

“Okay, I’m glad to hear that, then. I should probably let you get back to work.”

“Have a safe trip, mom.”

“I’ll call you next week. I love you.”

“Love you too.” Becky hangs up the phone. She turns her attention back to work, browsing the order form on her monitor. Through her open door, she sees Brian and Rob walk past, likely leaving for lunch.

Moments later, Jackie steps into her office. She plops down in a charcoal grey chair on the wall by the doorway.

“Hi.” Becky greets her. “What’s going on?”

“Nothing, I’m just snooping. You know me.”

“Snooping about what?”

Jackie scrutinizes her friend’s upbeat evasiveness. “What is with you today? You don’t seem like yourself.”

“Why?” Becky discreetly grabs her phone and shuts off the screen. “Were you expecting me to be all depressed about Brian or something?” She slides her

phone into her purse on the floor.

“Not necessarily, but I didn’t think you’d be the exact opposite.”

Nodding at her observation, Becky leans in over the desk and lowers her volume. “How much time do you have?” She points at the doorway. “Is somebody covering the desk?”

“Yeah, I’m on break.” Jackie’s interest is piqued. “What’s up?” She scoots the grey chair in closer to Becky’s desk.

“Last night after work I stopped at that little festival going on in the Portico district, and I went to a psychic.”

“I didn’t know you were into stuff like that.”

“I’ve never been to a psychic before, but I’ve always believed in the mystical.” Becky shrugs. “It seemed like a good time to try it out.”

“Sure, my cousin sees one regularly. So what happened?”

“She did a Tarot reading, and it was kind of spot on.”

“Like how?”

“She said that lately, I’ve been discontent. But then some person would come along and show me a new direction.”

“Like a new relationship?”

“I think so. I think it’s this guy I’ve been talking to.”

“Who?” Jackie’s eyes glimmer, unmasking her insatiable appetite for gossip.

“Nobody you know.”

She tilts her head with dubious concern. “Somebody *you* know though, right?”

“Oh yeah, we used to work together,” Becky tells her as if it’s the truth. Jackie accepts that explanation, so Becky continues. “Anyway, he got in touch with me a couple months ago. But I’ve kept it really casual of course, because of Brian.”

“So you’re interested in this guy?”

“Yeah.” Becky confides in her.

“And you never once brought him up to me?”

In an indicting manner Becky says, “No offense sweetie, but people talk.”

Guilty, Jackie diverts her eyes. Her loose lips are no secret around the office.

“Besides, it was totally innocent.” Becky stresses.

“It doesn’t have to be, now. Are you going out with him this weekend?”

“Yes.”

“What’s his name?”

Becky halts before hastily responding...Stillborn...she doesn’t know his name. Like a mini-miracle, their boss Gary appears in the doorway. Becky swiftly acknowledges him. “Hi Gary.”

“Becky, will you have time to get that order processed before you leave?”

“Yes, I’m just about done with it. I’ll copy you on the email before I go.”

“Okay.” Gary spies down at Jackie, who smiles up at him. She stands up from the grey chair and slips out of the office to let Becky get back to work.

“Was there anything else I should know about?” Becky asks him.

“No, it’s just a new account for you, so I wanted to make sure everything was going smooth.”

“So far so good.” She assures him.

“All right then. Hope your dental appointment goes well.” Gary pats the doorframe and backs out of Becky’s office.

After a long exhale of relief, she collapses back in her desk chair.

***

A female hand holds a single white rose. The sharp, angled blade of an Exacto knife tool slices a thorn off of the stem. The thorn falls into a small pile at the base of the stem, onto Black’s desk. The rose is turned. Another thorn is sliced.

“Becky. I’m meeting her tonight.” Relaxed in his desk chair, Black is in the midst of a discussion with Cade. He’s seated on a barstool at the pub table against the wall in Black’s narrow office.

“Oh, that one.”

“Yeah, that one.” He has his chair turned to Cade. “What about you? Where are you at with your top-secret abduction?”

“I’m almost finished with the game plan, but I’m not in any big hurry to do it or anything.” Cade glances over at Black’s subordinate, Kayleigh, who is de-thorning the rose.

With her hair pulled back into a ponytail, Kayleigh sits further down the desk near the surveillance monitor. She turns the rose, quietly working her way past the center of the stem.

“You’re not gonna drop out, right?” Black smirkingly taunts him.

Cade shakes his head. “Nah, it’s just not something to be rushed.” He hasn’t had the nerve to send his target the invitation.

There’s a knock at the door.

“Yeah?” Black asks over his shoulder.

“Can I talk to you? I know you’re busy. It’ll only take a minute.” Hannah is on the other side of the door. She doesn’t wait for a response, opening the door and letting herself into his office. “I’ll be fast.” Hannah promises. She spots Black’s sub out of the corner of her eye. Kayleigh is cutting the final thorn off the base of the stem. Hannah leaves her hand on the doorknob. “I just can’t go

on with the rest of the night without...” she addresses Kayleigh, “...Kayleigh, *please*.” She winds back around to Black. “Without talking to you privately.”

Kayleigh is quick to rise from her seat. She hands the rose to Black. He sets it down on his desk, between a black envelope and a black box, and instructs Kayleigh.

“Go down to the garage and put the sign on the van.”

“Okay.” She exits his office. Cade remains seated in the barstool against the brick wall.

After pushing the door shut, Hannah eases into the chair Kayleigh was sitting in. She rolls it in closer to Black. “I truly do feel wretched about this.” Hannah grovels to him. “You know that you’re like, one of my best friends here. I would never intentionally–”

Black interrupts her. “There’s a fine line between intention and inattention.”

“You’re right.” Hannah admits. “I just need you to know that I’m not taking it lightly.”

“I meant what I said earlier.”

“Yes, I know.” She raises her hand in resignation. “I’m your bitch.”

Over at the pub table, Cade cracks up at her.

Black lets out a subtle laugh. “That too, but.”

“But what?” Hannah lowers her hand and fixes on Black, who clarifies.

“I meant, when my instincts tell me something doesn’t feel right...”

“I will trust you, and respect that.”

Black leans back with an imperious air. “Say it again.”

“I will trust and respect your instincts.” Hannah glimpses at Cade, detectably ill at ease over him witnessing her meek display.

“Good.” Black is satisfied.

“Are we okay then? I could not *stand it* if you were mad at me.” Hannah frets.

He turns his chair and reaches for his phone. He checks the time. “Don’t you have a tortured soul to sniff out tonight?” Black taps the edge of his phone on his knee.

“Yes I do.” Hannah stands up from the chair and tucks it in under the desk. “I’ll let you get back to your project.” In a lightened stride, she makes her way to the door. Hannah leaves his office and pulls the door shut behind her.

Once she’s gone, Black makes a call. He puts the phone on speaker and sets it on the counter.

Cade looks over at Black’s screen. “You’re calling Random?” he asks in surprise.

“Yeah. I originally had you in mind for this errand.”

Random answers the call. “Taking me up on my offer?” He presumes.
“If you’re still offering.”
“Where are you?”
“My office,” Black tells him.

***

Down in the Mercer Estate garage, Kayleigh approaches a white cargo van parked on the far end. She’s holding a 2’ tall by 3’ wide magnetic sign. She sticks it up on the side of the cargo van and walks off. The sign reads, ‘Express Courier Services’.

***

Home from work, Becky sits in front of her computer in waiting. Her quiet living room is bright with afternoon sunshine. Over by the front door, a long narrow table sits against the backside of her beige couch. On top of the table is a vase filled with daisies next to a row of three framed photos. The first one is a family Christmas shot of Becky with her parents and sister, who’s in a wheelchair. The middle photo is an older one of Becky on a boat ride with a couple of girlfriends. The last one shows Becky at a bar with Jackie, Rob and Brian, whose arm is around her.

Becky stares at the clock in the corner of her screen. When the time changes to 3:00, her incoming email alert sounds, triggering Becky back to center screen. She clicks open the email message from Stillborn. It’s a four-word message that reads, ‘Go get the door’.

The doorbell rings. Startled, Becky gets up and walks over to her front door. She opens it and finds a delivery driver standing on her porch. Becky takes a quick look past him at the white cargo van in the driveway, labeled ‘Express Courier Services’.

“Hi, I’ve got a delivery here for Rebecca Martin.” Random is posing as the delivery driver.

“That would be me.” Becky tries to see what he’s carrying, but Random has the black and white items tucked under his arm. The clipboard is blocking her view.

He specifically hands her the black envelope first. Becky flips it over. She notices the #1 written in a corner, in white. Random passes her the second item, which is the single white rose with no thorns. She holds it up to her nose to smell it and sees a little #2 written on one of the petals in black marker. The last thing

Random has is the small box wrapped in glossy black paper. Becky sees the #3 in white print on top of the black box.

"And that's it. Could you sign this for me?" Polite but concise, he holds out the clipboard.

"Sure." She sets the gifts down on the long table behind her couch. Becky takes the clipboard from Random. He follows it up with a silver fountain pen. She pauses for a second and rolls the fancy pen between her fingers. It's a Mont Blanc. While signing the delivery receipt she comments, "Nice pen."

"Thanks." Random reaches out to take the pen and clipboard back from her. "You have a good afternoon."

"Thank you, you too." Becky closes her door and picks the three gifts up from the table. She carries them over to her desk to check them out.

First, she opens the envelope and pulls out a folded sheet of thick grey paper. Becky opens it up and reads the letter:

Number one, Real time is the black, the normal. Virtual time is the white, beyond the normal. And right now you're in the grey area, which is an invitation to play a game that takes you from the black into the white. The farther you go, the greater the reward. That's the one and only promise I'll make. So before we go any further, let's make sure neither of us is wasting our time. I need you to think about the things we've talked about and ask some questions.

The letter is signed, Black.

With a deducing nod, Becky flicks the corner of the letter. "Black. Black and white theme." She refolds the letter and slips it back into the envelope. Her incoming email alert sounds once again. She turns her chair to the monitor. Clicking open the email from Black, she devours the message:

Reply to this email and ask me whatever you need to know. Once I give you the answers, number two is what you'll use to indicate your consent. Should you decide to play, number three is what you'll wear when we meet later. Now get your questions out of the way so we can get going.

Becky's lips twist into an eager grin. She closes the email window and unwraps the black box. Inside the box is a supple white leather thong. After giving it a judgmental snort, she tosses the thong aside on her desk and clicks the 'reply' button on the email.

***

Meanwhile in the living room of Black's suite, he, Trip and Reno are spread out around the steel grey sectional. His front door is wide open. Buoyant reggae music plays in the background.

“Think you can help me out with that later?” Black asks Reno.

“Yeah, I was planning on being there tonight, anyway.” Reno lights up a cigarette.

“Her name is Becky, just to get that out of the way.” Black advises him.

Hannah cruises into the living room from the penthouse corridor and heads towards them. “Hello.” She joins Black on the couch, leaving a cushion’s width between them.

“You’re back. Why?” he asks aloofly.

“I’m just killing a little time, is all.” Hannah sets her phone down on the coffee table and eyeballs Reno. They swap a spirited sneer of contempt.

“The time-killing room.” Trip digs in his jeans pocket for a lighter. He has a joint in his other hand.

“Squandering is one of the many joys of hedonism.” Reno watches Trip *not* light the joint. He takes a drag of his cigarette.

“I smell coffee.” Hannah turns to Black. “Where are your subs at?” she asks, hinting at the expectation of being served a cup.

“The twins are downstairs in the lounge. Today’s their birthday.”

“Oh, that’s right.” She sounds bummed. “I guess I’m not gonna make it to the club tonight.”

“I don’t think they’ll notice.” Black gestures to the hallway on his left, at the bedroom doors. “I think the other two are just in their rooms.”

“I really hate to miss a V.I.P. party at the club, but.” Hannah slaps her hands on her thighs, pushing herself back up into a standing position. “Priorities, you know?” She disappears into the small kitchen to get herself a cup of coffee. The thud of a cupboard door closing is followed by the clink of Hannah setting a coffee mug down on the granite kitchen counter.

“What time is it?” Trip wonders out loud.

Black glances over at Hannah’s phone on the coffee table to check. “Almost five.”

“What time are you lighting that thing?” Reno points the tip of his cigarette at the joint in Trip’s hand. “Huh?”

“Oh.” Trip looks at the joint absentmindedly.

Hannah walks back into the living room carrying a mug of coffee and returns to her seat on the sectional near Black.

Further down, Reno waits for Trip to light up the joint, take a couple of puffs and hand it to Black. “Finally.” He sets his cigarette in the ashtray and stretches his arm out in front of Hannah to take the joint from Black.

She sips her steaming coffee and sets the mug down next to her phone. “I think I’m gonna go the strip club route this time around.” Hannah announces,

signaling her desire to talk about her impending subordinate hunt.

“For what, recruiting?” Reno asks while holding his hit.

“Yeah,” she answers with a hint of distaste about the chore. Reno offers her the joint. “No thanks.” Hannah declines. “I’ve gotta stay sharp.”

Trip stands up and leans over the coffee table to take the joint back from Reno, who’s on the opposite side of the sectional from him.

“Hannah’s on a mission.” Black teases her.

“Oh, that’s right.” Reno passes the joint to Trip. “Your new minion bailed already, didn’t he?”

Hannah emits a weary sigh. “Yeah, yeah.”

“You’ve gone the strip club route before though, right?” Reno settles back into his seat.

“I have. It’s always prosperous. Kind of like my shortcut.”

“May as well take it, then.” Reno scoffs. Alongside his cigarette smoke, the stench of weed has overtaken the coffee scent in the living room.

Behind Black, Shay appears in the open doorway.

“My phone won’t stop ringing.” She hangs onto the doorframe dramatically.

“Shay, you need to start delegating more of the game plans for these jobs out to us.” Reno sways to the thumping reggae beat.

“Oh please.” Hannah derides him with a huff. “I love how you offer while you’re sitting on your ass getting high.”

Reno gazes at her, stoned. He slants forward to snuff out his cigarette.

“It’s been a crazy couple weeks.” Trip agrees. “Income tax refunds, maybe?”

A ripple of laughter passes through the living room.

“You’re probably right, though.” Shay nods at him. “I keep thinking I’m caught up, and then I get another damn call. It’s not easy being me.”

“Give me a break. You’re addicted.” Trip accuses her and sees the terse smile that Shay gives him in response.

“Are the chamber four people still here?” Hannah asks her.

“Yes, they’re here.” Shay lets go of the doorframe and flops back against it. “But my end is done.”

“Who’s getting stuck with cleanup?” Black looks over his shoulder at Shay.

“Cade.”

“Glad to hear it.”

“I wouldn’t ask you twice in a row, Black. I don’t want to owe you too many favors. You cash ‘em in.” Shay grins at him.

“You should go down and get a massage,” Hannah tells her. “Unwind.”

“Funny enough, that’s exactly where I’m heading.”

“Enjoy. Bye.” Hannah flutters her fingers at Shay, who exits the doorway. Propping her feet up on the coffee table, Hannah peers over at Black. “Where is Cade, by the way? I’m surprised he’s not in here.”

“Oh, he’s busy.”

“Doing what? Working on his super-secret plan?” She mocks.

“Yeah, I think so.”

“His what?” Reno is clueless.

Hannah, the only lucid one in the room at this juncture, keeps the conversation rolling. She turns to Trip. “Guys seem to like you, Trip. Maybe I should have you recruit somebody for me.”

Trip doesn’t respond, spaced off in his own little world.

“I guess that’s a ‘no’.” Reno chuckles at Trip’s trancelike state.

Black checks the time on Hannah’s phone on the coffee table. He gets up from his couch and stands near the front door in silent encouragement for his guests to leave.

Oblivious to Black’s innuendo, Trip snags his lighter from the coffee table and mumbles, “I’ve got to go check on something.” He has a distracted frown on his face.

Reno and Hannah exchange a what-the-hell glance. “Everything all right, there?” Reno asks him.

“Fine, I just remembered something.” Trip stands up from the sectional and roams to the door in a haze. He passes by Black on his way out.

Black looks at Reno with a shrug that denotes he has no idea what’s come over Trip.

Hannah picks her phone up off the coffee table. “I should head off, too. I need to get mentally prepared to be,” she takes a deep breath, “*charming*, tonight.”

“No time to waste, then.” Reno jibes.

“No time to waste with you, that’s for sure.” Hannah counters insipidly. “You’re almost as bad as him.” She homes in on Black over by the door.

“So bitter, Hannah.” Reno grabs his cigarettes from the coffee table. He stands up and aims a feisty snarl at her. “It just kills you knowing that I could round somebody up tonight without even trying.”

“And you think I can’t?” Hannah retains her dignity while he attempts to pluck her nerves.

“You really think you’ll recruit one tonight?”

“Sure do,” she answers confidently.

“How much do you want to put on it?”

“Let’s say, two no-questions-asked favors.” She proposes.

“You got it.” He strolls across the dark hardwood towards the front door.

“It’s on.” Hannah springs up and follows him.

“I’ll start thinking about what I need done.” Reno continues his snarky banter with Hannah as they make their way to the door.

Black is waiting by the suite door with his hands shoved in his pockets.

“Try not to get lost on the way back to your suite while you do that.” She rolls her eyes.

“My fully staffed suite.” Reno highlights, sauntering out into the penthouse corridor.

Hannah steps up to the doorway and stands across from Black.

“Good luck tonight,” he tells her.

“Thanks. I need it now that I’ve got a wager with Reno.”

“I’m sure you’ll be very motivated.”

“You don’t know the half of it. And you,” she lightly pokes Black in the chest, “have a good night tonight. I’d tell you to have fun, but it’s *you*, you know.” Hannah refers to Black’s reserved disposition. “Nonetheless, I hope everything goes swimmingly.”

“We’ll see.”

“Tell the twins I said Happy Birthday.”

With a soft laugh through his nose he says, “They wouldn’t believe me. You better tell them yourself.”

***

Minya walks into her bedroom in Black’s suite holding an armful of dresses. Her sister Marsa is sitting cross-legged on the bed. She has her hair up in hot rollers. The flaxen-haired Egyptian twins are leisurely getting ready for their birthday celebration. With wideset blue eyes and plump lips, they have an exotic appeal. They appear dreamy and stoned even when they’re completely sober; Marsa, more so than her sister.

A vase of fragrant white roses with a Happy Birthday balloon tied around it sits on the nightstand. The twins’ phones are next to the vase. Minya walks past the nightstand and slides a pile of dresses off her arm onto the bed. Marsa looks up from filing her nails at the heap of dresses at the foot of the bed.

“Okay, I’ve gone through both our closets. I think I have it narrowed down to three dresses.” Minya bends down to start sorting through them.

Their queen-size bed is shoved into the corner of the small bedroom, leaving just enough room next to it for the nightstand and a long dresser along the wall opposite from the bed. A full-length mirror is propped up between the closet and

the bedroom door. Their carpeted floor is scattered with shoes, cosmetics, hair products and a few colorful gift bags.

“What’d you find?” Marsa tosses the nail file down on the nightstand. She reaches up to re-secure a hot roller in her hair.

Minya pulls out a cream sheath dress. “Is it corny if we match?” She sets it off to the side.

“Oh no way, we have to match tonight.”

“That’s what I thought, too.” Minya heads over to the closet. “I could only find one of the cream ones in your closet, so I’m guessing the other one’s in here.” She opens the closet door.

Marsa scans the two rectangular gift boxes on the dresser. Both are wrapped in glossy black paper, trimmed with white satin ribbons. “Black had me wrap your gift.”

“Same here. I didn’t get to see what it was, though.”

“Neither did I,” she imitates Black, “you are *not* to look inside the box, Marsa.”

Minya giggles at her sister and shoves a section of clothing out of her way inside the closet. “He had me wrap something else too, a box for Becky.”

“Who’s Becky?” Marsa bristles.

“Some outsider, I don’t know.” She flips through hangers.

“Is he trying to recruit her?” Prying for information, Marsa rummages around inside a cosmetic bag full of nail polish bottles.

“He’s obviously pursuing her, but I don’t really know any details. Never a dull moment around this place.”

“I know. That’s why I love it.” Marsa settles on a bottle of diamond polish.

“I can’t find the other one.” Minya sounds frustrated. On the nightstand, both phones beep simultaneously with an incoming message. “Who is it?” Minya peeps over her shoulder at Marsa on the bed. She’s reading the messages.

“It’s Black. He says to open our gifts.” Marsa transitions to a whisper. “Do you think he’s listening to us?”

“Probably.” Minya goes over to the dresser and picks up the two black boxes. Recognizing her handiwork on the bow, she hands Marsa her gift. “This one’s yours.” Minya leans against the dresser and unties the satin bow on her own gift. The twins open up their boxes and pull out matching silky, scarlet dresses.

Marsa gasps. “This is gorgeous!” She holds up the spaghetti straps of the revealing yet elegant dress.

“I guess we know what we’re wearing tonight.” Minya sets the box on the dresser behind her.

***

Becky also knows what she's wearing tonight. Sitting at her desk, she bounces back and forth between the white thong lying next to her keyboard and the email from Black, his response to the list of questions she sent him that afternoon. She scrolls through his reply email one last time before closing out the window and standing up from her desk chair. Without looking down at it, Becky picks up the leather thong on her way to the bathroom.

She walks in and shuts the door behind her. She loops the white thong around the neck of a plastic hanger which is holding a black cocktail dress, following in line with his black and white theme. Becky hangs the dress up on a silver hook on the back of the door next to a pale pink robe. She takes her phone out of her pocket, pulls up her workout playlist and sets her phone down on the bathroom counter.

Uplifting, repetitive techno music plays faintly through Becky's phone as a backdrop to the Q&A email she just finished reading for the third time. Her first question to him was, 'Are there any major changes I'll need to make in my daily life to play your game?'

Becky heads over to turn on the shower. She backs away from the tub and brushes out her blonde hair.

For one, you had to miss a few hours of work today to get my message. Things like that will come up now and then. You might think about making up a lie to use in reality, for times that you need to get away without telling the truth.

She brushes her hair up into a ponytail. Her second question was, 'What exactly does virtual time mean?'

The shower fills with steam while Becky undresses.

At the risk of sounding vague, that'll be entirely up to you.

Becky pushes the textured glass shower door closed behind her. The fuzzy silhouette of her body is visible through the shower door. She begins washing her face. Her third question was, 'Are there any safety issues I should be aware of?'

My lifestyle doesn't involve any sort of brainwashing, cult activities, or even intoxication that isn't consensual. It's all about trust and common sense.

Inside the shower, Becky rinses soapsuds off her face. She lathers up a terrycloth bath glove and starts soaping up her neck and shoulders, working her way down her body. Her fourth question was, 'How would I get out of this game, if I had to at some point?'

If normal-life circumstances get in the way, you just have to let me know. There aren't any strings attached on my end.

She stands under the showerhead, letting hot water run down her body. The joyful beat of the synth techno song intensifies. Her fifth question was, ‘What might make you get rid of me at some point?’

Wrapped in a towel, Becky walks up to the fogged over bathroom mirror. She steps in front of the sink to brush her teeth.

Disobedience is what would end the game. Because if you accept the invitation, then you’re agreeing to do what I ask while we’re playing. With your consent, comes your trust.

She pulls a curling iron from a lower cabinet and plugs it in. While the iron heats up, Becky reaches for a bottle of lemon sugar body lotion. She pumps some out and spreads it over her skin.

Keep in mind that your role in this will always be changing. So if there’s a part you don’t really like, something different is around the corner. As long as you can take the bad with the good, you’ll eventually get to make rules instead of obey them.

Becky slips into her pale pink bathrobe and leaves the bathroom. Her sixth and final question was, ‘What made you choose me for this?’

She heads through the golden rays shining into the living room, over to her desk and picks up the white rose.

Your screen name begged for attention, so I struck up a conversation. I’m pretty good at reading between the lines.

Rose in hand, Becky walks to the front door and opens it to a view of wispy clouds over the setting sun.

Now, when you’re ready to accept, put the rose out on your porch.

The white rose lands in the corner of her porch.

Don’t forget gift number three. I don’t care what you wear over it, but we’re going to a club where I know a lot of people, so aim high.

Becky is nothing if not meticulous about her appearance. In the hour it takes the sun to fully sink down into the horizon, she is onto finishing touches in the bathroom. Her blonde hair hangs in loose curls. She adjusts her black cocktail dress before reaching around her back to zip it up. Her makeup is done. Becky is ready to go. After swiping a silver bangle bracelet from the counter, Becky flips the light off and leaves the bathroom.

Be ready to go at eight o’clock. That gives you plenty of time, so take advantage of it.

She passes through her dusky living room, sliding the bracelet onto her wrist. On the wall above her desk, the Hello Kitty clock reads 8:00.

The doorbell rings. Becky slips her feet into a pair of black sandals. She grabs her handbag and rushes to open the front door. On the far corner of her

front porch, the white rose is gone.

Chapter 3

After she acknowledges the white rose missing from her stoop, Becky looks up from the porch at her ride.

"Becky?"

It's not Black. It's a handsome dirty blonde in his thirties, wearing an olive suit.

"Yes, I'm Becky."

"I'm Ryan. I'll be driving you to dinner." Behind him, a silver sports car idles in her driveway.

"Ryan." She repeats, a little stunned. "The driver?"

He nods at Becky, asks, "Ready to go?" and extends his hand to her.

If you accept the invitation, then you're agreeing to do what I ask while we're playing. With your consent, comes your trust.

"Yes I am." Becky takes his hand and follows him down to the humming car.

Ryan the driver is cordial during their short ride to dinner. He keeps the conversation as minimal and vague as possible within the constraints of courtesy. After seeing Becky to the front door of Luciano's restaurant, Ryan drives off in the silver sports car.

Nothing about the night ahead is divulged, yet it's all very organized and specific. A svelte, middle-aged hostess steers Becky through the upscale Italian steakhouse. They arrive at the round table draped with a white tablecloth where Black is seated. Two empty wineglasses and an ice bucket sit on the candlelit table.

The hostess pulls out the chair across from Black, who greets Becky with a socially expected smile. Becky looks right back at him while she gracefully slides into the chair. She acts like she's playing it cool, but Becky's seething with excitement. The hostess leaves and is replaced right away by a waiter approaching their table with a bottle of Vouvray. He presents the bottle, partially sheathed in a white cloth napkin. Black nods at the dutiful young waiter, who begins the uncorking process. He removes the cork, hands it to Black and pours a small taste into Black's glass.

After approving the wine, Black turns to Becky. "Welcome."

"Thank you. It's nice to meet you."

The waiter fills each of their wineglasses halfway before placing the bottle into the gold ice bucket on their table and walking away. Becky picks up her

wineglass. She scans Black's charcoal grey dress shirt, his dark hair and clean-shaved face. In person, his charged vigor is amplified.

"Have you ever been here before?" he asks her.

"No, but I've heard of it." Becky glimpses up at the vaulted stained-glass ceiling that glows in warm rust-orange shades. "You know what it reminds me of?"

Black shakes his head.

"Have you ever been to Fleming's Grill? It's down on Forty-Fifth Street, I believe." She sips her wine.

"We're not on a date. You know that, right?" Black wags his finger through the air between them. "This isn't a date."

"Okay." Becky freezes, holding her wineglass out in front of her.

"So you don't need to make idle remarks. I'll take care of the conversation." He relays before changing the subject. "Did you have any trouble getting out of work today?"

"It was short notice, but I have plenty of PTO hours so it was no big deal." She sets her wineglass down. "And by the way, I already have a lie I can use in the future, to get away."

"Tell me what it is."

"Sure, but I've got a quick question." She waves her hand over the table. "Normally there's a menu."

"I turned our order in earlier."

Becky balks in surprise. "I see. What am I having?" she curtly asks.

Black leans back in his chair and casts his eyes down on her. "Why don't you answer my question first?"

"Fair enough." She concedes. "Like I said, I'm a step ahead of you on the whole 'lie' deal, for a totally unrelated reason. Last month I got promoted to a new department at work, so I planted the seed that I have a handicapped sister. Which I do, but she lives with my parents in Phoenix." Becky curls her fingers around the stem of her wineglass. "I didn't mention that part, though." She takes a larger sip of her wine.

"And why did you do that?"

"That's the funny thing. I did it because Brian's in the department that I got promoted to. So, if I ever needed to get out of an awkward situation, I could use my sister as an excuse." With a tightlipped smile she adds, "Ironic, huh?"

"Convenient. Fortunate, even." He lingers in thoughtful silence until Becky breaks it.

"How about telling me something about yourself, *Black*?" She razzes him. "Like your real name, for instance." Her frisky attitude is not well received by

Black.

“Because who I am and what I do isn’t really important at the moment.”

“What if I want to get to know you a little better?”

“Oh you will.” Unflappable, Black tilts his head at Becky across the table. “Just not in the same ways you’re used to getting to know people.” He continues in a stanch voice. “And I should tell you, this dinner is really informal. I don’t want to overwhelm you or anything, so I’m keeping things light right now.”

“Oh, go ahead and overwhelm me.” She invites him with a flirtatious beam. Becky takes another drink of wine, draining her glass.

“When I say right now, I mean that.” Black’s tone turns patronizing. “Never fear kitten, I’ll hardly bore you. But my role in this game is to set your pace. And you can’t run a marathon without any training, because you’ll set yourself up for a loss.”

“Okay, okay,” Becky playfully butts in, “I get the metaphor.” She notices Black’s lean body straighten up and tower over the table towards her.

“Yeah, that right there,” he says in an assertive posture, “once we get up from this table, won’t be tolerated. Do you understand that?” He waits for Becky’s round-eyed nod. “Don’t test that.” Black relaxes back into his chair. Becky’s fluster fades into a coolheaded expression that demonstrates her understanding of the act he’s putting on. It’s a role-playing game.

“I apologize. When I don’t know the rules, it’s hard to play the game right.” She explains.

“Well for starters, don’t be yourself.” He gets straight to the point. “When I told you I wanted to show you off to some friends tonight, it’s not so they can weigh in on a potential girlfriend.” Black’s raw words are somewhat soothed by his calm delivery.

“Okay, I understand that.” Becky claims and then retreats inward, attempting to process what he’s saying.

A food server approaches the table with their meals. The waiter follows behind him, refilling Becky’s wineglass.

Black thanks the waiter and turns back to Becky, picking up where he left off. “And number two, quit trying to run the show. I’m not here to put up with your cheeky little bullshit attitude.” He picks up his fork. “So just shut up, clear your mind and eat your steak.”

His command leaves her speechless. Becky reaches for her silverware and cuts into her filet mignon.

***

A cobalt blue halter dress hangs from the shower door in the master bathroom of Hannah's suite at the Mercer Estate.

"Will!" Her impatient shout reverberates off the walls. "Where the hell is he?" she asks under her breath. Hannah, wearing a fluffy white robe, pivots over her vanity with an eye pencil in her hand. Focused on the mirror, she accents her smoky shadow by penciling in a dark streak just past the corner of her lash line.

"He's not in here."

Hannah glances back at Trip in the doorway, rattled by his presence. "Oh." Her blonde hair cascades down her shoulder in flowing waves. "Do you happen to know where he is?"

"I saw him downstairs getting something to eat."

"Okay. And what are *you* doing in here, if you don't mind my asking."

"I wasn't in here. I could hear you yelling from the hallway." Trip gestures behind him.

"Oh. Sorry." She turns back to the mirror.

"So, did you need something?"

Hannah uses a cotton swab to soften the line she drew at the corner of her lid. "Grab me a Xanax. They're in my nightstand."

"Are you nervous?" Trip chuckles and turns away from her bathroom door. He walks into the adjacent master bedroom.

"No, I'm still reeling with the whole 'putting Black's life at risk' ordeal. I just don't want the distraction tonight."

"Yeah, Shay told me about that," he says from the other room.

"I figured she had." Hannah pitches the cotton swab. "You know why it's such a big deal when I make a mistake? Because I don't usually make them." She spots Trip in the mirror's reflection, holding out his hand. "Thanks." Hannah twists around to take the pill from Trip's palm. She sets it down on the light-colored granite vanity and looks at his image in the mirror. He's looking back at her.

"Where are you going tonight?"

"Rumors," she tells him.

"I've been there. When are you leaving?" he asks.

"I don't know, around ten." Hannah spouts. "What are you doing? I thought everybody left for the club by now."

"I'm waiting for a phone call before I head over there."

"Something important?" Her edginess wanes.

"I don't know yet."

An inquisitive twitch crosses Hannah's face. Earlier that evening, Trip had grown distracted for unknown reasons and left Black's suite in a fog. "Does it

have anything to do with earlier?”

“What?” Her question baffles Trip.

“In Black’s suite, when you got all constipated and said you had to go check on something. Remember?”

“Oh, yeah, actually it does.”

“Is everything okay?”

“I don’t know yet.” He spaces off, similar to the way he did earlier. Hannah catches it but lets the subject drop.

“Okay, well I hope things go the direction you want them to, then. I guess.”

“You too.” Trip snaps out of his funk. “Tonight, I mean.”

“Thanks, Trip.” Hannah watches him disappear from the doorway on his way out of her suite. She leans back into the mirror muttering, “Kooky kid.”

***

Back at Luciano’s restaurant, Becky stabs her fork into her last bite of steak. She pops it into her mouth and sets down her fork.

“Tell me what you’re thinking right now.” Black picks up a fresh rum and cola.

“I’m not sure you want to know.”

“Dammit, Becky.” Shaking his head, Black sips his drink.

“All right.” She backs down. It’s obvious that he wants her to be subdued, but it’s equally obvious that she’s not sure how to go about it. “The temptation to challenge and exceed expectations is in my blood. So right now, I’m wondering how I’m supposed to just repress my natural instincts.”

“Stop juggling your faith with your doubt. Just observe.” Black takes another drink and sets his glass down on the table.

“See, I don’t know what you mean by that.” Becky picks up the wine bottle. “What do I like, tell myself, you know?” She pours the last splash of wine from the bottle into her glass.

He nods in understanding and dumbs it down for her. “Separate the game like you separate any other situations in life. You play a certain role when you’re with your family. And you play a different one when you’re out at the bar with your friends, right?”

“Yes.”

The waiter shows up at the table to deliver their dessert, cherry cheesecake, then vanishes.

Black picks up his fork and carries on. “I’m sure you know the term ‘work mode’. Think about how you already play other roles. Take away what you talk

about and focus on how you act around certain people, in certain situations." He eats a bite of his cheesecake and watches Becky follow in suit. "This is just a different act. So, push everything out of your mind and go into 'anticipation mode', all right?"

"Okay." Becky blinks at him a few times. His explanation allays her. She washes the bite of cheesecake down with the last of her wine.

"When I tell you to shut up and do what I ask, don't get *offended*." He lets out a short laugh. "Just do it. That's all you have to concentrate on, me and my directions. That's it. Your role's easy." Black sets his dessert fork down on the table and tosses his cloth napkin over the plate. "You did a good job, by the way."

Becky looks at him blankly.

"Your appearance, you did what I asked." He specifies for her.

"Oh, thanks," she says with a coy smile.

Black scoots his chair back from the table. "Ready to leave?"

When he stands up, Becky notices how tall he is, over six feet. "Shouldn't we ask for the bill?" She gapes up at him.

"We've paid. Come on."

Becky gets up and follows Black out the door of Luciano's and into his car in the parking lot, where he proceeds to drive them to their next destination.

She checks out the polished interior of Black's Mercedes AMG Roadster. The unhurried guitar strum of an alternative song plays at a low volume.

"This is a really nice car." She comments, clearly impressed.

Black nods, laidback, keeping his eyes on the road.

He's made it known that he doesn't want to see her personality and just wants her to go with the flow, so Becky remains quiet. They're traveling on a busy street, passing by brightly lit gas stations and retail locations that are closed for the night. Becky's phone chimes inside her purse. She ignores it, but Black broaches the subject.

"Phone?"

"It's just a text," she tells him.

"Unless it's important, silence your phone for the rest of the night."

"Okay." Becky fishes her phone out of her purse, turns off the sound and slips it back in.

Her compliance prompts Black to give Becky a short break from the intensity and throw her a bone. "I might give you a hard time a lot more than I give you praise, but I do have to hand it to you for your lack of self-importance."

"What do you mean?"

“I mean you didn’t have your phone out during dinner, taking pictures or doing anything impertinent. Tonight, or ever. You’re not compelled to broadcast your personal life. That level of awareness matters to me, a lot.”

With a slow nod, Becky replies uncertainly. “Thank you?”

“Thank *you*. I had more than one reason for choosing you. You’re discreet, you have common sense and you have drive. You just need direction, and I think I can give you that.” Black ends on that note. The lethargic music becomes the only noise in the car.

Opposed to a silent ride, Becky continues chattering. “Speaking of direction...”

“What about it?”

“I went and got a Tarot reading after work yesterday.”

Black arches his brows in criticism. “So, both a psychiatrist and a psychic within a two-day time period?” He glances over at Becky, scrutinizing her. “You’re not batshit, are you?”

“Me? I’m the one with the normal life.”

“Yeah, it sounds like it,” he says sarcastically. The tempo of the song playing surges.

“Well, they were both first time experiences for me, just to clarify that. As open-minded as you supposedly are, I’m surprised you’re not into that stuff.”

“Psychics?” Black shoots her an insulted scowl. “That’s not real. It’s intentionally vague nonsense.”

“I don’t know. You came up in the reading. She said we were destined to meet.”

“Mm, I highly doubt that.”

“It’s true.” Becky proclaims. “She said I’d encounter someone who would show me a new direction in life.”

“That could apply to anyone, Becky. And I’m more objective than open-minded, just to clarify *that*.” Black abruptly redirects her. “Listen, we’re almost there. Remember ‘anticipation mode’. Got it?”

“Got it.”

***

The landscaping lights radiate an amber shimmer around the Mercer Estate pool area. A thin haze rises from the heated water’s surface, making contact with the cooling night temperature.

Trip is lying in one of the lounge chairs beside the pool. He has his phone up to his ear and a sag in his shoulders. “Yes, I’ll be able to. Just let me know if, uh,

if that’s what needs to be done.” He pauses. “Okay, keep me posted.” Trip ends the call and rubs his forehead. His mood is a cross of worry and reluctance. He sits upright in his lounge chair. The house is behind him in the background...

Inside the house, up on the penthouse level, Shay’s standing in front of the window in Random’s private office. She investigates the pool area, resting her fingertips on the windowsill. There’s about two feet of space between her and the backside of his executive chair.

Random is sitting at his desk, fixed on his laptop monitor. His phone is lying alongside the keyboard. When the screen lights up, Random picks it up to read the message. “The limo will be here at ten o’clock tomorrow.” He notifies Shay.

“That’s good news.”

“He is literally leaving every detail of this scenario up to us.” Random sets his phone down and gets back to work.

“He’s only done one before and it was really simple, so he wanted to leave this to the professionals.” Her response is coherent but saddled with distraction.

Random peers over his shoulder at her. “What are you looking at?”

“Trip. He’s down by the pool. Something’s wrong.”

“Go check it out. I’ve got plenty I can do while you’re gone.” Random gets back to his monitor. He skims the open document on the screen.

“Yeah, I think I will. I’ll be back in a few.” Shay turns away from the window. She leaves Random’s office to go down to the pool...

Trip’s phone rings, cutting through the stillness in the pool area. He checks the display and answers it. Loud, booming noises blast through the earpiece, a mix of techno music, yelling and laughter. Trip holds the phone out from his ear as he speaks into it. “Geneva?”

“Are you on your way?” A woman asks over the noise on the line.

“Yes, I’m leaving right now.” Trip hastily ends the call and shoves his phone into his pocket. He gets up from the lounge chair and sees Shay walking across the limestone patio.

“Hey.” She approaches Trip and stands across from him. Her exuding concern seems to instantly make him uneasy. He looks past her at the pool.

“Hey.” Trip spews a quiet sigh.

“Is everything okay with you?” Shay reaches for Trip’s chin, gently turning his face towards hers. She doesn’t let go until Trip makes eye contact with her.

“I don’t know. But there’s nothing I can do about it.” Trip backs up and tries to slip away, but Shay grabs onto his arm.

“Stop.” She pleads for him to let her help.

“I don’t want to deal with this.”

She steers Trip back to the lounge chair, where he ultimately caves and takes a seat. Shay sits down next to him and folds her arms over her lap. “What’s going on?”

Trip doesn’t drag it out. “My dad isn’t doing well.”

“Okay.” Shay listens solemnly.

“Just–” He tenses up. “Don’t say anything, please.”

“I won’t.”

“I don’t want to have to talk about it, you know?”

“Yeah, I know.” She laces her arm through Trip’s. “I won’t say anything.”

“I’m running late.” He lets her know. “Are you sure you don’t want to come with?”

“I can’t go to the club.” Shay motions to the house. “I’m working on a scenario with Random. Otherwise I would.”

“You and Random both. Must be a good one.”

“Yeah.” She perks up and adds, “It is a good one, actually.”

***

The front door to Club Joy opens up, and Becky follows Black inside the lively nightclub. High ceilings and dark walls give it a warehouse rave-like feel. They make their way through the energetic crowd to the main-level bar. Strobe lights pulse throughout the spacious club. Techno music throbs in the foreground. Black and Becky arrive at the bar, where he takes out his wallet.

“Are you gonna tell me who’s checking me out, or is that a mystery too?” she asks him.

“It’ll be obvious.” He gets some cash out for the bartender. “I probably know at least, twenty percent of the people here, tonight.”

“No,” Becky says with a note of suspicion. She doesn’t bother telling Black what she’d like to drink. While waiting for cocktails at the main-level bar, Becky studies the club. Up above, there’s a purple neon-lit balcony level. The purple neon snakes along the wall to a cage, which houses the D.J. and light system. Beneath the cage on the main level, stainless-steel barstools line the perimeter of a crowded dance floor.

“You’ll start recognizing them over time,” Black tells her. “And you’ll even meet them here and there.”

“This isn’t like the only place you go, is it?”

“Of course not, but we have our favorites.”

“We, as in you and your friends?” Becky pries.

The bartender sets their drinks down. A rum and cola and a Long Island iced tea.

“Friends, confederates.” Black hands the Long Island over to Becky. He starts walking to a nearby spiral staircase, and Becky follows him. On the way over, Ryan comes up to them. Becky lights up in recognition.

“Black.” Ryan addresses him.

Becky widens her eyes at the revelation that he does in fact go by the name Black. Marsa and Minya slink up behind Ryan. They stay a step back on either side of him. Dressed in their matching claret dresses, the sultry twins smile at Black in appreciation for their birthday gifts.

“Ryan, how are they?” Black alludes to the twins.

“They’ve been a pleasure.”

“Where’s Rayne? Is she here?”

“She is. They’re upstairs.”

Black nods Ryan off and continues to the spiral staircase with Becky. They pass by the V.I.P. Only sign posted at the bottom of the staircase. A brawny white bouncer stands next to the sign, coolly surveilling while Black takes Becky’s wrist and leads her up the stairs. In a pleasant daze, she follows him up. The loud music reverberates through the metal grating of the steps.

Approximately 40-50 patrons are occupying the Club Joy balcony level for the V.I.P. event. Some are in semi-circle booths along the walls, and others swarm around the center bar. Black and Becky reach the top of the staircase. He shows her over to a corner booth.

The booth sits below three illuminated stained-glass windows. The three women already seated there slide over to make room. Their table, like every other table on the balcony, has a weighted birthday balloon bouquet in the middle. Becky scoots in next to Rayne, a beautiful African-American Domme with striking green eyes.

The other two intimidating women are across the table from Becky. Geneva, in her forties, is well dressed in age-appropriate club attire. Vienna, about ten years older, is eternally classy in a beige suit and donning a sagacious leer. Both women are pale, raven-haired Dommes.

Black sits down next to Becky at the end of the booth and initiates a conversation that is above her head. “I just heard the news today,” he says to Vienna across the table from him.

“It’s really bittersweet for me.” She imparts in a melancholy lilt.

“I’m sure.”

“But I’ll be around for a while. It might be a couple months before I move.” Vienna pulls a vibrating phone out of her purse. “Oh, sorry guys, I’ve gotta go.”

“Where to?” Geneva asks.

“I promised Damien a little CBT tonight, so I’m due in the ladies.”

Becky squints in confusion at Vienna’s response.

“See you later.” Geneva winks at Vienna, who collects her purse and exits the corner booth.

Under the table, Rayne’s arm moves over Becky’s upper thigh. Her fingers slide under the hem of Becky’s dress and up the inside of her thigh to the leather thong between her legs. With slender fingers pressing against the white leather that covers her, Becky turns her head towards Rayne, only to be penetrated by that cat-like emerald stare.

Regaling at Becky’s naivety, Rayne starts laughing and pulls her hand away. “Yes Black, she’s wearing it.” She informs him and picks up her margarita. Black has a look of satisfaction on his face, Becky, a look of horror. He places his hand on Becky’s bare shoulder.

“Are you good?” Black squeezes her shoulder.

“Mm-hmm.” Becky takes a few sips of her Long Island iced tea. Between the hearty dinner and her relatively high alcohol tolerance, Becky’s wine buzz has waned. She picks up on an odd smell and sniffs the air around her.

“Okay, then I’ll be right back.” Black scoots out of the booth, abandoning both Becky and his untouched drink.

“What?” Becky asks with a ring of apprehension.

“I’ll be right back.” He assuages her and goes over to the balcony bar. The bartender, a gaunt blonde guy who has several facial piercings, lights a stick of incense while Minya walks around behind the bar with him. Black has a seat on the barstool between Ryan and Marsa.

“I hope you don’t think we’re bad company.” Geneva instigates Becky, whose eyes never leave the center bar.

“NO, no. That’s not it at all.” Becky watches the blonde bartender pick up a pair of knives. Minya pulls a propane torch out from below the bar. She sets it on the counter and ignites it.

“My name’s Geneva, by the way. In case you didn’t catch that.”

The bartender holds the knife blades in the blue flame until they glow. He touches the tip of one blade down onto the bar, picking up a bud of marijuana, and traps the bud between the two blades.

“It’s nice to meet you, Geneva. I’m Becky. Do you know what they’re doing over there?”

Smoke instantly begins curling out from between the knife blades. The bartender holds them out over the bar.

“The knife method,” Geneva tells her. “It’s just a way to smoke weed.”

Black and Ryan lean in for a hit with straws in their mouths. They suck up the white smoke.

“Seriously?”

“Busy minds need a break now and then.” Rayne validates the vice.

In a booth on the opposite side of the balcony level, Cade rises up from his harem of female subordinates. He makes his way over to join Black at the center bar, where Ryan relinquishes both his straw and his seat to Cade. Becky keeps tabs on the bar while rephrasing her question.

“But, how can they do that in here?” Just then, Becky notices Marsa’s hand resting on Black’s thigh.

“Oh, we’re pretty cozy with the owner.” Geneva unveils, while Rayne says,

“Don’t worry about the twins, by the way.”

Becky winds around to Rayne, who flashes her a brilliant smile.

“That’s right. You’re his project right now.” Geneva apprises her.

“Project?”

“Project, pursuit. Call it whatever you like.” Geneva draws her thin shoulders back. Her innate grace compliments her poise. She looks incisively at Becky. “Black says you’re in sales. What exactly do you sell?”

“HR and accounting services, we’re like a national liaison.”

“I see.”

Preoccupied with Black, Becky doesn’t enquire about Geneva or Rayne’s livelihoods. She doesn’t even bother asking whose birthday it is, so Geneva ceases her effort at conversation. Instead, Geneva peruses the balcony level. She spots Trip at the top of the spiral staircase, heading for the center bar.

Trip halts when he sees Geneva, and she picks up her wineglass. Geneva scoots out of the booth to join him.

“Well.” Rayne turns to Becky. “We’ve got something we need to go do. It was nice meeting you.” She follows Geneva out the other end of the booth. The hard-hitting bass of impelling house music fills the air. Becky is left sitting by herself until Black walks back over from the balcony bar.

He casually sits down next to Becky, in front of his full rum and cola. “Looks like you couldn’t hold their attention, either.” He watches Becky’s jaw drop at his wisecrack, and then he shoots her a cavalier smile. “You’ve really got to quit with the canned reactions, Becky.”

She begins to recognize Black’s pattern of patronization, the game he’s playing. “I just need more practice,” she says, overtly catching herself off guard with her own words.

“I’ve always had patience with you.”

“I know that.” Becky nods genuinely. Her uneasiness melts away.

“But neither one of us likes to get bored, do we?”

“No, we don’t.” She admits before picking up her drink.

“So we’ll give you some more practice.” Black suggests and leans back in his seat.

“Okay.”

“Finish that drink. Let’s move on.” He glances at Becky beside him, daintily chugging her cocktail, and adds, “I hope you understand that I’m not just trying to dominate you.”

Becky chokes on her drink and sets the glass on the table. “Are you joking?” She dabs the dribble on her bottom lip. “Isn’t that exactly what you’re trying to do?” She sees Black shaking his head at her. “But, everything that you’ve ever sent me since day one has had to do with either self-discipline or emotional detachment.”

“I know.”

“So, I took that to mean you were,” she lowers her voice, “a Dominant.”

“I am.” Black confirms.

“Looking for a submissive.”

He cocks his head. “Initially yes, but there’s a lot more to it. I hope you took away more information than just *that*.”

“How do you mean?”

Black briefly diverts his attention to acknowledge Kayleigh walking past the corner booth. He picks up Becky’s drink from the table and hands it to her. “The stuff I sent you covered some fundamentals of the game, a starting point. But everything evolves.”

“So they weren’t rules on being submissive?” Becky sips her drink.

“You just can’t see the big picture.”

Shameless, she says, “No, apparently I can’t.”

“What you’re seeing is my approach. And what I’m trying to do is teach you to manipulate yourself.”

Becky finishes the last swallow of her Long Island, lushly invigorated. She tips her empty glass in contemplation. “I do remember you saying something to that effect a while back, but it still doesn’t make a whole lot of sense.”

“Okay. Let’s try something else, then. You’re done with your drink?”

“Yup.” She puts the empty glass down.

“Perfect, let’s go.” Black slides out of the booth seat.

On the opposite side of the room, Cade, Trip, Geneva and Rayne are seated in the booth adjacent to Cade’s subordinates.

“What do you think of her?” Cade points in Becky’s direction, where Black is guiding her towards the spiral staircase.

“She seems totally out of her element.” Rayne sips her margarita.

“She is, though.” Geneva infers with a shrug. Over at the staircase, she sees Becky and Black descending from the balcony level.

Down on the main level, Black has his hand on the nape of Becky’s neck. He steers her out onto the crowded dance floor. Becky’s sandals disappear into clouds of red smoke billowing across the floor. The house music is much louder, speakers aimed at the bouncing crowd, fueling their energy.

Black takes her further out into the bustling dance floor. He runs his hand down from the nape of Becky’s neck to the middle of her back and turns her around to face him. Putting his arms around her shoulders, he draws Becky in close to his chest and strokes the arch of her back. Black feels her responsive arms clamp around his waist. He bends his head forward to search the crowd, skimming his fingers up Becky’s spine. Focused. He presses his mouth into her temple, canvasses the crowd, and then stops.

A bedeviled frown comes over Becky’s face. A third hand is groping at her ass. When Becky twists around, the hand disappears back into the sea of surrounding people. She blows it off and turns back to Black, who’s looking past her at Reno.

Reno stays close by but intermixes with the springy crowd around them. Colored lights flash in time with the heavy, pounding beat of the music.

Becky gazes up at Black’s smirk through the strobes of light that take his face in and out of the shadows. She catches a hint of the cedary scent coming off of him amidst the nearby tang of body odor and alcohol surrounding them. Out of stark desire for his attention, she glides her hands up from Black’s waist to his chest. Becky clasps the fronts of his toned shoulders. She locks eyes with him.

Reno reaches for the bottom hem of Becky’s dress and pulls up on it. By the time she turns around, her dress is dropped. It falls back into place. Becky whips around to Black and sulks.

“Hey.” He caresses her back through the satiny black fabric. Black bows his head until his temple touches hers. His warm breath passes over Becky’s cheekbone. “Stop paying attention.” Soundly undaunted, he keeps her in check. “Remember anticipation?”

“Yes.”

“What are you in?”

“Anticipation,” she answers through a tremble. Her whisper grazes his jaw. She grasps Black’s shoulders. A band of violet shines down between their chests. His fingers rove alongside the zipper of her dress as a dancing body bounces against her hip.

Being inconspicuous, Black brushes his thigh across the front of Becky's dress over her crotch area, over the white leather thong. "Tell me that's not the softest thing that's ever cradled you." He hears Becky's quiet laugh. "It's even soft when it's not dry, isn't it?"

Becky blushes at his audacity and turns her head. She glosses over the blur of people in front of her. The crowd thickens around them.

Black signals to Reno and seizes this opportunity for discretion. He sweeps his left hand down Becky's side to firmly grab her right hip. Reno moves in close behind her.

"Answer me." Black runs his other hand down Becky's stomach, until he feels the waistband of the leather thong through the fabric of her dress. Tucking his fingers into the front of her dress, he curls them around the waistband and grips it, gently yanking it up.

Becky lurches back a bit, bumping into Reno behind her. She's essentially sandwiched between them to conceal Black's actions. He takes one final survey of the nearby crowd before rolling his calm eyes down onto Becky.

"Isn't it?"

Becky's panting quickens while Black's knuckles slide up and down her lower abdomen, on the outside of her dress. He pulls the thong at different angles to gauge her reaction. When Becky cringes with stifled frenzy, Black knows he hit a good spot.

"You better answer me." He continues tugging on the waistband, rubbing the leather up against her.

"It is." She confesses in a fit of panicky excitement. Reno's chest lightly touches her back.

Black bends his face down in front of Becky's. "Hold still." His shoulder jerks as he wrenches up on the thong. Behind her, Reno's breath hits the base of Becky's neck. He slips his hands up into her armpits and clutches onto her quivering body.

Becky sucks in a sharp gasp of air. Dragging her flared fingers down Black's chest, she grabs handfuls of his charcoal grey shirt. Eyes closed, she goes weak in the knees. Reno tightens his hold on Becky's armpits and catches her.

After her unexpected, bursting orgasm, Becky's eyes flicker open. The horde of people around them goes on as if nothing happened because to them, nothing did. Becky flushes in disbelief.

Shortly thereafter, she finds herself outside in the Club Joy parking lot. Black escorts her between rows of parked cars. He directs her towards an idling Porsche in the lot.

Becky goes up to the passenger side of the Porsche and opens the door. She ducks her head into the car before getting in. Although she never got a good look at Reno in the club, she seems to recognize the interloper's surly vibe. She slides down into the low seat and spots her handbag already on the floormat. She had left it in Black's car on the ride over, but now here it is.

Everything up to her ride home tonight was pre-arranged. Through the windshield, she sees Black heading back inside the club. Becky pulls the car door shut.

***

Brian pushes the car door shut on Rob's sedan parked in the lot of Rumors. "I'm not kidding you." He gets into a short line outside the door with Rob at his side. "I'm done with the bitches at the office." Brian declares.

"Heard that before."

"No, I seriously mean it this time."

"You said that last time, too. Then you started seeing Becky." Rob notes, and the line moves forward. "What I don't get, is how you think you're gonna meet any women here." He thumbs at the roof where the lighted pink sign spells out Rumors Gentleman's Club.

"Because I'm looking for the type that I would meet at a strip club. I need to find a woman who's free, know what I mean?" Brian holds his ID out for the bouncer on his way in. "Open-minded and comfortable with herself." He adds over the fast-paced indie rock song blaring inside.

Rob follows Brian into the tropical-motif strip club. Once they pass the tiki-torch partition, they see the long, main stage on the opposite wall of the club. "And one who is not employed in the sales office at WPC." Rob reiterates.

"Exactly." Brian leads him to the centrally located, sunken bar. The sweet smell of coconut offsets the pong of alcohol in the air.

"Your usual?" Rob sits down in a vinyl lounge chair at the bar to place their order.

"Yeah." Brian stands off to the side of him and scopes out the crowd. Will, a guy with light curly hair who's wearing a leather jacket, passes by him. Will gives Brian a once-over on his way around the bar towards Hannah.

She's over by a fake palm tree that's wrapped in a strand of yellow lights, sipping a martini. Brian is in her crosshairs. Between his searching stare and rolled-back shoulders, the built blonde projects readiness. His 'easy target' vibe brings a devious smile to Hannah's lips.

Will comes up behind her. Closed in on Brian, Hannah asks,

“Well, don’t you think?”

“Too eager.” Will disapproves of her mark.

“That’s exactly what I’m hunting for.” She lectures him. “I need a replacement, not a challenge.”

“I know, but–”

“But nothing.” Hannah circles around the sunken bar, getting ogled by every man bellied up to it in a vinyl lounge chair. She makes eye contact with Brian when she struts by him.

Brian’s gawk stays on Hannah, who opts for seat right in front of the long stage. “Hey,” he bends down to tap Rob on the shoulder. “I’m gonna be over there.”

“Here.” Rob hands him his beer. Brian sets off for Hannah’s table by the stage. He walks up to the empty chair beside her and puts his hand on the back of it.

“Hi, mind if I sit here?” Brian presumptuously sets his beer down on the table.

“Go right ahead.” Hannah picks up her martini while he slides into the chair.

“I’m Brian.”

“Hannah.”

“So, do you work here? On break, or...?”

“No I don’t *work* here.” She advises him in a haughty cadence. “Do I look like I work here?” Hannah points at her conventionally dishy halter dress.

“Not really, but you certainly could.” Brian pans over the long stage. “You’d blow all these women away.” He affirms before zeroing back in on the arresting blonde beside him.

Hannah scoffs at his compliment and sips her cocktail. She concentrates on the middle dancer, who’s bending her knee-high boot around the brass pole.

“It’s not a common thing to find a woman like you, sitting by herself at a place like this, just for the entertainment.” Brian rationalizes.

“A woman like me? You don’t know a thing about me.”

“Tell me about yourself, then.” He urges her.

“Well, I’m not really a fan of the getting-to-know-ya bit. So can we cut to the chase? Cause I don’t really have time to waste on men who get...” she glimpses over at Brian, “...too caught up in the rules.”

“Let’s just cut to the chase, then.” He grins at her.

“Let’s do. What if I told you that I’m a resident Domme at an established, underground BDSM club?”

Brian’s eyes bug out in an equal mix of elation and shock. “I– I’d, just, be thrilled,” he says with a slight pant.

“Is that so?”

“Yeah, very much so.” He makes no effort to conceal his enthrallment. Hannah bores into Brian like she’s systematically diagnosing him. She picks up her martini. A dominatrix-themed stripper holding a braided whip enters the stage in the background.

“You do know what that entails, don’t you?” Hannah takes a sip of her drink and sets the glass back down. The dominatrix stripper cracks her whip.

“Yes I do,” Brian answers with confidence. Still skeptical, Hannah leans back in her chair and looks down the bridge of her nose at him.

“Are you telling me the truth?” she asks.

“Believe me, I’m not naïve about these things. I’m telling the truth.” He doesn’t waver in the least.

“Let’s see about that.” Hannah wants proof. She picks up his beer and spits in it.

Brian reacts properly, swiping it off the table to guzzle away.

“All right, then. Would you like to go check it out?” Hannah propositions him.

“What are we waiting for?”

***

A stony silence ensues in Reno’s Porsche. Becky sits rigid in the passenger seat, biding her time in the uncomfortable but bearable atmosphere by staring out the window. Deadpan as ever, Reno is focused on the road. He begins merging over to the right lane of the freeway to exit.

Becky jumps at the loud sound of Reno’s phone ringing. He pulls it out of his pocket and answers the call.

“Hello?”

“Hi, are you busy?” Shay asks on the other line.

“No, I’m not busy.” He frankly replies.

“I’m gonna need your help with setting up, tomorrow.”

“Tomorrow?” Reno brakes, rolling up to a stop light. “I guess you already took care of the game plan, then.” He checks on Becky out the corner of his eye and sees the back of her head. She’s still staring out the passenger side window. Reno keys back in on the road in front of him.

“We did.” Shay gets him up to speed. “Random and I outlined it earlier tonight. A limo is being dropped off here tomorrow at ten. Meet me there?”

“Sure,” Reno agrees, “see you then.” The stoplight turns green. He steps on the gas.

“Okay, bye.”

“Bye.” Reno ends the call and starts shoving the phone into his pocket. “Oh.” He stops abruptly, pulling it back out. “That reminds me,” he says to himself. Becky peeks over her shoulder at Reno, who’s making a call. He raises the phone up to his ear. “So, how’s it going?” he asks Hannah on the other line...

“You wouldn’t believe me if I told you.” Hannah approaches the elevator on the penthouse level of the Mercer Estate. Holding her phone to her ear, she pushes the ‘down’ button and taps her foot impatiently on the carpeted floor.

“Ahh, this early?” Reno sounds staggered.

“Yeah, it was like a ninety second deal.” The elevator doors open, and Hannah goes in.

Moments later, the elevator doors open on the basement level. Hannah walks out and turns down the grim basement corridor. On the phone, Reno asks her,

“Is he there now?”

“He is.” Hannah stops mid-step. “It’s funny, because things never go this easy for me, you know?” The elevator doors close, and she resumes walking down the corridor of chambers.

“I guess it was kismet.”

“I guess this means you owe me one.” Hannah reminds Reno on the other line...

“Not a problem. In fact,” Reno refers to Becky in the passenger seat, “I’m settling up a debt as we speak.”

“With?” Hannah asks.

“Black.”

When Becky hears this, she goes completely blank. She turns away from the window and faces forward as they near her neighborhood.

“Your track record has taken a beating lately.” Hannah chides him.

“It’s just a game,” he says in stride and ends the call, slipping his phone into his pocket. He steers into the entrance of Becky’s neighborhood. The row of townhomes on her street are quite similar, but he doesn’t slow down until he arrives at hers.

She narrows her eyes. Riveted on the windshield, Becky watches Reno pull into her driveway like he’s been there a hundred times before. She opens the car door and looks back at him over her shoulder.

“Thanks for the ride.”

“Night, Beck.” Reno puts the car in reverse. She scurries out of the Porsche as ladylike as she can and hustles to her front door.

Inside, the floor lamp in the corner is turned on, dimly lighting her quiet living room. Becky kicks off her sandals. She pushes the front door closed and

heads for her desk, dropping her handbag on the floor beside it. Becky disappears into the kitchen and returns with a bottle of water. She sits down in her desk chair, just relaxing for a moment. A tiny smile crosses her lips.

Becky stoops forward in her chair over the keyboard. She opens her email and begins typing a new message to Black.

"Something short and sweet seems appropriate for a non-date," she says to herself. Right after she hits 'send', Becky second guesses herself. She clicks on her inbox. The mouse pointer hovers over Black's reply to the Q&A email from earlier in the day. Becky opens the email and scrolls through it. She stops on a segment that resonates with something he said at the club that night.

Keep in mind that your role in this will always be changing. So if there's a part you don't really like, something different is around the corner.

She reaches over to open a desk drawer and fishes out a pad of paper. Becky sets the notepad down on her desk.

As long as you can take the bad with the good, you'll eventually get to make rules instead of obey them.

Becky picks up a pen that's sitting next to her keyboard. She hunches over the notepad. The tip of the pen hits the paper. Becky starts writing a list of everything she remembers from the day, including Express Courier Services, Ryan the driver, Restaurant–

She hesitates, unable to come up with the name of the restaurant, and switches gears. Becky opens an internet search window and types in 'Express Courier Services California'. She combs through the first page of non-applicable results. Becky clicks on the second page of search results but finds nothing.

"How can it *not exist*?" Her forehead wrinkles with incomprehension. She taps the pen on the notepad and gets back to making her list, mumbling as she goes. "Club Joy, Geneva, Porsche guy...the twins." Becky scowls.

***

Back at Club Joy, upbeat music fills the air. The V.I.P. balcony is still alive with activity. The blonde bartender is lining up shot glasses on the bar. Geneva and Trip are sitting in front of them.

Seated in one of the semi-circle booths are Cade, Black and three of his subs: Marsa, Minya and Kayleigh. The twins are snug up against Black. Next to Minya, Kayleigh sips on a daiquiri drink while Cade finishes sending a message. He sets his phone down on the table. Across the booth from Cade, Marsa rests her head back on the padded bench behind her. She aims her twinkling, diamond-polished nail at Black.

“I want you to collar me, so I can never leave you,” she says to him.

“What?” Black peers at her, obviously a little stunned to hear her say that. “You have had a lot to drink tonight, haven’t you?” He leans over and lightly kisses her forehead.

“No, that doesn’t matter.” Marsa beseeches.

Across the room, Random appears at the top of the spiral staircase. He browses the balcony level crowd before making his way to the bar.

“It has nothing to do with that.” Marsa insists to Black, who reaches for his rum and cola.

“Mm-hmm.” He takes a drink.

“Kids.” Cade remarks about the fickle yearns of people in their early twenties. Black nods at him while Marsa presses on.

“Other Tops do it.”

“And others don’t,” Black tells her.

“Hey.” Cade gets his attention. “Random’s here.”

“He is?” Black skims the nearby booths.

“Over there. Getting a drink.” Cade gestures to the balcony bar where Random is picking up a whiskey on the rocks. He backs away from the bar and sees Rayne passing by.

“Rayne.” Random catches up with her by the iron railing. She spins around to him.

“Hi.” Rayne greets him with a genial wave. “When did you get here?”

“Just now.” He swirls the ice around his glass. “So have you heard from Sam lately?”

She shakes her head. “Not for a few days, why?”

“I was just wondering.” He brushes it off and steps back.

“Hey, why?” Rayne pounces on him. “Is something going on?”

“Nothing bad,” he says, baring an obscure smile. “You’ll find out soon enough.”

“Will I, though?” She looks past Random at Geneva approaching. “Okay, if you say so.” Rayne finishes interrogating him when Geneva joins them.

“I wasn’t expecting to see you, tonight.” Geneva lightly touches Random’s arm.

“I wasn’t expecting to show up.” A rhythmic bass beat thumps through the club. “I spent the evening working out a scene with Shay. We got it done, so I decided to get out for a while.” Random sips his whiskey.

“The one you and I are doing?” Rayne asks him.

“That’s the one.”

“Big job?” Geneva postulates, given that at least Shay, Random and Rayne are all involved.

“Yes, it’s pretty comprehensive,” he elaborates, “plus we’re accommodating a plane flight.”

“I see.”

“How’s your night going?” Random asks Geneva.

“Well, we met Black’s project earlier.” She spills to him, comfortably buzzed.

“Yeah? Any initial thoughts?”

“She was definitely nervous,” Geneva answers. “But also very curious.”

“I’m curious, myself.” Random gives her a parting nod and walks over to Black’s booth.

Seated on the end, Cade glances up at him and shifts over to make room. Six is kind of a squeeze in the semi-circle booth, but Random gets situated on the edge of the seat. He turns to Black, over between the twins.

“How’d it go?” He sets his whiskey down on the table.

“If I hear from Becky after tonight, I think it’s in the bag.”

“Why,” Random sways forward in interest, “what’d you do?”

“I had Reno help me out with a little event on the dance floor and then sent her home with him.” Black has a sip of his drink.

“Why? Are you trying to drive her off?”

“No,” Black sets his glass back down, “but I needed to spend some time with these two.” He reaches up to the twins, on either side of him, and strokes their shoulders.

“Yes, happy birthday.” Random acknowledges them. The twins smile sweetly at him. Minya resumes her chat with Kayleigh beside her. Marsa laces her arm through Black’s and tunes into his and Random’s discussion. “What’s your hunch?” he asks Black.

“My hunch, is that Becky will reconcile tonight in her mind and be ready for round two in a few days.”

“You don’t suffer from any lack of confidence, do you?” Random smiles at Black. It’s an earnest smile, in lieu of his usual sneer. Black notices it.

“Not about this.” He warily studies Random’s show of amity. “What’s with you tonight?”

“I’m in a good mood,” Random tells him. Black tips his head in consideration and asks,

“Oh, what’s that like?”

“It’s a refreshing change. You should try it.”

Before he can respond, Black's phone vibrates in his pocket. "I'll bet you that's Becky." He takes his phone out and unlocks the screen.

"No way." Random discards Black's assumption.

"I have learned a thing about her over the past two months, you know?" Black moves his drink, plants his elbow on the table and holds his phone out to Random. "She sent the message ten minutes ago."

"What does it say?" Cade leans into the phone.

Random reads Becky's email message out loud. "It says, 'Thank you for the evening. Look forward to hearing from you'." He doesn't hide his awe. "Wow," he says and sits back in his seat.

"She wants to play." Cade follows up.

"Persistent and bored." Black shoves his phone back into his pocket. He folds his arms in front of him and shrugs at Random. "They either come around, or they don't."

***

Chamber 7 in the basement of the Mercer Estate is dark and quiet. Hannah's voice gores through the silence.

"You know Brian, I think you really need to get in touch, *with something*, before it just gets too late for you."

"Agreed." His husky response echoes in the darkness. The whoosh of a paddle cutting through the air precedes the smack.

***

Right on schedule, a shiny black limousine sits parked in the driveway of the Mercer Estate, in front of its multi-car garage. Late morning sun bounces off of the chrome trim and wheels.

Inside, Shay and Reno are sitting in back. The stylish interior is well lit by overhead and panel lighting. A large TV screen is mounted above a sleek minibar area. Reno has an open file folder in one hand and a cardboard box of airplane-sized alcohol bottles in his lap.

"Next." Shay sticks out her hand to Reno. He pulls a whiskey bottle out of the box and gives it to her.

"This has to be the most extensive set of target photographs that I have ever seen." He leans in towards Shay. "She knows to look for a limo, right?"

"Of course she does." Shay punctures the neck of the plastic airplane bottle with a syringe, shooting in a dose of golden-green fluid.

“I mean, he’s got daytime shots, nighttime, hair up, hair down, every angle imaginable. The pictures take up more room than the game plan.” Reno flicks the scenario game plan, a couple sheets of paper on the right side of the file, double punched at the top and fastened to the inside of the folder. Meanwhile, a thick stack of photo collages is fastened on the left side. He flips through the photographs and asks, “Where are the x-rays? Fingerprints?”

“I know, he was excessive.” Shay places the little whiskey bottle in the bar compartment. A half dozen bottles are already lined up in the slot. “Wayne’s pretty green. Next, please.”

Reno hands her over another bottle.

“They’ve never actually met in person, so he’s accumulated a lot of pictures.” She explains.

“What, was it an online thing, I take it?”

“Yeah, just over a year.”

“Why wait a year to meet?” Reno glances up from the file at Shay, who’s pushing in the plunger on the syringe.

“They were both wrapping up divorces. I guess they wanted everything finalized before meeting in person.” Shay withdraws the needle and sets the airplane bottle down next to the others. She picks up a small glass bottle to reload the syringe. Shay pokes the needle into the bottle and draws back the plunger, filling the syringe with marijuana tincture.

“Yeah, especially if they went to court.”

“That’s what I gathered.” Shay taps the stem of the syringe with her fingernail.

“I have to say, I am very satisfied with the effect of the THC-laced alcohol.” Reno passes her another bottle. “It puts them out for just the right amount of time, and you don’t have to stress out about dosage.”

“I don’t know if I agree. I’ve had a couple times when the target came around too soon, and I still had to use the anesthetic.” Shay works the tip of the needle beneath the label on the little bottle and carefully stabs it into the plastic.

“Really? They probably didn’t get enough.” The targets do typically pass out before finishing their first drink. “I’ve had good luck with it.” He mentions to her. “Once they conk out, I’ve got a solid hour, if not more.”

“Well, regardless of the chemical, everybody reacts a little differently. Can you imagine trying to make Black pass out from a marijuana tincture?” Shay pulls the needle out of the bottle. “Maybe with an IV?”

“True, different tolerance levels.” Smiling, Reno closes the file and sets it down on the leather seat. Shay slips the bottle of gold tequila into the bar

compartment. Reno digs into the box and holds out a clear vodka bottle. Shay looks at it, and then looks at the syringe of greenish fluid in her hand.

“I need the blue-colored vodka bottle.”

“Oh, right.” Reno chortles at his oversight.

“Smoke on your way down here this morning?”

“I did.” He drops the clear bottle back in the box and pulls out the blue one.

“Uh-huh.” Shay takes the bottle from Reno. “Thank you.” She proceeds to work the tip of the needle into the plastic.

“When do I need to pick her up at the airport, anyway?”

“Monday morning, bright and early.” Shay slowly depresses the plunger on the syringe.

“How early?”

“The plane lands at ten-fifteen. You should be there by ten, just to play it safe.”

“Really?” He groans. “It’s kind of a long drive down there.” Reno will have to be awake, dressed and ready to leave Mercer by 9:00 or so, which is rather early for him.

“The flight is the one thing we did not coordinate.” Shay carefully plucks the needle out of the bottle.

“It’s all right, that’s not too bad. It could be worse.”

***

Sunday afternoon, Black walks past a black shoji room divider shading the recreational half of Cade’s office in his suite at the Mercer Estate. The surge of an explosion bursts out of the room’s surround sound speaker system. Cade glances up at Black while punching the control buttons on the arms of his gaming chair.

“Well good afternoon.” Cade pauses the video game, freezing the battle image on the large screen across from him. Black slides into the matching gaming chair beside Cade. There’s an end table between the two chairs. A red acrylic bong sits on the table. “Welcome back to the land of the lazy.”

“Happy to be back.” Black sets a can of soda down on the table next to the bong. The shelves below the large screen house a ridiculous collection of video games and an extensive library of pornography. Cade has a physical media fetish.

“What took you so long?” Cade goads him.

“Honestly? If you think recruiting a sub is tough, try converting an overactive, ordinary mind into a Top.”

“No thanks.” Cade chuckles before defensively adding, “But this isn’t just any old sub recruit I’m planning, by the way.”

“Of course it isn’t.” Black retorts. “Your one-upmanship is astounding, by the way.”

“I’m not downplaying your pursuit whatsoever. I would never attempt to do what you’re doing.”

“Because you couldn’t.” He reaches over for his can of soda and cracks it open.

“Not too proud to admit that.” Cade professes to him. “I’m fully aware that there’s only one reason I’m here, and it’s that law degree hanging on the wall above my desk over there.” He motions over his shoulder at the wall behind them.

“Necessity versus asset.” Black gibes and takes a drink.

“More or less. Anyway no, I would never try and pull off what you’re doing.” He asks Black for an update. “Have you heard from her since Friday night?”

“No, I think Becky’s smart enough not to blow up my email all weekend. That would rapidly end the game.” Black turns his attention to the large screen across from him. “So are you gonna fire this back up?”

“Hang on.” Their conversation provokes Cade to check his own inbox. “Oh, here it is.” He seizes up at the sight of her reply.

“What?” Black slides his hands down the arms of the chair to the control buttons.

Cade opens the consent form on his screen. “I got the go-ahead.” He posted a comment to his target’s story a week ago before messaging her directly today through the website, making it clear he was a legit user of the site, then extended an invitation to play the game. “She agreed.”

***

That evening, Shay and Hannah converge in the penthouse corridor in front of the door to Hannah’s suite. The word ‘Heretic’ is mounted on her door in antiqued gold letters.

“So, I noticed you have a new one.” Shay shoots Hannah a congratulatory nod.

“Yes I do.” Hannah raves. “He’s totally on board.”

“Impressive. What’s his name, again?”

“Brian.”

“He’s cute.”

“Mm-hmm.” Hannah puckers her fleshy lips in agreement. “He is kind of, isn’t he? Not that it really matters, but yeah.”

“Never know when it might come in handy.” Shay pontificates.

“No, you don’t.” Hannah sees Reno waltzing up to them in the corridor.

“Is the plane still on schedule?” he asks Shay.

“Yes, so you still have to get up early tomorrow, I’m afraid.” She feigns sympathy while resting her shoulder on the doorframe of Hannah’s suite.

“I was just checking.” Reno snarls at Shay and continues down the hallway.

***

The gloss black limousine is parked right outside the revolving doors of the international airport amid a row of taxis, slow-moving cars and travelers passing by on foot. Dressed sharp in a black suit, Reno leans against the limousine. He casually shoves his hands into his pant pockets. Reno scans the people filing out of the revolving doors. He unmistakably spots the target, Jessie, who heads right for the limo. Jessie’s short black hair and tan skin match up perfectly with the array of pictures Reno saw. She’s in a white lightweight sweatshirt and khaki shorts.

Jessie approaches Reno, carrying a bag over her shoulder and pulling a suitcase behind her.

“Jessie?” Reno uses the key fob in his pocket to unlock the trunk.

“Yeah,” Jessie answers him brightly. He opens the back door for her.

“I’m Josh,” Reno says. “Go ahead and have a seat. Let me get those for you.” He takes the handles of Jessie’s luggage so she can climb into the limousine.

Once she gets settled into the backseat, Jessie inspects the posh interior. Everything from the inviting minibar setup in front of her, on up to the television screen is pristine. She notices the dividing window to the front seat is down.

Reno gets into the driver’s seat and pulls the door closed. He flips on the left turn signal and merges into the traffic exiting the airport terminal. Reno glances at Jessie in the rearview mirror.

“Wayne said this is your first time in California. First time meeting each other, actually.” Reno’s small talk is obviously much more information than Jessie expected him to know.

“Oh really, he told you that?”

“Sure, why not?”

“Do you two know each other?” she asks.

“Yeah.”

“Really?” Jessie huffs, stumped by this news.

“Yes, why do you sound so surprised?”

“Well.” After an awkward delay she says, “Wayne’s a doctor.”

Reno looks back at Jessie in the rearview mirror with a brusque smile. “Are you implying he wouldn’t associate himself with a limo driver?”

“Well no, I–” Jessie stammers, “I didn’t mean any offense.”

“I tell you what, Jessie. It’s a pretty long drive, so you may as well fix yourself a drink.” He recommends.

“That sounds like a good idea.” Blushing in embarrassment, Jessie rifles through the spiked bottles of alcohol. She selects the little bottle of dark rum.

“Tell me what kind of music you like. I’ll roll up the window and let you relax.”

“You don’t have to do that. I’m not as arrogant as I came off.” Jessie sets a glass down on the polished shelf in front of her.

“I’ve dealt with a lot worse, trust me.” Reno asserts.

Smiling, Jessie opens the mini fridge and finds an ice bucket inside. She uses the silver tongs to drop a few cubes into her glass. Jessie twists the cap off of the rum and pours it over the ice. She finds a small container of pineapple juice in the refrigerator. After giving it a shake, she fills the rest of her glass with the juice.

“I’m sure you have some crazy stories.” Jessie puts the pineapple juice back in the fridge.

“Most of my clients are professionals, actually.”

“Oh, okay. So you don’t have to deal with the horror of prom nights and wedding parties then, huh?” She picks up her glass.

“No, I mainly deal with arrogance.” Reno’s curt reminder of her earlier gaffe prompts Jessie to start sipping her drink.

This is what Reno was aiming for. He powers on the television in back for her to tune into and waits for the next stage of the game plan to unfold.

In less than ten minutes, Jessie is putting her empty glass into the nearest cup holder. She’s slumped down in the seat with lidded eyes. Quiet and placid, she stares at the television, blinking frequently to keep her eyes open. On the screen, a movie plays at a low volume.

“I cannot believe how bad the jetlag is hitting me. I am sooo tired,” Jessie says through a tranquil yawn.

“Take a short nap.” Reno waves over his shoulder at her. “I’ll wake you up when we get there.”

“Do I have time?” She murmurs, becoming more addled by the second. “I mean, is it worth it?”

“You’ve got a good half hour or more, depending on traffic. Go right ahead.”

“Yeah.” Jessie languidly repositions herself, lying down on the lengthy seat. “I think I need to sleep this off.”

“There’s a pillow in here.” Reno reaches through the window into the back and opens up a compartment door containing pillows and blankets.

“That is excellent.” With suppressed enthusiasm, Jessie pulls a pillow out of the compartment and slides it under her head. When Reno closes the compartment door, his phone begins to ring. Jessie hears it and asks, “Is that Wayne?” in a slurred voice.

“Nope, it’s for me. Get back to your nap.”

“Okay.”

Reno answers his phone. “Hello Shay.”

“How’s it going?”

“Fine. She’s hit the miasmic stage.”

“Miasmic?” Shay laughs. “You’ve been hanging around Black too much.”

“I don’t always have a choice.”

“He’s starting to rub off on you. Anyway, I was just checking in.”

“I’ll let you know when we get there.” Reno ends the call. He can hear Jessie’s slow, deep breaths in the backseat.

***

Meanwhile in the WPC courtyard area, Becky and Jackie are sitting at a shaded table having lunch. Becky picks at her chicken sandwich, stuck in a distracted fog. There’s been no word from Black, not even a response to the email she sent thanking him for Friday night. Becky is openly grasping the concept of ‘anticipation mode’.

“But I thought we should definitely go with the pens.” Across the table, Jackie is in the process of hashing out wedding details. “Don’t you think?”

Becky notices that Jackie’s not talking. She jumps back into the conversation. “I’m sorry Jackie, say that again.”

“For the groomsmen gift, wouldn’t you go with the engraved fountain pen sets?”

“Oh, yeah.” Becky takes a bite of her sandwich. She puts it down and reaches for her phone on the table to refresh her email inbox while Jackie babbles on about the debate surrounding the groomsmen gift.

“And after all that, we end up deciding on the pen sets anyway.” Jackie crooks her head. “In silver, of course.”

“Of course.” Increasingly restless, Becky sets her phone down and gets back to her chicken sandwich.

“So, the only other thing we actually got around to picking up this weekend, were the little...” Jackie’s story fades into the background as Becky zones off again. She hasn’t solved the mystery of the fake delivery van. The delivery driver had a fancy silver fountain pen, much like the pen Jackie was just talking about. Jackie’s voice reemerges into the foreground. “And I think they’ll come together great. Is everything okay, Becky?”

“Yeah,” Becky tells her. “It’s just a Monday thing, you know?”

“Oh!” Jackie sucks in a quick gasp. “That reminds me. Did you hear Brian was a no-show today?”

“No, I did not hear that,” Becky answers, quite surprised.

***

Chamber 3 in the Mercer Estate basement looks remarkably similar to a standard exam room. The nitrous tank in the corner seems a bit out of place, but aside from that, it’s pretty spot on. Framed human anatomy posters hang on the walls. Across from the door is a counter with a small stainless-steel sink and a cabinet down below. The shelves mounted above the sink hold an enema bag and a stack of paper dressing gowns.

The exam table sits in the center of the room. There’s an IV stand on one side of the table and an adjustable floor lamp on the other. Jessie is lying back on the exam table, fast asleep. Her feet are up in the stirrups.

Dressed in a paper gown, Jessie inhales sharply. She comes to just as Random cinches a leather belt around her right ankle. Jessie lifts her head and glimpses around. Her left ankle is already fastened to the stirrup of the exam table. Jessie instinctively tries to sit up, which is when she realizes that her arms are bound to the sides of the table, wrapped with coils of thick white nylon straps.

A shriek of anxiety escapes through Jessie’s mouth. Random feeds the end of the belt into its buckle and pulls it tight. He’s wearing a white jacket. A stethoscope hangs around his neck. Random looks down at Jessie.

“You’re awake. We can get started.”

Chapter 4

“Brian just didn’t show up today?” Outside in the WPC courtyard area, Becky ganders at Jackie across the picnic table. Her half-eaten chicken sandwich sits on the wrapper in front of her.

“Yeah, he didn’t call in or anything. And he’s even got his phone turned off.” Jackie fills her in on the juicy details.

“Really?”

“Uh-huh.” Jackie arches her thin brows. “I guess Gary doesn’t want to make any final decisions or anything yet. He’s giving him until tomorrow to call in.”

“Really?” Becky repeats, tilting her head. “That is so strange. It’s just not like him.”

“I know. As much of a drunk ass as Brian is, he always makes it to work.” Jackie pulls her phone out of her purse to check the time.

Becky continues rambling, stuck in an incredulous funk. “Plus, he’s like best friends with Rob. Why would he leave his phone off?”

“I don’t know, but I need to pop by the restroom on my way back in.” Jackie drops her phone back into her purse.

“What odd timing for Brian to fall off the radar.” Becky muses.

“How so?”

“Nothing, just in general.”

“I’m gonna get moving, then.” Jackie stands up from the table to head inside.

“Okay, I’ll talk to you later.” Becky watches her go and says to herself, “Am I losing my mind?”

“Do you want to lose your mind?” A random co-worker asks Becky in jest, on his way past her table.

“If I haven’t already.”

***

Back in chamber 3, Random leisurely walks over to the counter. Underneath the counter is a leather-upholstered rolling stool.

Jessie takes in her surroundings. Much to her absolute shock, everything about the exam room seems to be appropriate. Her glare darts from the blood pressure cuff hanging on the wall, to Random, who pulls out the rolling stool and has a seat.

“What is this?” she asks frantically. “What am I doing here?”

“You came into town to meet Wayne, correct?”

“*Yeah*.” Jessie’s eyes bulge.

“This is your first time meeting.” He acts very matter of fact. “You need to get checked out.”

“That’s crazy.” She shakes her head. “I don’t even know how I got here.” Jessie tries twisting her upper body, but there’s no give in the nylon straps binding her arms to the sides of the table.

“You passed out in the limousine on your way from the airport. We brought you in here on a stretcher.” Random turns to the counter beside him and opens a drawer.

“No. No, there’s no way I drank enough to pass out. Not like this.” Jessie tries to assess her situation.

Random pulls a pair of latex gloves out of the drawer. “Well, you would’ve wound up here either way.” He snaps on a glove. “Whether you’d have passed out or not.”

“Why? And why am I tied down? *Why*?” Jessie’s frustration escalates.

“Because you were unconscious.” Random calmly pulls on the other latex glove. “And I knew you’d be disoriented. I didn’t want you to fall off the table. Safety first.” He quips, rolling the stool in closer to her. The paper gown is draped down between Jessie’s open knees.

“No, this isn’t right.” She stresses, clenching her fists. “Where is Wayne? Is he here?”

“He is, but he asked me to do the exam.”

“I don’t... Are you even a real doctor?”

Highly insulted, Random says, “Of course I am,” in a way that extinguishes any doubt.

On the other side of the door to chamber 3, Rayne is dressed in a pair of light blue scrubs, waiting for her cue. She rests her hand on a stainless-steel cart. The tray on top of the cart holds a variety of medical instruments, including hemostats, a thermometer, gauze and a speculum.

Inside the chamber, Random turns to the metal door and calls out,

“Rayne!” He turns back to Jessie. “And he knows exactly where you are.”

The door opens, and Rayne backs into the chamber bringing the cart inside. After pushing the cart over to Random, Rayne closes the chamber door behind her.

Rayne’s arrival gives Jessie a spark of hope. “Please, help me.” She begs her.

“Help you what?” Rayne asks, genuinely bemused.

“Untie me, I’m awake now. I don’t need this.” Jessie wriggles her strapped arms and jerks her ankles. The belts dig into the tops of her bare feet.

“It’s just better this way,” Rayne tells her in a staid tone.

“It is?” She blurts back.

Random swivels his stool around to the stainless-steel cart beside him. “Believe me.” He looks over his shoulder at Jessie, flaunting a frank expression. “I’ve done this a lot.”

“Why didn’t Wayne tell me about this?”

Random picks up a tube of lubricant from the steel tray and places it onto the thick, blue paper towel alongside some swabs in sealed tubes. “Don’t be coy,” he says with an errant smile. “Think I don’t know why you’re in town?”

“Where is he?” Jessie asks, noticeably quieter.

“Maybe, eight feet away.” Random reveals.

On the wall above the counter is a large rectangular box with a metal frame. The opaque white film in the frame makes it appear to be an x-ray light box. It’s actually a viewing window for the observation booth on the other side of the wall...

Inside the chamber 3 observation booth, a laminated counter runs along the length of the small room. Speakers are mounted on the walls and LED strips along the floorboards light up the perimeter.

Jessie’s voice comes through the speakers, asking, “He’s eight feet away?”

Shay, Geneva and Wayne sit in desk chairs at the counter, supervising the exam room. Wayne is outright captivated by the scene playing out in the chamber. Shay nudges him and whispers,

“It’s almost time for you to go in.”

Wayne nods but stays fixed on Jessie...

On the other side of the observation booth window, Random is standing next to the exam table. “I’ve been telling you he’s right here.”

“Then he can hear me.” Jessie assumes.

“Yeah, he can hear you.” Random walks over to the nitrous tank in the corner. He picks up the mask and hands it over to Rayne, who encourages Jessie to make the most of the experience.

“He’ll hear you if you want to scream a little.” Rayne puts the mask on her.

“Got an idea of what’s happening now, Jessie?” Random pushes the power button on the nitrous machine. It expels a faint hum.

“I do.” She decompresses when Random twists the dial on the machine’s instrument panel. After all, Wayne’s contract didn’t specify who would be initiating the scene.

***

The guest rooms on the main floor of the Mercer Estate are designed exactly like any customary upscale hotel room. Contemporary canvas prints hang on the walls, and two tall, brushed aluminum lamps sit on the sleek dresser. The ivory sheers covering the windows filter the afternoon sun.

Relocated to the guest room, Jessie lies on the king-size bed with a white sheet wrapped around her naked body, peaceful and content. Waking up tied to the exam table in chamber 3 a few hours earlier seems to be a distant memory for her.

“You’re not too upset with me, are you?” Wayne asks from his chair by the window, behind Jessie in the background.

“I was never upset with you. That was an intense scene.” She swoons. “I was scared shitless for a while there, but not upset.”

“Well, I’m glad you’re here,” he tells her.

“I am too.” Jessie rolls over to face Wayne and asks, “Where are we, exactly?”

***

Back downstairs in chamber 3, Geneva wanders through the open door to find Random sitting by himself on the rolling stool beside the exam table, sending a message.

“Still down here?”

Random glances up from his phone at Geneva. “I’m just waiting for the cleanup crew to show up.”

“So what ended up happening?”

“Nothing. I knocked her out and Wayne took over.” He thumbs at the observation booth window in confusion. “I thought you were in there.” Random sets his phone down on his knee and rests his elbow on the edge of the exam table.

“I was, but I left the booth at the same time Wayne did.”

“Oh, well it was all recorded if you’re interested.”

She chuckles at him. “I’m not that interested, thank you.” Geneva sees Random’s phone light up with a reply message. “If you’re busy then come find me later.”

“No, it’s just Cade. He wants to meet with me this afternoon.” Random pats the exam table. “Have a seat.”

Geneva snubs his offer, considering what likely happened on that exam table earlier. “I’m fine standing.” She maintains her decorous stance near the open doorway.

“What’s up?”

“There’s a personal situation brewing with Trip. He’s been really private about it, and I don’t mean to disrespect his privacy, but if anyone should be made aware, it’s you.”

“I’ve been wondering about him.” Random shuts off his phone screen. “Shay’s been tightlipped.”

“He asked us not to say anything. But the situation’s coming to a head, and this house doesn’t lend itself to privacy.” Geneva waits for him to tuck the distraction of his phone into his pocket and focus on her. “His father is in the hospital.” She discloses. “It’s a matter of time, and Trip is the only next of kin. So he’ll be going back to Oklahoma soon, which concerns me.”

“Hmm.” Random looks down for a moment and then back up at Geneva. “I appreciate you bringing that to my attention, but what can we do?”

“Well, I agree that there’s nothing we can do to derail the train, but I don’t have a good feeling about this at all. I think it’s naïve to be unprepared for some sort of repercussion from this trip.”

“We’ll have to deal with it when the time comes. Who knows what’ll end up happening.” Random bluntly states. Geneva nods at him and turns towards the doorway to leave the chamber.

Once she’s gone, Random heads upstairs to Cade’s office in his suite on the penthouse level.

***

Cade is seated at his mahogany desk in the non-recreational half of his office with his back to a bay window. He’s in the midst of his meeting with Random, who’s across from him in a leather armchair with a frown on his face. A manila file folder lies out on the desk. The sunny office setting is a conspicuous contrast to the obvious friction between them.

“You know we’re crossing a line with this one.” Random tenses his jaw.

“She signed off on a contract.” Cade retaliates. “She just doesn’t know who it’s with.”

“Because it’s not our standard contract.”

“No, it’s not. It’s a personal job, personal contract.”

“Mm-hmm.” Much like Random’s, Cade’s private corner office has a view of the woods on the west side of the property. “She’ll never see this coming.”

“They never do.” Cade sinks back in his desk chair and gives a dismissive, borderline sarcastic response. “I mean, you *just* did one over lunch. Was she expecting to see you when she came to in chamber three?”

“This is completely different.”

“No it’s not. The reason targets are caught off guard isn’t because they didn’t agree to a scene. It’s because they don’t know when or where it’s going to happen. The element of surprise is the core selling point.”

“You just made my next argument. Every scenario we’ve done has been legitimately pre-arranged. And we’re compensated to perform the service.” Random picks up the file folder and holds it up in the air. “This is an anonymous, personal pursuit. If anyone should sweat that detail, it should be you,” he drops the file on the desk between them, “our resident lawyer.”

Unshaken, Cade rests his elbows on the arms of his chair and laces his fingers together. “I am confident about this. If I wasn’t confident, I wouldn’t pursue it.”

“So basically, you believe that she’ll eventually be copacetic with your version of what she signed up for, and that’s good enough for you?”

“Worst case scenario, she’ll have no way to identify any of us. And we will have committed no actual crime.”

Random’s annoyance soars. “What if there’s an unnoticed camera somewhere along the way? And you don’t think a single trace of DNA will be left on her? I find that hard to believe.” His gnarl bites through his guise of equanimity.

“You read the game plan, right?” Cade bends forward over the desk, equally tenacious. “There won’t be a significant source of DNA. And I’ve already thought out the defense if the need arises.” He taps his fingers on the file folder. “This sets the chain of events off in our favor. There’s no actual crime.”

“I don’t think that’s a true statement.” Random argues, shaking his head.

“It can be.” Cade relaxes back in his chair. He valiantly challenges Random. “So are you in?”

“Of course I’m in.”

***

Sitting at her desk in her office at WPC, Becky’s in the middle of a routine check for personal email messages on her phone.

“Knock knock,” Jackie says from the doorway. Becky puts her phone away in her purse while Jackie slips into the office. She’s carrying a small stack of mail, which she passes to Becky across her desk. “Do you have any outgoing, tonight?”

“Not today, thank you.” Becky takes the mail from Jackie. She slides the stack of envelopes into her Tuesday bin to deal with tomorrow morning.

“So, I totally forgot to ask you at lunch.”

“Ask me what?”

“Did you meet up with your mystery guy this weekend?” Jackie loiters near the office door.

“Yeah, we went out to dinner and to a club,” Becky answers casually.

“How was it?”

“It was good. I mean, we’re not rushing into anything. We just hung out.”

“Uh-huh.” Jackie loafs back against the wall and waits for Becky to give a juicy report, but she doesn’t. “Well you were so excited on Friday that I figured you’d be full of stories, today.”

Becky nods in understanding of Jackie’s expectations but simply doesn’t have a customary response. “I guess I’m just doing things different this time around. He doesn’t want to be a rebound relationship, and I don’t want that either.”

“So then where’d you go?”

“Luciano’s for dinner, and then we met up with some of his friends at Club Joy.” Becky did eventually come up with the name of the restaurant after doing some searching.

“Wow.” Jackie lights up in approval. “Super nice restaurant and face time with his friends, huh? Sounds like he’s serious.”

“Yeah, you could say that.” Becky has a secretive grin on her face. “We had a really good talk during dinner, and we both agreed it was best to take things slow.”

“I can tell it’s serious because you’re being stingy with the details. But that’s okay, I can be patient.” With a knowing smile, Jackie pushes away from the wall and turns to leave the office.

Becky’s learning all about being patient, herself. It’s five o’clock on Monday, and she still hasn’t heard a word from Black.

***

The front door to Black’s suite is wide open. He walks out of his office into the modern living room, slipping on his tennis shoes. Black stops when he hears Hannah talking. She’s out in the penthouse corridor.

“Oh, he snapped like a twig.” She brags about Brian to Reno, who’s walking alongside her. “It surprised me how fast, actually.” When the two of them pass by the open door to his suite, Black calls out,

“Hey Reno, wait up.”

Reno backs up and stands in the doorway while Hannah dashes across the corridor to make a pit stop in her suite on the other side.

“When is your next appointment with Alice?” Black asks him.

“Tomorrow at eleven, why?”

Black reaches into his pocket and pulls out a phone. “I know it’s asking a lot, but I need you to set Becky up with the phone.” He tosses the phone to Reno. He promptly catches it.

“No problem, I still owe you anyway. You want this to happen tomorrow?” Reno shoves the phone into his pants pocket.

“At the tattoo parlor.” He specifies.

“During my appointment?”

“She hates needles.” Black smirks and leans against the back of his grey sectional. “I thought it’d be funny.”

“Sure.” Reno agrees. “What do you want me to make her do?”

“Your pick.”

“My pick? She won’t like it,” he says sardonically.

“I guess that’s the point.”

Reno looks at Black with a cynical gleam. “Are you sure you’re trying to recruit her? Because you know that I’ll come up with something she might say no to.”

“That’s ultimately her choice.” Black folds his arms in front of him. He doesn’t appear to be concerned.

“As you wish.” Pert as always, Reno sets off down the corridor in the direction of the elevator. He passes by Shay, who’s heading in the opposite direction towards Trip’s suite.

Trip’s front door is cracked, so Shay pushes it open and goes inside. She steps between the two bushy floor plants that sit on either side of his door. Across the room, a band of tangerine sunset peeks through closed drapes which are striped with gold, olive and brown tones. Shay sees Trip sitting on the overstuffed olive-colored couch in his living room. The TV is turned onto an old black & white movie, but the volume is muted. Shay has a seat in one of the two chocolate brown recliners that sandwich the couch.

“Hi.” Trip has his phone in his face. His socked feet are propped up on the coffee table.

“Did you hear something?” she asks him.

“Yes, I’m booking my flight.” He slouches back into the couch and runs his fingers through his hair.

“Do you want me to go with you?”

“No,” he answers dismally.

“How about handling the Q and A around here?” Shay offers.

“Yeah, that would be nice.” Trip shows Shay his appreciation then gets back to his phone. “In fact, would you mind telling Geneva that I’m leaving?”

“She knows about your dad?”

“Geneva always knows.” He shrugs. “She pried it out of me the other day.”

“Okay. I assume everything’s under control in your suite, here?”

“Yeah, they know I’m leaving. They’ll be fine.” Trip bites at his lower lip while scrolling through flight itineraries. A few silent moments pass.

Shay gazes at the muted television. “If you decide you need anything else, you know where to find me.” She gets up out of the recliner and walks to his suite door.

“Thanks Shay.”

“Take care,” she says quietly on her way out. When she steps into the penthouse corridor, Shay pulls Trip’s door closed and sees Hannah coming out of her own suite across the hall.

“Hey, you look somber.” Hannah glimpses over at Trip’s suite door. The word ‘Veracity’ is mounted on his door in polished chrome letters. “Is something going on with Trip?”

“His dad is in the hospital.” Shay whispers.

Hannah grows concerned. “Like critical, or...?”

“Unfortunately,” she tells her. “And you know how he gets when it comes to his dad.” Shay notices the blank pang on Hannah’s face, so she spells it out for her. “He clams up. They’re pretty much estranged.”

“Oh, right.”

“Which makes it difficult.”

“I’m sure it does.” Hannah gushes. “Poor kid.” After an empathetic sigh, she wraps it up. “I hate to leave on this note, but I left someone hanging.” She shares before parting ways with Shay. Hannah rides the elevator down to the main floor and goes outside to the Mercer Estate pool area.

Outside, the sunset has given way to a star-filled sky. Hannah walks through the cool night air. Off to her right, the outdoor seating area on the east end of the patio glows beneath strands of bulbs wound around its pergola roof. On her left, the light radiating up from the sunken hot tub is hazy with steam.

In the middle of the limestone patio, flames dance inside of a round fire pit. Black, Ryan, Kayleigh and Cade are seated around the fire pit in white Adirondack chairs, enjoying an after-dinner bonfire. A splash from the nearby pool is heard, followed by the sound of a female squealing with laughter. Black takes a drink of his coffee and sets the clear glass mug down on the ground next to his chair. He turns to Cade.

“So, you’re finally pulling the trigger on the elusive abduction plan.”

A fiery young redhead, known as the Spinner, comes over from the pool to join them. Water drips from her wavy hair while she towels herself off.

“I am, yes.” Cade responds to Black, ignoring the Spinner’s presence.

“Am I in it?” Ryan asks.

“No, sorry, I didn’t have a part for you.” Cade glances over at the Spinner sliding into the empty chair next to him. “Oh, look who’s here,” he says in a blasé tenor. Draping her towel over her lap, the Spinner inches her chair closer to him. Cade shoots her an objectionable leer, which does not seem to deter her.

“Cade!” Hannah yells on her way over to the fire pit.

“Yeah?” He watches Hannah weave in between Black and the Spinner. She rests her hand on the back of the Spinner’s chair.

“I need a favor.”

The Spinner’s pixie-like face lights up in anticipation.

“What’s that?”

“Let me borrow your Spinner.”

“Only if you keep her,” Cade answers.

Rolling her eyes at him, Hannah holds out her hand to help the Spinner up out of her chair. “Sorry about the short notice.” She twirls away from the fire pit and struts off. The Spinner tosses her towel on the chair, following Hannah.

“Hey, anytime!” Cade points at Hannah. “I mean that.”

Hannah leads the enthusiastic redhead to the patio door and into the house.

Soon, the two of them are stepping out of the elevator into the basement corridor. Hannah guides the bikini clad and barefoot Spinner down the hallway of chamber doors, stopping in front of number 7. Fugazi’s “Waiting Room” is playing inside the chamber and can just barely be heard in the basement corridor. Hannah stands at the metal door with her hand on the knob and instructs the Spinner.

“Hands only, and DO NOT even *think* about finishing him.”

The Spinner goes to protest, but Hannah’s blaze of hostility stops her.

Hannah opens the door. She steps inside, and the alert redhead trails her in. Chamber 7’s cold atmosphere is anchored in its cement floors and cinderblock walls, offset only by the candles burning in the wall sconces. Hannah walks to the purple velvet chair over in the corner. The Spinner moves through the small chamber to Brian.

A wide eyehook is bolted into the cinderblock wall. Two thick chains hang down from the hook. The chains are attached to a pair of metal cuffs. Brian’s wrists are shackled in the cuffs above his head. His eyes are masked. His head is

resting against the cinderblock wall behind him. He's sitting on the cold cement floor with his legs outstretched, dressed only in his striped boxer shorts.

Seated in the purple velvet chair, Hannah waits for the Spinner to creep up on Brian before she shuts the loud music off.

Brian's head perks up. "Hannah?"

The Spinner snickers softly and crouches down beside him.

"I was starting to think you were just gonna leave me like this." Brian sniffs the air around her. "You smell like chemicals."

She sways in closer to Brian. Her balmy breath hits his cheek.

Brian turns his face towards hers. "Hannah?" He's nose to nose with the Spinner when she responds,

"I'm not Hannah."

Brian reels back in surprise. The Spinner rakes her short nails down his bare chest.

"Who are you?"

"I'm a lot of fun," she answers in a sultry growl.

"I'll bet you are, but, uh."

The Spinner sweeps her hand down Brian's stomach. "But what?" She reaches for his groin.

"Whoa, what are you doing?" Brian's body stiffens as she takes him into her hand.

The Spinner giggles and tightens her hold on him.

Brian starts to squirm. He bends his knees up, pinning her wrist between his thigh and abdomen. "You gotta knock that off." He's adamant.

"I don't want to."

Brian gasps out an uncomfortable laugh. "It truly pains me to say this, but you have *got* to cut it out." He rattles his shackles above his head. "If I could, I'd stop you myself."

"Why?" She squeezes him harder. "Why do you want me to stop?"

"Because you're not Hannah," he says straightforward.

The Spinner lets go and pulls her hand out of Brian's boxers. His legs slide back out onto the cement floor in front of him.

Beaming with triumph, Hannah rises from the purple chair. The Spinner stands up, and Hannah nonverbally excuses her from the chamber. The dispirited redhead leaves, pulling the metal door shut behind her with a bang. Hannah walks up to Brian.

"Hey!" He shouts. "Are you still in here?"

Hannah stands between Brian's outstretched legs. "I never left."

"See, I knew it." He rests his masked head back on the cinderblock wall...

Outside the chamber 7 door, the Spinner waits hopefully for Hannah to call her back in. She looks down the empty basement corridor. Puffing out a little sigh, she presses her ear up to the metal door to try and hear what's going on inside the chamber. She can't hear a thing. Enough time passes to give up on the idea of being invited back in. She slogs towards the elevator to head upstairs and out to the pool area...

Back outside by the fire pit, Ryan reaches down the side of his Adirondack chair for the beer bottle sitting on the ground beside him. He picks it up and has a swig, seeing the Spinner trot across the limestone patio back to the pool. She crosses paths with Trip, who has a bottle of wine in his hand.

In the chair next to Ryan, Black hands a half-smoked joint over to Kayleigh beside him. He blows out a cloud of smoke and says, "Something is definitely going on with Random." His comment is directed at Cade.

"Yeah, I noticed." Cade takes the joint from Kayleigh and turns to Black. "What's that about?"

"I don't know. I've been trying to figure it out." Contemplation washes over Black. "It has something to do with Becky. The only thing I can come up with, is this is the first time I've tried to recruit a Top. He's done it before, so maybe he's hovering around to watch me fail."

Cade exhales a lungful of smoke. His face pinches with doubt. He leans forward in his chair. "He doesn't seem to want you to fail." Cade passes the joint over Kayleigh's lap to Black.

"True." Black takes the joint from Cade. He picks up the ashtray sitting on the arm of his chair.

"And I doubt he just suddenly wants to be your friend."

Black taps the joint into the ashtray, smiling. "No, I'm sure he doesn't." But he has been jovial lately. "Something's going on."

***

Tuesday morning, Becky carries a steaming mug of coffee into her office. She sets it on her desk and has a seat. Rob appears in her doorway, placing his hand on the doorframe.

"Hey, Becky."

"Hey." She rolls her chair up to her desk.

"I know this is a longshot, but you haven't heard from Brian, by any chance?"

"No, I haven't." Becky confirms. "I take it you haven't, either."

"Nope, his phone's been turned off."

“Still?”

“Yeah, it’s been like four days. I’m gonna leave early for lunch and swing by his apartment.”

“Have you been by there yet?” she asks, and Rob nods.

“I stopped over last night on my way home. Nobody there.” He exchanges a baffled frown with Becky.

“Hmm. Well, good luck.”

“Thanks.” He slides his hand down the doorframe. “I’m getting pretty worried.”

“I’m sure.”

Rob leaves her office and roams down the hall.

***

In the meantime, steam billows from the surface of the Mercer Estate’s bubbling hot tub. Black, Cade and Hannah are all present for their morning hot tub ritual. Expelling a satisfied sigh, Hannah flings an empty banana peel over her shoulder. Black takes a drink of his espresso and sets the cup down next to his phone.

“So.” Hannah keys in on him. “You’re doing what today, again?”

“I’m setting Becky up with a phone. Reno is, actually.”

With breathy impudence she says, “Ooh, big step,” and smirks at him.

“I see you’re feeling smug this morning. Maybe because your new recruit’s been stashed away in chamber seven for the past four days?”

“Mm-hmm.” Hannah reaches for her phone and taps the screen, pulling up the live feed from chamber 7.

“I’m surprised it’s been available this whole time.” Cade notes.

“I know, impeccable timing on my part.” She winds around to Black.

“I’ll have to meet him sometime, if you ever let him out.” He watches Hannah swoop in towards him, holding her phone out over the rippling water.

“Well, here he is.” She hands him her phone.

Black takes it and sees Brian balled up in the purple velvet chair with a blanket pulled up over his head. “That’s nice that you allow him on the furniture.” Black hands her phone back. Hannah purses her lips inquisitively.

“Too generous?” She shuts off the display and sets the phone down on her towel.

“When are you moving him into your suite?” Cade asks her.

“Today is his lucky day. I figured it was only right to give him a bedroom today, since I’m taking away his old one.” She jeers.

“You’re moving him out of his apartment today?”

“As we speak.”

***

Rob parks his Chevy sedan on the street in front of Brian’s apartment building. He gets out of his car and curiously scrutinizes the moving truck parked further up the street. Rob walks to the door of Brian’s building...

Inside Brian’s small apartment, a stack of boxes sits by the front door. His kitchen counters are bare. A queen-size box spring is leaning against the wall in the hallway. Most of his furniture has been moved out of the living room, except for the couch against the wall and the TV stand across from it. Will and Farrin are in the process of packing up Brian’s apartment.

“I’ll get the rest of the furniture pulled out of here.” Farrin, a tall black man with a muscular physique, veers off into Brian’s bedroom.

“Okay.” Hunkered down behind the TV stand, Will pulls a series of plugs out of a power strip. Brian’s furniture and anything that won’t fit into his bedroom in Hannah’s suite is going into a storage unit.

Farrin comes back into the living room carrying a nightstand. He takes it over to the front door. The doorbell rings. It startles Farrin. The nightstand slides out of his hands and hits the floor with a thud.

“Brian? You okay?” Rob asks from the other side of the door.

Farrin looks down at Will, who’s looking up at him from his knelt position on the floor behind the TV stand. They both remain quiet and still.

Rob begins knocking on the door. “Brian, it’s Rob. I hear you in there. Open the door, man.”

Farrin backs away from the front door. He gets Will’s attention and points at the door. Farrin mouths the words, ‘it’s open’ while twisting his hand in a turning motion. Will nods and quickly pulls the power cord out of the back of the television.

Rob knocks harder on the door. “It’s just me. You can open the door.”

A couple seconds pass. Farrin is fixed on the doorknob. Will is looping the cord around his hand.

“Listen, I just want to know if you’re all right.”

The doorknob turns. Will stands up, and Farrin moves towards the door.

“Here.” Will whispers and tosses the cord to Farrin. When the apartment door opens, Farrin steps behind it. He wraps each end of the cord around his hands, hiding silently behind the door.

Rob walks into the apartment and gapes at Will, completely stumped. “Who are you?”

“A friend of Brian’s.” Will slips his hands into the pockets of his jeans. Rob hesitates like he’s not buying it.

“I know Brian’s friends, and I *don’t* know you.” Scanning the barren apartment, Rob accosts Will. “Looks to me like you’re cleaning him out.”

Farrin kicks the door shut. Alarmed, Rob whips around to him. Farrin lunges forward and wraps the cord around Rob’s chest and arms. He easily spins Rob’s body around and knots the cord behind his back.

“What the hell?” Rob yells. He jerks forward, but he’s no match against Farrin’s firm grip.

“Lower your voice.” Farrin pushes Rob down onto his knees and puts pressure on the center of his back, guiding Rob’s face to the floor. He places his knee on Rob’s shoulder blades to pin him down. With the loose ends of the cord, Farrin binds Rob’s wrists together behind his back.

Rob looks over his shoulder at Farrin, exposing the fear in his eyes. “What’s happening?” he asks in a hysterical whisper. “Why are you doing this?”

***

Back in the hot tub, Hannah’s blue eyes come alive with excitement while she articulates the genius intuition behind her new recruit. “Guys like Brian react purely on their calculation of someone else’s personality, whoever they’re dealing with at the time. So there’s not much self-originating thought going on up there to contend with, you see?”

Cade nods in humor as he courteously listens to Hannah detail her assessment of Brian. Black is busy on his phone.

“Hey, are you even listening?” Hannah barks at Black.

“Yes, I’m listening. Continue.”

She does. “What he lacks in independent thought, he makes up for in clumsy devotion, like a relentless idiot.” In her dramatic panache, Hannah cups her dripping palms under her chin, strumming her fingertips together. “There’s no need for the detachment process when you’re dealing with a salesman. They come that way,” she interlocks her fingers and folds her hands together into a gun formation, “pre-programmed to shoot for the rush.” Hannah aims her index finger gun barrel at Cade. She raises her fingers in a firing motion.

“Disconnected from pride.” Cade chuckles.

“And always up for the challenge.” She affirms and turns to Black. “What are you doing, anyway?” Hannah lowers her hands back down into the bubbling

water.

“I’m hacking into the settings for an email account, so I’ll know exactly when a specific message has been opened.”

“So, stalking?”

Black addresses her allegation with an irreverent stare. “For a purpose, yes.”

She smiles at Black. Her phone begins to ring in her Nine Inch Nails “Happiness In Slavery” ringtone. Hannah appears mildly concerned. “Hmm, that’s Will.” She grabs her phone and answers the call. “Yeah?” On the other line, Will says,

“We have a problem.” Hannah’s mouth curls down in dismay. Will keeps talking. “Brian’s friend came over here searching for him, and we had to restrain him.”

“How did he get inside?” she asks.

“The door was unlocked.”

“And why is that?”

“We were getting ready to take down a load,” Will tells her.

Hannah spins around in her seat, resting her elbows on the edge of the hot tub. “It seems pretty quiet over there.”

“He’s subdued at the moment.”

“What’s his name?” Hannah reaches for her towel.

“Rob.”

She stands up and proceeds to step out of the tub with her phone to her ear. Water glides down her tan legs.

“This is unlike you, Will. I expect you to be able to handle things like this.”

“Well, this isn’t a controlled situation. I need some direction.”

Holding her towel in front of her body, Hannah marches to the house. “You just tell Rob to sit tight.”

Black and Cade look at one another. Once Hannah is out of earshot, Cade says,

“Sounds like somebody dropped in.”

“Evidently.” Black shifts his attention back onto his phone. “In the meantime...”

***

Becky is in her office, concentrating on her computer screen and clutching her coffee mug. Down below inside her purse, her phone chimes. She sets the coffee mug on her desk and bends down to get her phone out.

“It’s about damn time, Black.” When she reads the email title, ‘Don’t read this until you get home’, Becky scoffs. She immediately taps open the email and reads Black’s message:

Typical Becky, and you wonder why I waited so long to contact you. We’ll see if you can get serious before my patience runs out.

“That’s it?” She scrolls further down the screen, but there’s nothing more to see. Becky’s work phone rings. She drops her phone into her purse and reaches across her desk to pick up the receiver. “Becky Martin.”

“You couldn’t wait two seconds to open that email, could you?”

Stupefied by the accusation, Becky quickly realizes who it is on the other line. “Black? How did you–”

“You get one chance to redeem yourself.”

“Seriously?” Becky’s question is followed by a lull of silence on the line. “Okay, what can I do?”

“When you leave for your lunch break, I want you to go two blocks south on Ninth Street and turn right. There’s a tattoo parlor about three doors up from the corner.”

“Yeah, Exotica, I know where that is.”

“Be there at noon. You’re not meeting me.”

“Who am I meeting, then?”

The line goes dead. Becky slowly hangs up the phone. The clock on her computer reads 11:11 a.m.

***

“Well now, this is no way to treat a friend of Brian’s.” Hannah circles around Rob on the living room floor of Brian’s apartment. He’s lying on his stomach with his arms bound behind his back and duct tape over his mouth. Rob’s head is turned to Hannah. He peers up at her with a hint of familiarity. “Get him up on his feet and sit him down on the couch.” Hannah meanders over to the couch.

Farrin clenches onto Rob’s elbow and pulls him up onto his feet. Hannah takes a seat on one end of the couch while Farrin steers Rob over there. Rob stumbles down onto the couch cushion and lands in a sitting position. Shaking his head in agitation, he huffs through his nose.

“Don’t get testy, or I won’t take off the tape.” Hannah warns him then advises Will. “We’re all leaving here at the same time, so finish up.”

Will joins Farrin back in the bedroom where they continue packing boxes.

Reaching for his face, Hannah speaks to Rob in a calm and forthright manner. “I talked to Brian about you on my drive over here.” Her manicured nail

picks at the corner of the duct tape covering Rob's mouth. "He said I could be straight with you, that you've known him at his best and his worst." Hannah makes eye contact with him. She grabs onto the corner of the tape. "Ready?" she asks and starts peeling the tape off. Rob slams his eyes shut.

"Ahh– ow." He gasps in pain and blinks a few times. He twitches his mouth.

"Here." Hannah leans in towards him. "I bet you wish you could scratch that." She gently runs her nails around Rob's mouth and across his cheeks. "He said you're a really good friend. One who would try and understand why he did what he did."

"Is he coming back?" Rob sounds unnerved.

Hannah pulls her hand away from his face and eases back into the couch cushion. "Well, he never really left. So, in a sense, yes. But is he coming back here?" She holds up her hands and gestures around the apartment. "No." Hannah relaxes her hands down into her lap. "And he won't be back to work."

"So how come?" Rob grows insistent. "I know he's like a magnet to weird shit, but what exactly has he gotten himself into?"

"The alternative lifestyle, it's what he was looking for."

Rob listens but has a pessimistic scowl on his face.

"I know it might seem like I just," Hannah shrugs, "snatched him from the strip club that night, but he was a completely willing participant from the get-go."

"To the extent of walking out on his job of seven years, shutting off his phone and letting strangers pack up his apartment?" Rob's inflection is dubious. "I know you know what I mean here, right?" He probes her.

"I do." Hannah reassures him. "I completely understand how it must look. In fact, that's why I'm talking to you first. Brian can tell you how he feels about all of this, and he will, but if you're looking for intelligible answers, I have them."

"How do you know how Brian feels better than him, when you just met him four days ago?"

"Because I'm more familiar with this process in general. I've gone through it with many other people."

In the bedroom, Will is ripping the duct tape. Rob flinches at the sound.

"The basic reasons why people get into this lifestyle are similar." Hannah explains. "I get why Brian wanted to leave with me that night. And he did know what he was getting into. We discussed it before we ever left the club."

"And he knew, at that moment, that he'd be abandoning his whole life? I'm sorry, but I find that hard to believe." Rob disputes her.

"That's fine. He'll tell you himself. In his own words, which, lack eloquence but may at the very least convince you that Brian's actions are entirely of his

own accord. And maybe that's all you really need to understand at this point."

***

It's going on lunch hour and they don't serve food, so there are only a handful of people in the small, neighborhood sports bar. Most of them are seated at the bar, watching one of several muted television screens hanging all over the walls.

Rob is at a cocktail table by himself. Anxiously waiting, he swirls the whiskey around in his glass. His phone is sitting in the middle of the table. Finally, it begins to ring. The call comes in as 'unavailable'. Rob answers his phone on the first ring. "Hello?"

"Hey Rob, what's up?" Brian's carefree attitude comes through on the other line.

"What's up?" Rob's fingers grip down around his phone. He responds in a low, irate roar. "Your phone's been off for the past four days. Two strange guys in your apartment jumped me and tied me up earlier today." Highly sarcastic, he asks, "What's up with *you*?"

"Yeah, sorry about that."

"I am so freaked out that I actually waited in a public place for you to call, because I'm scared to go home." Rob admits, guileless and sweaty.

"Oh no, don't be. That's ridiculous."

"Is it?" His nervous eyes flit around the bar. "I'm not so sure. I don't know what you got yourself mixed into, but these people are serious."

"You do not have to worry about going home, okay." Brian flat out tells him.

"What's going on?" Rob throws his hand up in frustration. "What happened Friday night?"

"Listen, why don't we just meet up at Tiger's tomorrow night?"

Rob's palm lands on the table in front of him, calmed down. "Okay."

***

Becky opens the door to Exotica tattoo parlor and steps inside. Colorful decals partially cover the stucco walls of the parlor. Becky walks up to one of the black leather-bound books hanging from the ceiling on cable wires. She opens it up to check out the sample designs.

"Can I help you?"

"Yes." Becky shuts the thick book. The employee, a bald white woman with a silver nose ring, is behind the beaded curtain in the doorway across from Becky. "I was wondering if I could go back there. I'm meeting somebody here."

“Who?” The employee pulls the beaded curtain open.

Becky stalls. “Um, I really just need to take a look.”

“Okay. Have a look around, then.” She welcomes Becky in, parting the beaded curtain for her.

“Thank you.” Becky passes through the curtain. She stands at the end of a hallway of doors.

“Go ahead, the rooms are all open.”

Becky treks down the hallway and sheepishly peeks into each open door. When she checks the second door on her right, she catches a glimpse of a familiar face. Reno’s reclined back in a cushy black tattoo chair. His face is turned towards the door, but his eyes are closed. Becky dismisses the familiarity and continues down the hallway. She stops, suddenly disdained. Becky backs up to take a second look. It’s the Porsche guy.

Becky walks into the studio, where Reno is having work done on his smooth chest. The tattoo artist, Alice, is a twenty-something female whose long hair hangs in little braids. She has a barbell in her left eyebrow and chains tattooed up her arms. Alice lifts the machine from Reno’s skin when she sees Becky come in.

“Hello again.” Becky sits down on a wooden stool near the door. The smell of antiseptic drifts through Alice’s studio. Midday sun shines through the large window across from the door. Reno nonchalantly glances over at Becky.

“What are you doing here?”

“I was hoping you could tell me that.” She retorts.

The machine hums as Alice gets back to work on his tattoo.

“Make yourself comfortable, by the way. This here is Alice, since you didn’t bother asking.”

“Sorry, it’s nice to meet you...” Becky notices the chain tattoos running up Alice’s arms, “...Alice.”

Alice politely smiles but doesn’t look up from her work.

“What are you having done, there?” Becky asks Reno.

“You read, right?”

“Yeah I can *read*.” Ruffled by his brashness, she hops off the stool and leans over the black outline on Reno’s chest. “Travesty?”

“See the little badges Alice is putting inside of the letters?”

“I see them.” Becky sits back down on the stool. “I don’t see the significance.”

“How would you?” he asks.

“*I don’t know*. Are you gonna tell me?”

“I used to work Nevada. This is my insignia. We all have one.”

“Okay.” Becky wonders out loud. “So, what’s Black’s insignia, then?”

“Oh, it’s–” Alice goes to answer, but Reno interjects.

“He can tell you himself. Sorry Alice, I didn’t mean to cut you off.”

“No problem.”

“Oh, now just a minute.” Becky stares at Alice in astonishment. “You’re in on it, too? Am I the only one in town that isn’t aware of this?”

A thin laugh trickles out of Alice’s mouth. She puts down her machine and picks up a white towel. She wipes Reno’s chest with the towel while he reaches for his pack of cigarettes sitting on the barstool next to him. He lights one up.

“What exactly do you want to know, Becky?” Reno tosses down the lighter and exhales a cloud of smoke.

“Anything I want to know?”

“How about this, as long as you don’t waste my time with stupid questions, I’ll grant you three answers.” He proposes. “But only three, so give it some thought.”

Alice gets up from her stool to fetch an ashtray for Reno. She sets it on the barstool next to his pack and busies herself during Reno’s cigarette break.

“All right.” Becky gets down to business. “Is there some sort of name for this society you all belong to?”

“Not really, but if you’re involved, you’re a party member and if you live on site, you’re the inner party. Get it?” Reno’s *1984* reference sails right over Becky’s head. She foolishly rushes to her second question.

“Black’s in the inner party, then?”

Reno grimaces at her. “Are you sure you want to waste your second question like that?”

“No, actually I don’t, thank you.”

“Black this, Black that. You don’t even know my name, do you?”

Becky doesn’t respond. She rests her elbows on her knees diffidently.

“But you’re not wasting your second question on that nonsense, are you?” Reno sneers at her, flicking his cigarette into the ashtray. “Do you have any tattoos, Beck?”

“No, I don’t. I’m a chicken when it comes to needles.” She admits.

“Is that right? Did you know that the biggest pussies are the ones who most enjoy inflicting pain?”

“Is that a fact?”

“That it is. Pain’s never been my thing.” He pauses to take a drag of his cigarette. “Let’s hear question number two.”

“I’d like to know if there’s a point to my visit here, today.”

Smoke swirls out the corners of Reno's mouth as it curls downward in disappointment. "That is a poorly thought out question. Weren't you told to come here to redeem yourself? You already know the point, Becky."

"Oh, come on." She coaxes him. "It was just bad phrasing."

"No way, I'm not letting you slide twice in a row. Make number three count."

Becky glowers at Reno. "Well, I don't really have a choice. I have to know what I'm supposed to do to redeem myself."

Reno sits up straight and turns sideways on the chair. He fishes the phone out of his jeans pocket. "Here, this is for you." He bends forward, handing the phone over to Becky.

"A phone?" She takes it from him.

"It's yours, but you can only use it to communicate with Black." Reno lies back in the black vinyl chair. "You have no way of finding out the number to the phone. But try all you want."

"Okay, let's see here." The phone chimes when Becky powers it on. A bewildered frown comes over her face. "What the hell is 'random'? What kind of phone service is that?"

Reno rolls his eyes towards Alice and says, "A very private one." He snuffs out his cigarette. Alice laughs quietly in the background. She picks up her machine and goes back to work on Reno's tattoo.

"I've never heard of such a thing."

"Anyway, if you redeem yourself, you keep the phone. But your act of atonement is entirely optional."

Becky lowers the phone. "It's optional?"

"Optional is a choice– that you either make or you don't." He informs her.

"Yes, thank you. But how does it apply in this situation?"

The tattoo machine hums while Reno elaborates. "You have to choose whether to move forward in the game, or get out of it."

"You mean quit?"

"Right."

"So, it's really not optional."

"It's definitely optional. No one can force you to get a clit ring."

Becky blasts out an appalled huff. "No, that's what he expects me to do?" She crosses her arms over her lap.

"That's right."

She bats her eyes in disbelief. "That's insane."

"Once again, it's entirely optional." He reminds her.

Becky throws her head back, still clinging to the phone. “I’m on my lunch break right now.” She frets.

“And?”

“And this is a pretty major decision to make over my lunch hour.”

“Is it? Piercings aren’t permanent.”

She crosses her arms back over her lap. “You have a point.” Her frustration subsides. Becky bounces her foot in deliberation.

“It’s ironic, isn’t it? That your act of atonement for being impulsive, is being asked to do something impulsive.” Reno marvels at his own cleverness and then resumes his relaxed mode.

“Just not on my terms.”

“Of course not.” He hacks and then comments to Alice. “Somebody here really needs to get with the program.”

“In all seriousness, is this worth it?” Becky candidly asks Reno.

“If I were you, I’d go ahead and do it.”

“Would you? Get a clit ring, really?”

“I said ‘if I were you’.” Reno glances at Alice. “She’s a mouthy one, isn’t she?”

“A little, yeah.” Alice limits herself to answering direct questions from Reno.

“Of course it’s worth it,” he tells Becky and asks Alice, “wouldn’t you agree?”

“I agree completely,” Alice says, absorbed in her work.

“See, I wouldn’t lie to you, Beck.”

“Right, so let’s say I do this.” She hypothesizes. “How would I let him know?”

“Remember that phone I gave you?”

Becky looks down at the phone. “The one in my hand, you mean? *Yeah*.” She opens the contacts on the phone, but the list is empty.

“It has a camera.”

“But I don’t have any phone numbers in here. How would I send it to him?”

“You don’t need to do a thing. He’ll get the picture.” Reno promises and spots Becky’s gaze of consideration.

***

Doleful alternative music drones on softly through Black’s office. He’s in his desk chair, staring at his laptop. He reaches for a coffee mug while scrolling down the page. Black’s phone buzzes on the desk beside him. He picks it up and

opens the message. A camera image pops up on the screen. He lifts his brows in surprise when he sees the picture.

“Really Becky?” Black nods. “The game goes on, then.” He shuts off the display and sets down his phone. There’s a knock on the office door.

“Hey, you in there?” Cade asks from the other side of the door.

“Yeah, come in.” Black turns his chair around as the door opens. Cade walks in carrying a manila file folder. He hands it to Black and sits on a tall barstool across from him.

“There’s your copy.” Cade signals to the folder. On the tab, a name is written in black marker: Jane Bostick.

“The Jane Bostick abduction.” Black opens the folder and skims Cade’s game plan. “So you’re really going through with it?”

“Why not?”

“Why not.” Black repeats, still on the first page of the game plan. “I see that you assigned your best men to the job.” He mentions to Cade in a wry tone.

“Hey, take it as a compliment.”

“Why? Because you’re throwing caution to the wind and dragging me into it with you? That’s a compliment?”

“Yes. With you three, I don’t see what can go wrong.” Cade rests his elbow on the pub table beside him.

Black waves the game plan at him. “Have you talked to Random yet? Is he gonna be up for this?”

“I’ve talked to Random.” He apprises him.

“Really?” Black frowns, vaguely offended. “You gave him the plan before me?”

“I kind of needed him to know I was doing a high-risk scenario, and that I was expecting him to help me.” Cade laughs. “You know? I mean, he was gonna be the hardest one to convince.”

“What about Reno?”

“I’m meeting up with him as soon as he gets back here,” Cade answers. Reno will be the easiest one to get on board.

“Hmm.” Black gets through the first page and flips the sheet overtop of the folder. He continues reading. “It’s very detailed.”

“Take your time. Read it over.”

“Oh.” Black lowers the file, reaching back to pick up his phone. “Becky took the challenge, today.” He opens the picture from Becky and holds out his phone. Cade stoops down to check it out.

“So I see.” He pats Black’s chair. “That’s good news.” Cade sits back in his barstool. “What’s your next move?”

“I’m gonna stop over and see her tonight.” Black sets his phone back down on the counter behind him. Cade pulls his own phone out of his pocket and reads the message from Reno, saying he’s almost back to the house. He stands up from the barstool. On his way out, he asks Black,

“Have you figured out why Random’s so interested in her?”

“Not yet.”

“Hmm.” He leaves Black’s office and cuts through his living room to the penthouse corridor. Magenta’s vacuuming the corridor, but there’s no one else around. Cade travels down to his own suite at the west end of the hall. He walks into his office, leaves the door open and waits for Reno.

Seated at his desk in front of the bay window, Cade’s soft brown eyes sweep up from his laptop monitor to his office door. Reno strolls in and plops down on the leather chair across the desk from Cade. He sets a glass ashtray down on the corner of the mahogany desk.

“How far did Alice get on your tat?” Cade asks him.

“It’s coming along. I’m going back on Sunday.” He raises a cigarette up to his mouth. “Oh, guess what, Black’s little brat got a clit ring today.” Grinning, Reno lights the cigarette.

“Yeah, I saw it.” Cade slides a manila file folder across the desk to Reno.

“Ah yes.” He picks up the file and opens it.

“You’re playing the lure.”

“I’m not surprised.” Reno’s success rate relies on human nature’s innate trust for attractive people. He ashes his cigarette and then lounges back slowly into the chair. He delves deeper into the file contents. “Wait a minute, Jane *Bostick*? Is she any relation to–”

“Yes.” Cade interrupts him, chortling. “That’s why I’m being so careful. I can’t afford any risks.”

Reno glances at him. “I get it. Okay, then.” He redirects his focus back down to the game plan. “Where in the world did you find her?”

“Just on a website.” Cade brushes Reno off, reluctant to reveal too many personal details about Jane.

“Go on.” Reno blatantly ignores Cade’s attempt at discretion.

“It was an amateur story site.”

“Interesting.” He sets his cigarette in the ashtray and asks Cade, “What did she write about?”

Cade rests his head on the back of his chair. “Exactly what we specialize in around here.” He divulges.

“So,” Reno perks up with intrigue, “the proverbial black sheep. She’ll be a piece of cake.” He shoots Cade a smile of approval.

Across the desk, Cade's computer dings with an incoming message. He bows in to read it. "Hmm, Trip's bored on the plane."

"What?" Reno cocks his head, wholly clueless. "Trip's on a plane?"

***

In Black's master bedroom, the dark brown drapes are pulled back, letting in the golden glow of early evening sun. A sitcom plays on the TV mounted above his stone fireplace.

Black walks out of the steamy master bathroom toweling off his damp hair. He's dressed in olive pants and a black t-shirt, getting ready to leave for Becky's. He throws his towel through the bathroom doorway onto the tile floor. His phone rings, so he goes over to the nightstand. Looking down at the screen with a smile, Black holds his phone up to his ear. "Well hello, Sam in Amsterdam." He sits on the edge of his bed...

Sam's living room is warmly lit by a candle on the coffee table and a kitsch floor lamp in the corner. It's after 2:00 in the morning, and she's just getting home from work. Sam sits down on her couch in a full length, faux leather jacket.

"Hello yourself," she says to her phone, which is sitting on the coffee table on speaker with Black. Sam strips off her jacket to reveal the dominatrix gear she's wearing underneath. She's in a black vinyl halter top, laced up the front, with a matching miniskirt and arm gauntlets.

"To what do I owe the pleasure?" he asks.

"I have some news. But first, how are you?"

"I'm fine."

"Your bullet-dodging days are behind you, then?" Sam props her right foot up on the edge of the coffee table and begins unlacing her knee-high boot.

"For the time being."

"I'm glad to hear that."

"What's your news, Sam?"

"I'm moving back."

Her statement silences Black. He connects the dots between Sam's return and Random's recent behavior. "Random..." he says under his breath, so quiet that she asks,

"What?" Sam blinks at her phone in confusion, unaware of the realization Black is coming to on the other line.

"Have you told Random?" His mood takes a feisty turn. "He must be excited."

“Yeah, and so am I.”

“Not more than me.” Black’s reply carries a ring of insinuation.

Sam slips the boot off of her right foot and tosses it on the floor. “Hmm, that sounds sinister.” She starts on the laces of her left boot.

“Maybe it is.” He responds plainly.

Chapter 5

Sam unlaces her left boot, tilting her head at the odd turn that her phone conversation with Black has taken.

“So when will you be back in town?” he asks her, resuming normal dialogue.

“It’s a few weeks off, yet.” Sam pulls off her left boot and sets it down next to its match on the floor. “But keep it to yourself for right now, okay?”

“Sure.”

“I just don’t know exactly when I’ll have everything wrapped up here.”

“What brought on the decision to come back?”

“Several things.” She smiles. “Why, do you want me to rethink it?”

“Of course not, I was just curious to what triggered it.”

“It’s a lot of things.” Sam reaches up and pulls the ponytail out of her long hair. “It just feels like the right time.” She shakes her head, causing thick curls to tumble over her shoulders.

“I see.” He lets her ambiguous answer slide.

“Do you have any interesting projects going on?”

“Yeah, funny you should ask. Random’s been really eager to help me out with it.”

Sam notes his implication. “And you think that’s because of me?”

“I know it is. This project is the exact type of thing he’d want me to be preoccupied with in the wake of your impending return.”

“Why?” She pivots towards her phone on the coffee table in sheer suspense. “What kind of project is it?”

“Turning an outsider into a Top.”

“Nice, that’s ambitious!” she says encouragingly. “How’s it going?” Sam begins unlacing her forearm gauntlets.

“Not bad. It’s still too soon to tell for sure, though.”

“It’s not an easy task.”

“So you’ve told me.” He alludes.

“Well, I’m interested to see how that goes for you.”

“As is the *good doctor*.”

Sam squints at his remark and then changes the subject. “What else is going on around there that I should know about, aside from the obvious?”

“Vienna’s moving,” Black tells her.

“I know.” She hisses. “I am so pissed off. Does she know when, yet?” Sam peels the gauntlet off her left arm and lays it down on the coffee table. She starts

working on the laces of her right arm gauntlet.

“Not for sure.” He then changes the subject, himself. “I see you haven’t lost your knack for skirting the issue.”

“Black, I can’t weigh in on what Random’s thinking. How would I know? Maybe he just wants to be on good terms with you since I’m coming back.”

“No, he wants me to be busy. It’s pretty obvious now. But I really don’t expect you to weigh in.”

“You keep bringing it up, though.” Sam tosses the gauntlet down on top of the other one.

“Well, because I’ve been trying to figure this out, and I just got struck with the answer. You know how that is, when it all comes together in your head.”

Sam closes her eyes and softly laughs. “No, I don’t. That’s why I’ve been here for the past two years.”

“You’ll figure it all out when you get back.” Black assures her with an impious undertone.

***

Back in Cade’s office, Reno is still seated across the desk from him, holding the open Jane Bostick file. “Why is Trip on a plane?” he asks.

Cade looks at the clock in the corner of his computer screen. It’s 6:00 p.m. “I gotta go.”

“Where?”

With sudden urgency, Cade closes his laptop and stands up from his desk chair. “Over to the apartment.”

“Pedophile trapping?”

“Yup.” Cade reaches down to open a desk drawer. He takes out a 9mm gun and pushes the drawer closed.

“Have a good time.”

“I always do.” Cade leaves the office, gun in hand.

Closing the Jane Bostick file, Reno stays behind in the leather chair. He pulls out his phone and dials Shay.

“Hey Reno,” she answers.

“Hey. So, tell me why Trip’s on a plane.”

***

Trip is in the first-class section of the airplane cabin. The seat next to him is unoccupied. His overhead light shines down onto the laptop on his tray table. He

leans forward, types a couple lines and relaxes back in his seat. Trip has a headset on.

Cade's voice comes through the earpiece. "I didn't think I'd make it here in time."

"He should be there any second." Trip talks quietly into the mouthpiece of his headset, concentrating on the laptop screen.

On the monitor, there's a window with a live feed of Cade in a virtually empty apartment living room. He's seated in an armchair with a briefcase in his lap. Cade glances up at the camera that's mounted in the corner of the ceiling. "What profile did you use, by the way?" Cade opens the briefcase. A laptop computer is sitting on the table beside his chair. He takes a small speaker out of the briefcase and plugs it into the laptop.

"I'm BratMandy today," Trip tells him.

"Okay. This is such an excellent waste of time." Cade removes the 9mm gun from the briefcase and sets it on the table next to the laptop.

"It's a community service, really."

"Sure it is, and an entertaining one." Cade reaches back into the briefcase for a pair of handcuffs. After slipping the cuffs into his pant pocket, he closes the briefcase and sets it down on the floor next to his chair.

"The drunk guy who shit himself." Trip reminisces, quelling his laughter.

"Yeah, that was good."

There's a knock on the apartment door. Cade picks up the gun.

"Oh, here we go." Glued to the screen, Trip watches the trap he set unfold...

Cade turns to the laptop. He starts up the first audio file he has in queue. A girl's voice plays through the high-definition speaker.

"David?" The young voice is crisp and clear.

"Yeah, it's me," David says outside the door.

Cade plays the second audio file.

"Come on in, it's open."

Then he stands up from the chair.

The apartment door opens. Cade steps behind the door, and the middle-aged pedophile, David, walks inside. Cade pushes the door shut behind him and holds the gun to his head.

David freezes.

"Mandy had a change of heart." Cade notifies him.

"Yeah, I'm figuring that out."

Standing directly behind David, Cade presses the gun to his temple with a steady hand while taking the handcuffs out of his pocket. "Put your hands behind your back."

David doesn't resist. He slowly moves his arms behind him.

"Thirteen-year-old girls can be fickle, you know?" One-handed, Cade puts the pair of cuffs on David's wrists. "In the meantime, we've learned all about you, David Alan Garrett. Everything. And that's just to make sure you don't ever try this sick shit again. You are officially on our radar. Understood?"

"Yes, it's understood. I had a bad feeling." David maintains a compliant and calm front.

"And yet here you are, despite it." Cade walks away from him. He sets the gun down on the table next to the laptop.

"Am I getting arrested, then?" David asks.

"No, but for wasting our time, I need you to take your wallet out." Cade has a seat in the armchair. He rests his hand on the gun. "How much cash do you have in there?"

"Not much, maybe like thirty bucks." David gets his wallet out of his back pocket.

"That's fine. Throw me your wallet. You've got credit cards, right?" Cade holds his hand out.

David sighs. "Are you taking everything?" He turns and tosses his wallet over to Cade.

"Nope." Cade catches the wallet and flips it open. "I'm just collecting a few thousand towards rent and expenses. You can't really expect us to foot the bills for this place, can you?" Cade shrugs, taking a couple of credit cards out of David's wallet. He sets them down on his knee. Leaving one hand on the gun, Cade picks up his phone and starts typing a credit card number on the keypad.

"So a few grand, and that's it? That's what you want?"

Cade stops typing to say, "I could always kick your ass."

***

Sitting at a stoplight behind the wheel of his Mercedes, Black turns off his stereo. Over on the passenger seat, his phone is ringing. He puts the phone on speaker. "Hello Random."

"Hey, where'd you go?" Random asks on the other line.

"I'm stopping over to visit Becky."

"Right, the newly pierced conquest. That really surprised me, I've got to admit."

"She's full of surprises. Anyway, I'll be back in a little while. I'm sure Cade wants to get together and go over his game plan."

"Actually, he's out pedophile trapping right now."

“Really?” Black’s forehead crinkles with interest.

“Yes. The reason I called you was to see if any of your girls want to bartend, the twins maybe?”

The light turns green. Black shifts into first gear and continues down the road lit up by streetlights. “They help out in the bar on Saturdays already, but I can ask them. Why?”

“Ryan wants to move across the hall for good,” Random tells him.

“Oh okay, I’ll keep that in mind.”

“Well enjoy your visit. I’m sure we’ll hear from Cade later.”

“Yeah, I’m sure we will.” Black reaches over to end the call. He turns into Becky’s neighborhood, drives past the row of townhomes and pulls into her driveway. Shutting off the engine, he walks up her front steps and rings the doorbell.

Becky opens the door and sees Black standing on her porch. She inspects his black t-shirt, Harrington jacket and olive pants. He looks put-together, even in basics. “Come in.” Becky backs up, and Black enters her living room. She closes the door behind him. “Do you want a mojito?” she asks him.

Black wanders in and stops, somewhat bemused by her drink offering. “You have everything on hand for a mojito?”

“I do,” Becky answers on her way to the kitchen. “I worked behind the bar at a Mexican restaurant when I was in college.”

Black’s brows arch upon learning Becky knows how to bartend. “Hmm, good to know.”

“What’s that?”

“Nothing,” he says.

Busy in the kitchen, Becky keeps on talking. “So, Stillborn, which I still find incredibly revolting.”

Black smirks, subtly taking inventory of her living room. He notices a picture on the table behind her couch. It’s the shot of Rob, Jackie, Becky and Brian at the bar. He picks up the picture frame and says, “I’m not known for doing things in good taste.”

“Anyway, Stillborn, a.k.a. Black, a.k.a...” Becky trails off in inquiry.

Black can hear her slicing limes on a cutting board. “It ends there.” He carries the picture frame to the kitchen.

“So it’s okay for you to know everything about me, but I can’t even know your real name?” When Becky turns to an upper cabinet, she catches the image of Black standing in the kitchen doorway. “Oh,” she jumps back, “you scared me.”

“What’s this?” Black holds up the picture. Her eyes stray from the frame up to Black’s face.

“Brian’s not the only person in that picture.” She informs him with a trace of defensiveness.

“You’re not having any second thoughts about anything, are you?”

“No.” Becky recoils at his question. “That just happened to be a good day.” She reaches up for a cabinet door. “And he happened to be there.” Becky pulls a couple pint glasses out of the cabinet. She sets them down and drops mint leaves into each one.

Black lays the picture frame face down on the dining room table behind him. He watches Becky pick up a wooden muddling tool and go to work on the mint leaves. “You have a muddler, even?”

“It’s a small investment for one of my favorite drinks.” Becky mashes the mint into the sides of the glasses. “Wait a second,” she grills Black, “how did you know that was Brian?”

“I didn’t. I had a hunch, so I made you confirm it for me. That’s what I do.”

Becky slowly withdraws the muddling tool from the glass and sets it on the counter. “What if it wouldn’t have been Brian?” She turns to her refrigerator and takes out a pitcher of prepared mojitos. The ice swishes around in the pitcher while Becky pours some into the glasses.

“Then you would’ve told me who it was anyway, right?” he asks through a faint laugh.

She garnishes each glass with a lime wedge. “Probably.”

“I asked a question that I knew would trigger the desired response.”

Becky hands Black one of the mojitos. She spins to her glass patio door, which leads out to a small concrete patio. She flips on the outside light.

Becky opens the sliding glass door, and they relocate outside where a couple of wicker chairs are sitting on the patio. Black slides the door shut behind him and joins Becky in one of the chairs.

“So, mind games.” She concludes. “That’s ‘what you do’?”

“It’s a significant part of what I do, which should be pretty obvious to you by now.” Black tries a sip of the mojito. He shows his approval by taking a bigger drink.

“And you’re teaching *me* mind games, then?” She presses him.

Black’s phone chirps in his pocket. He sets it out on the arm of his chair but ignores the message. “Right now I’m still playing them on you. But yeah, that’s the eventual goal.” He takes another healthy swig of his mojito before setting the glass down next to his phone.

The exterior light casts a yellow glow onto the patio floor below. Bright stars dot the night sky above them. Off in the distance, a neighbor's sprinkler ticks. They both just quietly stare straight ahead, sharing a few moments of peace.

Becky breaks the bout of tranquility. "Do I ever get to know the real you, at all?"

"You're really hung up on that, aren't you?"

"I think it's only natural."

"I hope you don't expect to like what you see."

Becky lets out a short, uneasy laugh.

"Anyway, it's funny you should ask." He picks up his mojito. "I've been thinking about that, you know?" Black looks over at Becky. "Since you didn't back out today at the tattoo parlor."

"I know." She looks back at him with a lighthearted glint. "I could have."

"I knew you wouldn't."

Becky scoffs and sips her mojito.

"And you didn't." Black's phone chirps again with an incoming message. He checks the screen. It's Cade.

"Busy guy." Becky smiles at him.

"Well, I didn't plan on staying very long." Black has a sip of his drink. "I just wanted to stop by." He sets the glass back down on the arm of his chair.

"Okay."

"What are you doing tomorrow night?" he asks her.

"Oh, I'm giving an honorary speech at an awards ceremony." Becky turns to Black, totally deadpan.

"For work?"

"No." Her serious face cracks up in amusement. "I'm kidding. I was thinking about going to a water aerobics class after work, but that's about it. Why?"

"I was gonna offer you that real-life date you've deluded yourself into wanting."

Becky's mood lifts into exhilaration. "Really?" she asks through a shocked gasp.

"*Yeah*." He mocks her breathlessness. "Be ready at nine?"

"I will."

Black finishes off his mojito and hands the empty pint glass to Becky. He grabs his phone and stands up from the chair.

"You've got to go already?" She doesn't hide her disappointment. "You just got here."

He looms over her. "Thanks for the drink."

"Sure."

***

Later that night, on opposite sides of the Mercer Estate penthouse corridor, both Black's and Random's suite doors open. They come out into the corridor at the same time. When they see each other, Random smiles and Black sputters out a soft laugh.

"I guess you were copied on the invite from Cade." Random infers.

"Yeah, I'm heading down for the dress rehearsal." He and Random set off for the elevator. Despite Black's snarky comments about Cade's big secret plan as of late, he's still openly inclined to defend his friend. "The actual scenario's only three days away, and this is the first trial run. I guess that's not so bad."

Random agrees. "No, it's smart to run through it. It's just..."

"Yeah, I know." Black reaches out to push the 'down' button for the elevator. "I might've found a solution to the bartender problem."

Random thinks for a beat. "Becky?"

Black nods.

"Must've been an illuminating visit."

The elevator doors open. Black and Random step inside. They step out on the main level, heading to the meeting place, the Mercer Estate garage.

The overhead lights are all on in the expansive multi-car garage. The row of parked cars includes Reno's Porsche, Black's Roadster, Shay's Cayenne and the silver sports car that Ryan used to pick Becky up for dinner. Off towards the end is the white cargo van.

There's an empty parking spot in the middle of the garage, scattered with a few wood stools and a cardboard box. On one of the wood stools, the Jane Bostick file is opened to a picture of her.

Cade's black SUV is parked right next to the empty spot. He is standing by his passenger side door with Kayleigh. Black's sub waits silently beside Cade with her fingers laced together behind her back. She's there to play the role of Jane.

Black and Random walk inside the garage.

Cade dives into the rehearsal. "All right, let's get started." He opens the back door of his SUV.

"Really? Straight to business?" Black follows Random over to the SUV. "How'd the pedophile trap go?"

"As well as they can," Cade answers him and turns to Random. "I'll drop the briefcase by in the morning."

"Take your time. Hopefully we won't need it again anytime soon." Random stops across from Cade.

The four of them are gathered around the open truck door.

“When did you find out about it?” Curious, Black continues questioning Cade about the pedophile trap.

“It was spur of the moment. Trip’s on his flight to Oklahoma.”

“Ah, boredom.” Black hums in understanding.

“Yeah. So, anything else? You wanna chat some more, or can we run through this?” Cade motions to his SUV, snippy and impatient.

“What would you do if I just started laughing maniacally right now?” Black asks him.

“Please don’t.”

“You better relax, then.”

Kayleigh casts her eyes down at the ground, smiling at Black’s banter with Cade.

***

Dingy tan drapes on the living room windows almost entirely block out the late morning sun. In front of the drapes, a TV is on with the volume way down. The beige walls are pretty bare inside Dustin’s small, drab living room in Oklahoma City.

Dustin is in his early twenties, slumped back in a faded blue recliner. He’s holding a large travel mug of coffee in one hand. He runs his other hand over his tired face and through his messy chin-length hair.

Trip is sitting on a worn brown couch that’s partially covered with a blue sheet. The coffee table in front of him is littered with empty food containers, beer cans, a remote control and some magazines featuring either guns or cars on their covers. However, Trip is fixed on the two small bags of heroin on the edge of the table. “Thanks for letting me crash on your couch last night,” he says to Dustin, an old friend from when he lived in town.

“Yeah yeah, it’s no problem.”

Trip picks up the bags of heroin. “But I mostly appreciate this.” He shoves the bags into his jeans pocket.

“Yeah,” Dustin bobs his head, “good luck with all that, damn.” He takes a sip of his coffee. Dustin has that lazy, stoner-like vibe down pat.

“So, if I could just ask you for one more thing?” Trip bends forward and rests his elbows on his knees.

“The bus station?”

“Can you still take me?”

“Yeah, I can do that. Just need to find my keys.” Dustin pats the pocket of his tan shorts.

***

Meanwhile at the Mercer Estate, Cade walks through Random’s suite, up to the open door of his office. Carrying the briefcase, Cade knocks on the doorframe a couple times before stepping into his private office.

Random’s sitting at his desk. He looks up from his computer at Cade, who’s in his typical morning attire of bright swim trunks and a t-shirt. He has a towel around his neck. “We have that apartment paid up through April, by the way. As in, April of next year.” Random reclines back in his posh chair.

“It’s a scary world out there.” Cade puts the briefcase on the corner of Random’s desk. “But I’m always happy to help make it just a little less so.” He settles into a nearby chair.

“It’s probably the best public service that our little collective here could provide.”

“It really is.”

Random moves the briefcase down to the floor next to his desk. “So anyway, how did Trip seem to you last night?”

“It’s hard to tell with him. He was still on the plane at the time.”

“True. You gotta feel for him, though.”

“I do. It’s probably a good thing that he wasn’t close to his father.” Cade carries on his conversation with Random while...

Outside the Oklahoma City bus station, Trip is leaning against the grey brick building, reading the numbers on a bus that passes by. He reaches down and grabs the strap of his worn leather shoulder bag. He swings the bag over his shoulder and strolls down the sidewalk, decisively apathetic.

“Either way,” Random says, “pulling the plug is never a call anybody wants to make.”

“No, of course not.” Cade concurs sympathetically.

Trip roams up to a city bus that sits idling at the curb. He takes his ticket out of his bag and heads up the steps into the bus.

There are only a handful of passengers on the bus so far. Trip chooses a seat near the back. He surveys his surroundings and pulls his foot up onto his knee.

“But knowing Trip, he’s already figured out ways to cope.” Random speculates.

Trip starts picking at the rubber sole of his shoe until he finds the rip. He peels it back to dig out the dried mushrooms he stashed in the heel.

Random adds, “And he didn’t want to take Shay or anybody with him, which is a good sign there’s something he wants to hide.”

Trip pops the mushrooms into his mouth and glances over at an Amish couple that sits down across the aisle from him. They exchange smiles with Trip.

“Yeah, this should be interesting.” Cade predicts.

***

Out back in the hot tub, Hannah is sunken down letting the jets work on the base of her neck. Her morning banana is on the edge of the tub. “What’s the holdup with Cade?”

Black is sitting in his customary spot with his back to the house. He reaches back for his phone and calls Cade. “Are you coming down here, or what?” Black asks him.

Hannah belts out, “You’re gonna miss the banana, Cade!”

Black smiles at Cade’s fervent response on the other line. “Okay, I will.” He ends the call and tells Hannah, “He’s on his way.”

“I figured that would get him running. Pervert.”

“He’s dropping off the pedophile kit to Random.” Black sets his phone down behind him on his towel. “Speaking of perverts.”

“Oh, really?”

He nods at her. The distant sound of women talking carries over from the pool area. Black sinks down and leans his head back on the headrest behind him. “All he’s gonna do is stress out about this abduction for the next two days, anyway.”

“Well that’s fine. I need to stress out, too.”

“Oh. Great.” Black grouses.

“Who’d he do a trap with, anyway?”

***

Sun shines through the city bus window onto Trip, slouched down in his diamond-patterned seat near the back. His eyes shift from the ceiling to the front of the bus, which slows at a highway intersection and stops. He sees an interstate ramp up the highway. Exceedingly antsy, he gets up and goes to the front of the bus to exit.

Trip is the only passenger who gets off at the stop. He swings his leather bag over his shoulder and starts treading down the highway. The bus pulls off. Red

dust kicks up behind Trip's heels as he ventures down a seemingly desolate stretch of road.

Within a few minutes, he sees the Southbend Diner around a bend in the highway and walks towards it.

Inside, soft conversation and the clank of dishes fill the roadside greasy spoon. Roughly a dozen customers are dispersed throughout the modest diner eating plates of comfort food and sipping their midday caffeine. Brewing coffee overpowers the fusion of food smells ranging from maple syrup to pungent pork.

The cowbell hanging on the door rattles when Trip pulls it open. He scans the dining room and sees an older guy sitting in a booth, reading a newspaper. Trip slides into the booth across from the older guy, who looks up from his paper.

"Pardon me," Trip asks him, "do you mind telling me what town I'm in?"

"You're in Southbend. Where're you headed for?" The older guy has a gruff tenor.

"I'm going to Woodcliff."

"Then what're you doing up here?"

"I guess I got off on the wrong bus stop."

"You got off about seventy miles northwest of where you shoulda, then," the guy tells him.

"Okay, thanks."

"Sounds like you need a keeper."

Trip hears a sugary female voice behind him. He turns around in his seat to the blonde babe one booth over. "You busy?" he asks her.

Beaming, she shakes her head and waves Trip over to her booth. A plate of pancakes sits in front of her on the gold-flecked tabletop.

Trip scoots out of the older guy's booth and gives him an appreciative nod.

"You got off at the wrong stop, huh?" The blonde babe has a southern drawl and a friendly doll face.

"Maybe I didn't." Trip slips into the booth seat across from her. She stabs up a bite of pancake. He flips over a coffee mug that's sitting on the table.

At that moment, the mushrooms he took on the bus kick in...

Upbeat trippy music plays in Trip's world, and his perspective slants down fifteen degrees to the right. Colors blanch in and out. Trip tips his head sideways to compensate for the fifteen-degree slant. He hooks a finger through the coffee mug's handle, so it doesn't slide off the table.

He canvasses the other patrons in the diner, whose faces appear sunken in and sallow. His gaze drifts back onto the blonde babe– the only one who still looks normal. Trip notices that she's talking, so he nods at her. He glances down

at the tabletop and sees the gold flecks rise up from the surface. Trip puts his hand over the top of his mug (to keep the flecks out) while a plump waitress approaches with a coffeepot. The waitress shrugs at his mixed signals and heads for the next booth without filling his cup.

The blonde babe continues talking and motions out the window at a red, late-model pickup truck sitting in the diner's gravel parking lot. She takes another bite of pancake and washes it down with a swig of iced tea.

The blurred image of a young guy materializes at the end of their booth. Everything around the guy is perfectly clear, just not him. His chin-length hair and tan shorts can just barely be made out. The guy is undoubtedly addressing Trip, but his words are slowed down, and his voice is unrecognizable. "What are you doing here, man?"

"Do I know you?" Trip asks him, utterly confused. The music in his head distills down into the background noise of the diner, and he descends from the onset peak of his trip...

Dustin is standing at the end of the booth with outstretched arms. "It's me, Dustin!"

The blonde babe's round eyes dart back and forth between Dustin and Trip.

"Oh, Dustin." Trip grins at Dustin, who is profusely concerned.

"Yeah. What are you doing here? You're only like thirty miles south of Oklahoma City."

"I got off on the wrong stop."

"Excuse me, I'm gonna go to the ladies' room." She shoots Dustin a polite wave and exits the booth.

Dustin sits down in the booth across from Trip. He pushes the plate of pancakes out of his way and leans over the table. He speaks to Trip in a low mumble. "What are you on, man?"

"Tripping."

"Oh. Do you remember why you're in Oklahoma?"

"Yeah." Trip claims.

"Are you gonna make it to the hospital?"

"I might put that off for a day or two, but I'll make it."

"Huh." Dustin sounds puzzled. "Can you do that?"

"Sure I can."

Dustin looks down at the table, where Trip is still clinging onto his coffee cup with one hand and covering the top of it with his other hand. "What are you doing with your cup?"

"Um, I didn't want anything to get into my coffee." Trip takes his hand off the top of his empty cup and lets go of it. "What are *you* doing here?"

“My stepbrother works in the kitchen. He runs stuff up to here, and I pick it up from him.” By stuff, he means drugs, which Trip appears to pick up on.

“Oh, okay.”

Dustin gestures to the restrooms. “So what, are you just gonna hang out with this girl for a couple days, or...?”

“You mean Babe?”

“Is that her name?”

“Yes.” Trip states as if it’s a fact.

“Is that what you’re gonna do?”

“If I can.”

“Are you gonna be all right?” Dustin asks through an awkward laugh.

“Sure.”

Babe comes out of the bathroom and back over to the booth. Dustin begins scooting out of her seat.

“You’re fine,” she tells him.

“No, I need to get going anyway. You live here in Southbend?”

“No, I live in Mutual,” Babe answers. She waits for Dustin to stand up from the booth. “This is just the closest town with a restaurant.” She slides back down into the vinyl seat.

“Oh, sure, I’ve heard of Mutual. It’s about what, thirty miles east?”

“Yeah, just about.”

“Well, you two have a good day. Trip, call me if you need anything, okay?”

“Thanks Dustin.” Trip watches him walk off and then centers on Babe across the table. “Sorry about that.”

“Nothin’ to be sorry about.” She forges ahead. “Now, we need to find you a hotel.”

Evidently that’s what they were discussing before Dustin arrived, so Trip seamlessly responds. “A bed and breakfast would be better. I actually don’t mind interacting with people.”

“So I see.” Babe ribs him, rummaging around in her purse. She pulls out some cash to leave for the bill. “We’ll see what we can come up with.”

Trip holds up his hand to stop her. “No, I’ll get this.” He takes his wallet out of his back pocket.

“All you had is coffee. If that.” Babe points at Trip’s coffee cup, which is still empty.

“I’ll get it.” Trip counts out more than enough cash and tosses it down on the table.

“All right, then. Anyway, you’re gonna need to get the rental car in Woodcliff, but there should be someplace to stay between Mutual and there.”

“Okay.” Trip places his palm on the gold-flecked table. “Let’s do it.” He pushes himself up out of the booth.

***

Around the corner from WPC’s front reception area is the coffee station. It’s an inset shelf in the wall with two cabinet doors down below. The shelf holds a couple of coffeepots and a divided basket that’s stocked with sugar and creamer packets.

Becky picks up the caffeinated pot of coffee. She fills her mug with a post-lunch boost of energy for her date with Black later tonight.

Further down the hall, Rob comes out of his office. He sees Becky and stops in his tracks with a guarded stance.

She glances over at him. “Oh, hey Rob.” Becky replaces the coffee carafe and grabs a stir stick. She backs away from the coffee station and walks up to Rob, noting his uneasiness. “What’s the matter?”

“Oh, nothing, I forgot what I even came out here for.” Rob heaves out a flustered laugh. He spins around to his office door.

“Wait up a minute.” Becky trails him down the hallway. “Did you have any luck finding Brian yesterday?”

“Nah.” Rob brushes off her concern. “I’m done worrying about it. He’ll turn up.”

“Really? Nothing at all?” Becky stops in front of her office door.

“Not yet, no. But I’ll let you know.”

“Okay.” She stirs her coffee and adds, “I’ll do the same.”

“Thanks Becky.”

Becky’s face pinches in thought. She steps into her office.

***

Trip can’t seem to stop staring across the bench seat at Babe while the old red truck rambles down the sun-drenched highway. He’s still pretty high.

Babe peeks at Trip out the corner of her eye. She takes her right hand off the steering wheel and flings it out to him. “What are you lookin’ at, goofball?”

“I’m sorry. I’m sorry for staring. It’s just,” Trip takes Babe’s outstretched hand and draws it in towards his chest, “I think you’re the most beautiful thing I’ve ever seen in my life.”

“Aww.”

“And since I’m not even from here, I’m starting to wonder if something brought me into that diner today, so I could meet you.” He kisses Babe’s hand and gives it a light squeeze before letting it go.

Babe slowly places her hand back on the steering wheel. She glimpses over at Trip. “Where are you from, stranger?”

“I’m in town from California, from L.A.”

She stifles a giggle. “Ah, California guy just passin’ through southern Oklahoma?”

“I’m here for family business.”

“And you just happened to get off on the wrong stop, because?”

Trip pauses in an attempt to relay why he got off the bus in the first place. “I think I’m having trouble coping. See, the reason I need to get to Woodcliff is to visit somebody in the hospital.”

“Oh, I’m so sorry.” Babe blushes in embarrassment. “I didn’t mean to be insensitive.”

“It’s okay.”

“No it’s not. That was rude, just lemme apologize.”

“How would you know better? I could be full of it for all you know.”

Babe scrutinizes him and shakes her head. “No, I can see it in your eyes, yet anyway. Is there anythin’ I can do to cheer you up?” She offers, representing her inherent small-town values.

“Oh Babe, you already are.”

“My name, by the way–”

“No.” Trip cuts her off with a boyish smile. “Just let me call you what fits you, okay?”

“Um, okay?” She laughs unsteadily, like she’s not sure how to read his request.

“Don’t take it the wrong way. I just don’t think of people in terms of their labels. I’d rather remember your face or your voice, than your name or your birthday.”

“Hmm, okay, that’s a little weird.” Babe furrows her brow. “Are all you city guys funny like that?”

“It might just be me, actually.”

“Oh, I doubt that.” While peering over at the stranger beside her, Babe gets distracted by a squirrel up ahead on the road. She huffs. “Look at that, there.” She jabs her finger at the windshield.

“What?” Trip scours the road, unsure about what Babe’s referring to.

“That stinkin’ squirrel.”

A brazen squirrel is perched on the side of the road, waiting for the truck.

“Why do they do that? He has plenty of time to cross but watch him!” Babe exclaims as the squirrel waits, playing chicken with the truck. “He’ll wait ‘til the last possible second to run across the road.”

Trip taps on the passenger side window. “He made it, though.”

“But why do they do that?”

“For the sport of it,” he answers.

“What? You mean, cause he’s so sure of his little squirrel self that he treats his life like a crap shoot just for the sport of it?”

“What else do they really have going for them other than the rush, you know?”

Laughing under her breath, Babe flashes Trip a whimsical simper.

***

Random walks out to the Mercer Estate pool area with a midafternoon drink in hand. Shay and Rayne are lying next to one another in lounge chairs beside the sparkling swimming pool. Rayne has earbuds in, completely tuned out.

A few others, including Reno, Kayleigh and Ryan, are in the pool. Reno’s lying on a shaded raft. Kayleigh is in the water, tossing a foam football to Ryan.

Random sits down on a lounge chair next to Shay with his back to the house.

“So.” Shay pushes her sunglasses up onto her head. “Trip’s phone is shut off.” She alerts him.

“I know. I tried checking in on him last night. It’s still off?”

“Yeah.” Shay bites at her lower lip in concern.

“Hmm. That little shit.” He gleans the activity in the pool.

“I’m glad I’m not the only one who’s paranoid.”

“Geneva’s the one who brought it up to me in the first place, so I guess that makes three of us.” Random looks down at his drink and swirls the melting ice around in the glass.

“It’s not exactly unjustified concern.” Shay points out.

“I know, given his history. Kinda bothers me that he didn’t want to take anyone. That’s what doesn’t add up.” He takes a swig of his drink.

“Well, he can be a loner at times.”

Random debates Shay’s rationale. “Still, who wants to go through something like this alone? And why did he turn off his phone unless he doesn’t want us to know where he is?”

“I don’t know. And I hope we’re wrong, but it doesn’t add up.”

“No it does not.”

Rayne sits upright and pulls out her earbuds, blatantly oblivious to the serious nature of their conversation. “Oh, hi there.” She greets Random.

“Rayne.”

“Does anyone know what’s for dinner tonight?”

“Yeah.” Shay does. “Tonight’s half Greek food and half vegan.”

“Oh.” Uninterested, Rayne asks, “Anybody want to go out for dinner with me and Ryan tonight?”

“I do.” Random takes a sip of his drink.

Behind him, Hannah passes by in the background. She walks up to a massage table that’s set up towards the end of the swimming pool. It’s far enough away to keep the pool noise at a minimum. The wooded area beyond it sets a serene ambiance.

Brian is lying face down on the table. He’s receiving a massage from Jayla, the resident masseuse.

Jayla sends Hannah a courteous smile. “Hi Hannah.”

Brian lifts his head out of the headrest and squints up at her.

“Relax, resume.” She authorizes. When he lowers his head back down into the padded headrest, Jayla continues the massage. Hannah folds her arms in front of her and asks him, “You’re meeting up with Rob later, right?”

“Yeah, if that’s still okay?”

“Of course it is. Just expect him to overreact and think that you’re in some kind of trouble.” Hannah advises him with a scoff.

“I know.”

“He’s gonna ask the same basic question about ten different ways. He might ask if you’re in a cult, or if you’re on drugs.” She trivializes the most likely inaccurate assumptions.

“At first maybe, but he’ll be cool. I’ve known Rob for a long time.”

“So you’ve said.” Hannah pushes forward with her instructions. “Will is driving you there tonight, so just text him when you’re getting ready to leave. All of the contacts are already in your new phone.”

“Okay.”

“If I don’t see you before you leave, good luck.”

***

Outside of Aunt Nelly’s Bed and Breakfast in Oklahoma, Trip and Babe stand across from one another in the gravel parking lot. Her old red pickup is parked next to Trip’s shiny new rental car. The sun is just beginning to set on the

farmhouse Bed and Breakfast. The property is lush with trees, tucked into an incredibly tranquil rural setting.

Babe sucks in a deep breath. “Well, here we are. You’ve got your Bed an’ Breakfast, got your rental car...”

“Got your number.” Trip adds the most important item.

Babe bashfully digs the toe of her boot into the gravel between them. “Mm-hmm, so I think you’re all set for the night.”

“Are you sure you can’t come in for a little bit?”

“No, I been gone a real long time.” Babe regretfully declines. “I’ve gotta drive home. And don’t you need to get to the hospital?”

“I can do that tomorrow.” Trip reaches in his back pocket for his wallet. “Let me give you some gas money, please.”

“No, no.” She waves her hand in protest. A light breeze rustles the leaves of the surrounding trees.

“Are you sure?”

“I’m positive.” Babe nods, reassuring him of her position on the matter. “But, can I ask you somethin’? Are you busy tomorrow night?”

“I doubt it.”

“Then would you consider joinin’ me for supper at my house? Tomorrow at five?” Babe hooks her thumbs in her belt loops and waits for Trip’s reply.

“Oh, I’d hate to invade on your family dinner.”

“Dinner was at noon. Supper’s at five.” She corrects him sweetly. “And I did invite you.”

Trip’s arrant resistance to the idea ultimately thaws in Babe’s persuasive glow. “I can’t imagine turning you down for anything, so. Sure, I’ll be there at five.”

“Okay good.” Satisfied by that, she takes a step back. “And take care. I hope your family’s doin’ well.” Babe turns to the pickup truck.

As she walks off, Trip’s eyes travel from her distressed cowboy boots up her tan legs to the frayed hem of her cutoff jean shorts, her lilac crocheted top, and the wave of blonde hair sweeping across her upper back. He exhales an ardent breath when Babe arrives at the red truck, peeping back over her shoulder at him before she gets inside.

***

The lights are off in Hannah’s master bathroom that night. She hovers over her pale-colored granite vanity, lighting pillar candles with a stick lighter. Behind her, the bathtub fills with water. The milieu is somber. Hannah turns to her tub.

Bundled in a fluffy white robe, she selects a bottle of almond milk bubble bath and squeezes it into the bathwater. The running water masks her sigh.

She reaches for her phone on the vanity and sets it on an empty soap dish in the tub before getting in there herself. Bubbles rise tall inside the deep tub while Hannah sheds her fluffy robe. She slips down into the water, immersing herself in the wall of white suds.

Hannah pokes her arm up out of the bubbles. She aims a finger down at her phone on the soap dish in front of her. She taps the screen a few times, picks up her phone and settles back into the chin-high suds. With her phone to her ear, she waits for Sam to answer...

Morning sun cheerfully lights up the living room of Sam's Amsterdam flat. She is seated on her couch with her laptop. Her feet are propped up on the coffee table. A vase of blush peonies in the middle of her coffee table permeates the room with their sweet fragrance. Lying beside the vase, her phone rings with Hannah's call.

Sam leans forward to answer, putting the call on speaker. "Hello?"

"Sorry Sam, it's still real early there, isn't it?" Hannah's downbeat voice comes through on the phone.

"That's okay, I'm up. Are you on the website?" Glancing down at her laptop screen, Sam guesses at the reason for Hannah's call. Her long hair is pulled back in a ponytail. She's wearing plaid pajama pants and a Pixies t-shirt.

"No, I just want to talk, if you have a minute."

"To me?" Sam sounds befuddled.

"*Sorry*."

"No, you're fine." She snickers at Hannah's response. "It's just not an everyday thing."

"I know. And I hate to bother you, but Black's out for the night, Cade's in his own world right now, Will is part of the problem and Reno just pisses me off."

"So, nobody else to talk to, huh?" Sam deduces.

"No offense."

"None taken, what's up?" She moves her laptop over to the couch cushion.

"I'm just a ball of nerves tonight, over a *sub*."

Sam is stunned silent for a moment. "I don't think I've ever heard you say those words before."

"I'm not sure I have."

"What's gotten into you?" She hears Hannah blow a raspberry before laying it out for her.

"When something seems too good to be true, or comes too easily, I just wait for the other shoe to drop. And I don't have this problem very often. Normally I

work my butt off for everything, so it's rare that I feel this way."

"What's the worst that could happen?" Sam asks her.

"I lose my investment in a new sub. Granted, he's a very new sub, so there's not a lot invested. But he just fell right into my lap when I really needed one, and he could be such a good fit in my suite."

"Why do you think the other shoe's gonna drop?"

"Because he agreed to meet up with like, his best friend, tonight."

***

At that same time in Tiger's lounge, Brian and Rob are at a high table near the bar. There are a couple pool tables around them, one of which is being used. Tiger's lounge is homey and not very crowded. A round of laughter bellows out from the bar, over top of the trendy pop music playing.

"I never would've saw this coming." Brian picks up his bottle of beer. "I didn't even realize I needed a change, until I stepped out of my routine and really looked at it." He sips his beer.

"What made you think you needed this big of a change, though?"

"It was time to break the cycle." Brian explains his odd circumstances to Rob. "And not, not just with Becky. I was really falling out of touch." He takes another swig of his beer and sets down the bottle.

"Falling out of touch with what?"

"Everything," Brian answers genuinely. The crack of a pool ball being struck is heard in the background.

Wary-eyed, Rob has a partially drank whiskey and cola sitting on a coaster in front of him. "It didn't seem that way to me."

"I guess I was getting pretty good at playing the role."

Rob slumps back in his chair. "I don't know, man."

"I was on autopilot constantly. The life I was living was just a way to ignore everything I was unhappy with."

"Like what?"

"Like," Brian chuckles, "normal life."

"Come on." Rob spouts, unamused by Brian's vagueness.

"Seriously. Boring job, tiny apartment, bad relationships. Everything." Brian's reasoning doesn't exactly appease Rob, whose forehead creases in concern.

"It really sounds like somebody put this idea into your head." He reaches for his drink.

"No." Brian zealously contests. "Nobody put any ideas in my head."

“It sure seems that way.” Rob sips his drink.

***

“Anyway, this friend of Brian’s doesn’t think too highly of me, thanks to Will.” Hannah tells Sam while dragging her index finger through the top layer of frothy bubbles.

“Thanks to Will?” Sam’s puzzled question blasts out of Hannah’s phone.

“Yes, there was an ordeal.” She pokes her fingernail into the bubbles, popping them as she goes. “I mean, I don’t blame the friend for being a little turned off. I just hope he doesn’t talk Brian out of anything. It’s just so early on, you know?”

“Hmm, is Brian aware of the ‘ordeal’ involving the friend?”

“Yes.” Hannah pulls her finger up out of the bubbles and places her hand over her hairline, overly dramatic.

“If he already knows about it, then what’s the worry? Brian wasn’t a part of the situation, was he?”

“No, he was here, fortunately.”

“I think your bases are probably covered, then.”

“They probably are.” Hannah holds her foamy hand out. “But I don’t know. Part of me is just expecting him not to come back tonight.” She flicks the bubbles off her fingers.

“What could Will have possibly done to freak this guy out so bad?”

“Oh.” Hannah sighs.

***

“Okay, explain to me what happened at your apartment yesterday.” Back at Tiger’s, Rob’s elbows are on the table. He leans in towards Brian as though he’s trying to draw some sense out of him. “Because you kinda just blew that off.”

Brian’s enthusiasm dwindles in his effort to reconcile the apartment mishap. “I didn’t mean to blow it off. It’s just, the situation wasn’t as critical as you made it out to be.”

With a short and skeptical grunt, Rob sways back in his seat. “What version of the story did you get? Because it was a pretty big deal. I just went over there as a concerned friend.”

“I know.” Brian slides his empty beer bottle to the edge of the table.

“I heard a loud noise, so I went inside. And this *very* intimidating guy kicked the door shut, tied me up with a television cord and pinned me to the ground

while another guy duct taped my mouth shut.”

A college-aged female bartender arrives at their table carrying another round of drinks. She cordially sets Rob’s whiskey and cola down on the table in front of him.

“Thanks Lisa.” Brian nods at the bartender and takes the fresh beer from her hand. She collects their empties and heads back behind the bar.

Rob lowers his voice. “How is that not a critical situation, Brian? Tell me.”

“Well...”

***

“Well?” With her phone held up to her ear, Hannah waits on pins and needles for a slice of Sam’s insight. The wall of bubbles has begun to collapse down around her shoulders. “I’m up against years of history, here.”

“Is Brian happy?”

“He sure seems to be.”

“So he knows what goes on there, and he knows what you’ll be expecting from him?”

“Yes, he’s moved in.” Hannah reminds her.

“What was his driving force, to let you recruit him in the first place?”

“Dissatisfaction. He’d grown fearless, cocky and borderline self-destructive, which led him to the dead end of monotony in his life. He thought he knew what was behind every corner until he met me and allowed me to re-instill fear into him.”

“The variability of fear ended the monotony.”

“And it brought him satisfaction. That was his driving force.” Hannah lifts her arm out of the bathwater. It’s coated in almond-scented bubbles.

“Makes sense.” Sam surmises.

“Yes, me explaining it to him made sense too, and me explaining it to you obviously makes sense.” She rests her elbow on the edge of the tub. “The question is, can he explain it to the outside world in a way that makes sense? Not only does he lack self-awareness, but he’s a MAN, Sam.” Hannah massages her temple.

“I understand that obstacle.”

“Then you understand why I’m panicking.”

“If he’s happy, and if he has found satisfaction, then he’ll find a way to explain it. History aside, I really think you’re worrying about nothing. I think you’re fine.”

“You’re probably right. It just seems too soon for him to face reality, to be back in normal life.”

***

When she sees the headlights of Black’s car turning into her driveway, Becky comes out the front door and pulls it closed behind her. She jogs down her front steps towards the Mercedes Roadster as Black gets out of it.

“Wow, and it’s even you picking me up,” she says in a blithe tone.

“Yes, I told you I’d give you the normal-life date you want.” Black walks over to open the passenger side door for Becky. He notices her off-the-shoulder white top and sprightly mood.

Becky gets into the car and flutters her lashes at Black. “So that means you have to tell me the truth, right?”

With his hand on the door, Black peers down at her. “I always tell you the truth anyway. You just don’t ask good questions.” He shuts the passenger door and gets in behind the wheel.

Becky watches him put the car in reverse, let up on the clutch and back out of her driveway. A raw, bluesy rock song by The White Stripes plays on his stereo. The streetlights along the road out of her neighborhood sporadically light Black’s calm profile inside the shadowy car.

“Where are we going?” She studies him up and down, from his profile to his hand pulling the stick shift into second gear.

“We’re just going for a drive. If there’s somewhere you want to stop, let me know.”

“Okay.”

He defers to Becky. “If that’s all right with you?”

“Yes, that’s fine.” She marvels at his change in demeanor. “Thank you for asking.”

“Don’t get used to it.” Black slows down at the stop sign at the end of her block and waits for the oncoming traffic.

Becky smiles, perusing around the inside of his car. She sees the silver mp3 player that’s plugged into a port in his center console. “Can I snoop through your music?”

“Yeah, go ahead.” Black turns right, heading out of the neighborhood.

“You don’t keep songs on your phone?” Becky picks up the mp3 player.

“I never have.”

“Hmm,” she pores over his music library and remarks, “you have got some unusual songs.”

***

Meanwhile at Tiger's lounge, a droll nineties tune churns out of the digital jukebox by the front door.

"I know the apartment thing. I know it was all very strange." Brian holds up his hand in acknowledgment.

"Not strange, scary." Rob retorts.

"Okay, scary. But it wasn't a threat to you, Rob. It was just a poorly handled situation." Brian ensures him. "Still a bad thing, but that's really all it was."

"So you *are* blowing it off."

Brian throws his head back in exasperation. Stuck in somewhat of a stalemate with Rob, Brian's attention wanders over to the front door where a couple of people are entering the lounge. He sees a familiar face and raises his hand in a brief, friendly wave then gets back to Rob across the table. "Listen, I'm not blowing anything off, okay? They made a bad call. They shouldn't have done that to you." Sincere, he adds, "And I'm sorry it happened. I really am."

Though Rob acts placated by his apology, he still can't seem to get past this sudden transformation in Brian. "I can't even believe we're having a conversation like this."

"It's definitely weird." Brian agrees. "But at least it's different." He takes a drink of his beer.

"This just doesn't sound like you. Are you doing all this because you wanted to nail that blonde so bad?"

Brian's eyes bulge. He swallows his mouthful of beer. "No, I don't even get to."

"Really?" Rob asks suspiciously.

"Really." He stares straight at Rob, giving him a grave look.

"Then what is your motivation?"

Brian's face relaxes into a grin. He starts talking glibly about the Mercer Estate. "Rob, if you were turned onto this place, you'd give Gary your notice and pack up your stuff, too."

"No, I don't think so."

"No? You'd rather grovel to some jackass client to keep him from pulling his service account day after day?"

"A paycheck's a paycheck." Rob takes a sip of his drink.

"So okay, if given the choice, you would reject an expense-free luxury life?" Brian challenges him.

"There's got to be some price to pay for that. Like abruptly giving up your life as you know it."

***

Ambient music quivers softly throughout Black's car. Becky is browsing Black's music library. She appears quite content to have the ability to ask him questions at will, such as,

"Have you ever been married?"

"No, you?"

"No," Becky says through a light laugh. "That seems like something I would've mentioned to you by now, knowing me."

"That's true." He agrees.

"What did you used to do? Before all of this, I mean?" She glimpses up from the mp3 player at Black.

"I went to school and worked as an actuary for a life insurance company."

"Hmm," Becky hums in surprise, "interesting."

"If you think I'm an asshole now, you should've known me back then."

"Why do you say that?" She pries, combing through his diverse music library.

"Are you familiar with the occupation?" he asks her.

"Yes. An actuary is a person who brings a fake bomb on a plane, because it decreases the chances of there being another bomb on the plane."

Black glances over at Becky with a slight smile. "Funny."

"Thanks," she whispers.

"Anyway, then about three years ago, I met Sam and... the rest is history."

Becky nods and sees him take a lighter out of his pocket. "So where do you live, then?"

Black pulls a half-smoked joint out of his cup holder ashtray. "A place out on the edge of town." He lights the joint.

***

"Yeah I mean, living on the property and helping out around there is part of the deal. But that's a small price tag. There's an open bar, all amenities, excellent food. The people there are cool as hell, and the place is crawling with women." Back at Tiger's, Brian flops back into his seat and picks up his beer.

"What kind of place is this?" Rob asks him.

"It's an underground, club, I guess you could say." He sips his beer, impervious to Rob's disapproving glare.

"You guess? I don't know, Brian. I really feel like you're making a bad decision, here."

“I think you’re blowing it out of proportion. Number one, this is not an irreversible decision.”

Rob exhales in comfort of the fact that his friend doesn’t necessarily view this as a permanent situation.

“And number two,” Brian adds, “I have every intention of keeping in touch and hanging out with all you guys. Nothing goes away except the things I want to leave behind.”

Upon hearing that Brian will still be around regularly, acceptance finally washes over Rob. “As long as you’re not totally falling off the radar.” His attitude lightens considerably. He picks up his drink.

“No, not at all.” Brian confirms, successfully putting the Rob issue to rest.

***

“So, this place where you live?” Becky interrogates Black behind the wheel. Beside him, his window is rolled down a couple inches.

“What about it?” He brings the joint up to his lips. It crackles when he takes a hit.

“Is it like a commune, or something?”

“No, not what you’re probably picturing.” Black offers Becky the joint. A thin curl of smoke escapes his mouth.

“No thanks.”

He blows a cloud of smoke out the window. “The property used to be a hunting lodge, like a weekend resort for game hunters. But the guy who owned the place started racking up gambling debts. Before he hit bottom, he sold the lodge to one of the members.” Black taps the joint into the ashtray. Its earthy aroma infuses the air.

“Who’s that?”

“Doesn’t really matter, the guy’s dead now. This was over fifty years ago.”

“Really?” Becky sets the mp3 player back down in Black’s console.

“Anyway, him and a few of the other members pitched in and redid the place. And in 1968, they started up a new club.”

“Do I ever get to see this place?” Becky cracks her window as smoke spreads through the car.

“Probably.”

“But you’re not gonna tell me when.”

“Of course not.”

Becky twists sideways in her seat. She confronts Black’s profile with a serious pout. “All right, then answer this for me.”

“What’s that?”

“How’d you know where I work?”

“Oh we’ve got surveillance software, hacking experts, all kinds of shit,” he answers nonchalantly. “There’s obviously GPS on that phone I gave you, too.”

Becky clenches her jaw at the extent of his resources, the sheer level at which he plays this so-called ‘game’.

Black seems oblivious to Becky’s astonishment. He takes another hit of the joint.

She collects herself enough to spit out a gasping reply. “Really?”

“Yeah, are you surprised?” He glances at her. “You wouldn’t believe the stuff we can find out about people.” Black snuffs his joint out in the ashtray. His focus reverts to the road. The meandering electronica song playing in the car drones on like a trippy backdrop to Becky’s unblinking pose.

“Huh, I guess you all take this *game* pretty seriously.”

“It’s all in fun.” He shrugs. “If something makes people happy and doesn’t cause any damage, then what’s the problem?”

Chapter 6

The next morning, Becky is seated at her office desk scrolling through work emails. She has a reflective glaze in her eyes. During their normal-life date, Black gave Becky enough insight for her to make an informed decision of whether to run like hell or choose to start a new chapter in life.

Becky looks up from the monitor. A stack of files lands on the corner of her desk. Her boss, Gary, steps back from her desk and slides his hands into the pockets of his black dress slacks.

“Now, I know you’re the newest person in the department, but I’m asking everybody to pitch in a little until we hire a replacement for Brian.”

“Oh, okay.” She reluctantly reaches for the stack of files.

“So I really need you to follow up on these accounts for me.”

With a sullen frown, Becky sets the files down by her keyboard. “I’ll let you know if I have any questions.”

“You do that.” Gary instructs her. He exits her office, leaving the door cracked. Becky sighs and flips open the first file on the stack. She skims through it.

Jackie pokes her head in the door. “How many did you get stuck with?”

“I don’t know.” Becky flips the file closed and runs her thumb down the side of the pile. “Half a dozen, I guess. Has anybody figured out what in the hell happened to Brian?”

“No.”

“Really?”

“Really. What are you doing for lunch?” Jackie asks.

“I think I’m gonna run home today.”

“Okay. Well, Gary’s making the rounds. I better get going.”

“See you later.”

Jackie disappears from the doorway. Becky continues glossing over the stack of Brian’s abandoned accounts. After a while, she pushes them aside and turns to her keyboard. She pulls up her bank on the computer and logs in. Becky clicks on the link to her checking account. She leans back in her desk chair, growing contemplative. She has enough money saved up to make it a year without a paycheck. Her gaze drifts from her checking account balance, over to the stack of Brian’s accounts, up to the clock in the corner of her monitor which reads 10:30 a.m.

***

Meanwhile, Hannah drinks the last of her fresh-squeezed orange juice and sets the empty glass down next to her banana peel. She directs her attention to Cade. “Let me borrow your seat, just for a minute. I’ve got a lower back spot.”

“Oh, I guess so.” Cade shifts over in the bubbling hot tub to the seat across from Black. That undesirable spot is wedged between two corner loungers that limit leg span room.

Hannah repositions until she’s satisfied with the jet that’s aimed at her lower back. “Ahh.” She briefly closes her eyes while adjusting to the jet’s pulse. Suddenly, Hannah’s eyes pop back open, bouncing back and forth between Cade and Black. “Before Cade gets back into his abduction blueprint, I thought you’d like to know that Brian happily returned home last night.” She broadcasts with gusto.

“You must be doing something right this time.”

Hannah ignores Cade’s remark and goes on. “Just to keep him on his toes, I had a little visit with him earlier this morning. Right,” she points to the pool, “over there.”

“About what?” Black asks.

“Me,” she tells him...

Hannah and Brian sit side by side in lounge chairs facing the pool. They each have a glass of fresh-squeezed orange juice. Across from them, the still pool water glistens under the rays of morning sun.

Hannah sets her banana down on the seat beside her. “Will said that everything went fine last night.”

“Yeah, it was all pretty much like I expected.” Brian reports.

“Good.” She abruptly switches the subject. “What type of porn do you generally watch, Brian?”

He thinks about it for a moment. “It’s not specific,” he frankly relays, “it’s kind of all over the place.”

“Mm-hmm, any niche, fetish?”

“Sure.” Brian chuckles at her. “All kinds of them.”

“Can you remember ever seeing the Profane Productions logo before?”

“Many, many times, yes.” Brian pauses in recollection. There’s a name associated with the production company. “Hannah Sedgwick is the elusive mastermind behind Profane Productions. I’ve read articles.” He stops talking and concentrates on Hannah with marked skepticism. “No.” He sees her furtive smile emerging. “No way.” Brian shakes his head. “You’re not Hannah Sedgwick.”

“Why, because that wouldn’t make any sense, or what?”

Brian hunches forward exhaling a rapt pant. “I don’t even know what to say. I was already ten kinds of intimidated by you, but. Hannah Sedgwick?” He gasps at the bombshell...

“You revealed that pretty early.” Cade notes.

“I thought that extra morsel would seal the deal, quell any lingering doubt.” Hannah reaches up out of the rippling water to tuck a stray strand of blonde hair behind her ear. “And you know, why keep it under wraps?”

“Yeah, you’re a producer, not a porn star.” Black smirks and drops deeper into the tub until his shoulders are submerged.

“Oh I’m a star, just not an actor. Besides, the only one who has a problem with it at all, is Random.”

“Anyway.” Cade cuts her off and turns to Black. “When we get back inside, can I swing by to go over a few things with you?”

“Bet you’ll be glad when this is over, tomorrow.” Hannah trades a sneer with Black.

“I have a feeling it won’t end there,” he tells her before answering Cade’s question. “But yeah, that’s fine.”

“Thank you.” Cade nods appreciatively.

Hannah stretches her tan arms over her head. “Well, I suppose I would’ve heard something if there was something to hear, but any word on Trip yet?”

“No. But I’m sure he’s getting by, at the very least.” Black presumes.

***

“Alive & Well”, a peculiar little song by Phantom Family Halo, thumps in the background of Trip’s room at Aunt Nelly’s Bed and Breakfast in Oklahoma. He’s sitting on the patchwork spread that covers the bed in his small room, flipping the page of the hardcover book he’s reading. Each page takes him longer to finish. Eventually his literary distraction fails him. Trip closes the book and places it on the knotty pine dresser beside him. His craving for true escapism draws him up off the bed and up to the bedroom window. Opaque white sheers are tied back on either side.

He stares out at the distant, vast farm fields veiled by overcast skies. Trip fixates on the heavy clouds in the sky, like they’re calling him to hunt down a filter. He backs away from the window and goes into the adjacent bathroom.

Trip flips on the light and closes the door behind him. The shabby chic bathroom has a prominent lavender color motif. He scans the bathroom sink

vanity, stopping at an apothecary jar full of cotton swabs. Trip lifts the jar's metal lid and digs out a couple of swabs.

He takes them back into his bedroom, over to the knotty pine dresser where his shoulder bag is lying. He reaches in and pulls out a small black bag. The unzipped bag reveals a few syringes inside. Trip stuffs the cotton swabs into the bag and keeps on gathering supplies.

He circles back to the nightstand, where his book is sitting beside his coffee mug from earlier that day. Inside the mug is a metal spoon. Trip snatches the filmy spoon out of his mug. He carries it into the bathroom.

Trip turns on the faucet and dispenses a pump of lavender-scented soap into his hand. He begins scrubbing the coffee film off the spoon, rinsing it off under the running water. There's no doubt about the direction he's heading.

***

"Where's Becky?" Gary steps up to the WPC reception counter. Jackie transfers a call, hangs up the phone and looks at him.

"Um, she's not in her office?" She checks the time on her computer. It's 2:25 p.m.

"I just went in there to check in on her, and her light's off."

"She said she was going home for lunch."

"It's almost two-thirty." He stresses.

"I guess she never came back from lunch."

"What the hell is going on around here?" Gary throws up his hands. "First Brian and now Becky?"

Jackie stalls, unsure of what to tell him.

***

Meanwhile, Black is seated in front of his laptop inside his office at the Mercer Estate.

Cade is on a barstool behind him holding an open file folder. "Random will be down between the front seats, and you'll be behind Jane with the blindfold."

Black glances over his shoulder at Cade. "At that point, she'll have her phone with her, then."

"Yeah, it'll be in the truck. But she won't be able to get to it."

"When are you putting the tracker on it?" Black turns to his computer and pulls up Becky's location on a GPS map. She is not at WPC. He checks the clock on his screen. It's 2:30 p.m., but she's not at work.

“Reno’ll take care of it once we get her here.” Cade clarifies. “Her purse will end up back in her car.”

“Okay.” A twinge of concern crosses Black’s face when he realizes Becky’s at home. “Wait a minute.”

***

The television is on in the living room of Becky’s townhouse that afternoon. It sits across from her couch on a TV stand. The bottom shelves display vacation trinkets, books and candles.

She walks out of her bedroom with a basket of laundry. Two phones are sitting on the long table behind her couch. Her new phone begins ringing. She sees Black’s name displayed on the screen and answers the call. “Hello?”

“Why aren’t you at work?” Black asks on the other line.

“What?” Becky sets her laundry basket down on the floor.

“Why didn’t you go back to work, today?”

“How in the hell would you know that?” She wanders around to the front of her couch.

“The phone, Becky,” he tells her in an impatient voice.

“AH yes. You’re tracking my every move. How could I forget?”

“Tell me what’s going on.”

“I made another decision.” Becky timidly announces, sinking down onto her couch.

“To quit your job? What for?”

“I think it’s rational to assume that you do not have a traditional day job. So, how realistic would it be for me to advance in this game with one?”

“What is your point?”

“I’d like to speed things up a bit.” She admits.

“That’s not your call to make.”

“I realize that. But worst-case scenario, my job would take me back in a heartbeat.” Becky’s bold statement is underlined with plea.

“Why are you so sure?”

“Because Brian quit this week, so they’re already a person short.” She reveals and plunges back into the couch cushion...

Back in Black’s office, he’s on his laptop busily hacking into Becky’s home computer. Cade is no longer in there.

On the other line, Becky continues making her case to him. “And one of my co-workers knows that I went home for lunch. So I’d say I was sick, I stayed home.”

Black searches through Becky's picture files and runs across one titled, 'Me and Brian'. He clicks open the file, a picture of Becky with Brian. It's a different image than the framed photo he briefly saw at her townhouse the night she made him a mojito.

"Listen Becky, it's a little soon for you to be quitting your job. And why do I have to remind you that you're not running the show?" Black opens a message box on his screen, below the picture of Becky and Brian. He starts typing a message to Hannah.

"Please, just let me do this." She implores him.

"Why do you *want* to do this?" he asks and sends the message to Hannah. It reads, 'send me a picture of Brian'.

"I've asked myself that. And I keep coming back to the same answer: why not? I'm twenty-nine, and I have never stepped outside of the box of normality. I've been doing exactly what's expected of me ever since I was a kid. I've gone to school, held a job, paid my bills and been a good little citizen."

The picture file from Hannah arrives promptly. It opens up to a shot of Brian, unconscious and lying on his stomach. He has a ball gag hanging from his neck. His hands and feet are bound to the legs of a weightlifting bench below.

"And it's time." Becky reasons. "It's time that I make a choice that isn't safe, for once. I know you hold the cards though, so please tell me it's okay to just bite the bullet and do this."

"Be ready to go at eight o'clock tonight." He hangs up on Becky. The two pictures of Brian from two different sources are opened up on his laptop. Fixed on the screen, Black raises his fingertips to his cheeks. He covers his mouth, muttering, "Fuh-huh-ck..." through a short, disparaging laugh. Black runs his hands over his face and drops his palms to the desk.

***

The small dining room in Babe's family's farmhouse is a bit dated but squeaky clean. Its walls are a pale rust color and display a few old family portraits in ornate plaster frames. A plain chandelier hangs above the table full of home-cooked food.

Despite the sound of a TV in the next room, the rural house seems much too quiet for Trip. He looks across the table at Babe and takes in the comfort of her warm smile. She is seated between her younger brother, a slim eighteen-year-old with strawberry blonde hair, and her father, Ray, who's in his late forties.

Babe's mother walks in from the kitchen and swipes the plastic jug of gin off the table. "Ray, this ain't the guest bottle." Caroline's golden brown ponytail

swings as she disappears into the kitchen.

Trip picks up his fork, holding it over his plate of pot roast and vegetables.

“Drinks the same.” Ray grumbles and peers at Trip. “So what kinda name is ‘Trip’, anyway?” Babe’s rugged father cuts into his slab of roast, and her younger brother chuckles.

“Daddy.” She hisses at him.

“What? I wondered if it was short for somethin’.”

“No, you’re not the first person to ask.” Trip stabs a hunk of potato with his fork. “It’s a nickname my dad gave me years ago, because we moved around a lot, my mom and I did.” He eats the hunk of potato while Babe’s wide-eyed mother sails back into the dining room with the *glass* bottle of gin. She has a gin and tonic in her other hand.

Caroline hands the drink to Trip and takes her seat at the table. “It’s a gin and tonic.”

“Thank you.” Trip sets the drink down in front of him.

“Where all have you lived?” Caroline is fit and pretty, dressed in a white and yellow checkered camp shirt and white shorts. She’s openly intrigued by the young stranger her daughter has brought home.

Trip smiles at Caroline. “It’s kind of a long story.”

“We got nothin’ but time sugar, go right ahead.” Her twang is much more pronounced than Babe’s. Caroline begins eating her meal and focuses on Trip. The rest of the family all follows in suit.

Trip notices Caroline’s dominant flair. He obliges her request. “All right.” Trip sets his fork down and eases back in his chair a bit. “My dad’s from Woodcliff, as you already know.” He picks up his drink. “So it started when my mom decided to leave my dad and move to Las Vegas. I was two at the time, but I guess she worked in a couple casinos.” He tries a sip of the gin and tonic. “This is good, thank you.”

“You’re welcome. Go on, now.” Caroline nudges him along.

“Anyway, my mom was always searching for her version of Mr. Right. And when I was six, she married her second husband. Rick was a gambling addict, so we had to move away from Vegas. We ended up in L.A. where he got hooked on smack, anyway.” Trip shrugs apathetically. “She filed for divorce, and we left L.A. right away. She couldn’t afford to live there.” He divulges.

“Mm-hmm.” Caroline spreads honey on a biscuit and nods at Trip, urging him to continue.

“After L.A., we worked our way back east and spent a few years in Oklahoma City. By the time I was fourteen, we’d settled in New Orleans. And I made it through most of high school there. But at the end of my junior year, my

mom met this guy, *Derek*," he says with contempt, "at the bar she worked at. He was in town from New York on business, and conveniently enough, our lease was almost up."

"So you moved to New York?" Caroline picks up the bottle of gin, topping off her and Ray's glasses.

"We did, but it was brief. Before *Derek* could get her to the altar, mom caught the eye of this rich old Italian swinger. And he moved us out to Italy at the beginning of my senior year. So, tragically, that's how things ended with *Derek*." He sips his drink.

"I get the feelin' you didn't much care for Derek." Babe observes.

"I couldn't stand that guy."

"So'd you finish school in Italy?"

"No, I never did," he tells Babe. "Well, I got my GED later on. But once I got out to Italy, I didn't see the point of school. We were pretty well off and I kind of, just didn't have a lot of direction, honestly." Trip sets his glass down on the table. "But Giancarlo was a great guy. I liked him a lot, and my mom was with him for the longest."

"What happened to him?" Caroline asks.

"He had a heart attack at age fifty-eight."

"Oh no," Babe says sympathetically.

"Yeah. A couple years later, I came back to the states." Trip glances over at Ray, whose face is riddled with indifference. "So anyway, it's not a story I tell to brag, or anything."

"At least you're honest." Caroline belts out in an assuring tone. "There's somethin' to be said for that."

***

Becky follows Black through the door of Trudy's tavern, a loud, dim nightclub. Green LED lighting casts a murky glow on the white ceilings above. The psychedelic melody of an odd rockabilly tune rambles throughout the club.

"What is this place?" Becky heaves uncomfortably. Nearby, a large-chested, brunette cocktail waitress passes drinks out to a table of men in suits. The waitress's big boobs are popping out of a bright coral bikini top. "Is this a strip club?" Becky asks as they sit down at a tall cocktail table along the wall by a small dance area.

"No. Sometimes they dance on the bar, but they wear clothes. Hey, it's ladies' night, so you call it for five bucks."

“Sounds great.” Becky gripes and sees the brunette cocktail waitress approach their table.

“What are you two having?”

“A rum and Coke; Becky?”

“That’s fine.” Becky sets her purse down on the table.

“Two.”

The waitress heads for the bar. Becky rolls a round Amstel coaster back and forth on the table in front of her, conveying her unrest.

“You are extra annoying tonight.” Black plucks the coaster away from Becky and lays it down on the table between them.

“Well, this is a bigger deal to me now that I left my job.”

“Whose fault is that?”

“It’s all mine, I’m not denying that. But because of it, I feel like the pressure’s on now.”

Black tilts his head at Becky. “I’m pretty sure you’d still have your job if you go back in tomorrow.” He patronizes her.

“No, that’s not what I’m saying. It’s just like, I’m committed to this now. So I have to succeed, you know?”

“I do.” He replies with an understanding nod.

Becky finds some solace in Black’s genuine expression, so she segues into a different topic. “I’m curious about something.”

“What’s that?”

“Will we ever have regular old sex, ever?”

“You’re under no obligation.” Black informs her.

“It’s not an obligation. Don’t you even want to check this out,” she points at her crotch, “this thing you challenged me to get?”

“Ever heard of Epictetus?”

“What?” Becky flares her nostrils, baffled by his question. “Is that a place, or a person?”

“You haven’t. Too bad, he was an interesting guy. Anyway, he said, ‘People feel disturbed, not by things, but by the views which they take of things’.”

“Okay, so he must’ve been a philosopher. I’ve never heard of him.” She arches her brows and waits for Black to continue.

“Did you hear what I just said, though? The piercing itself is not a big deal. You perceive it as a big deal.”

“Was that supposed to answer my question somehow?”

“It was supposed to explain that you’re putting way too much emphasis on that thing.” Black gestures across the table and down to Becky’s lap. “That ring wasn’t even my decision. You can take it out for all I care.”

“What do you mean it wasn’t your decision?” she asks through an uneasy laugh.

“I didn’t make that call. My friend at the tattoo parlor decided to make the wager a ring.”

“You told him to, though. Right?”

“I told him to pick *something*.”

Becky puts her elbows on the table and cradles her face in her hands. “What is with the endless mind games?” She looks at Black, who smiles at her.

“What were you expecting?”

“I don’t know what I was expecting.” Exasperated by his charades, Becky slides her elbows off the table and waves her hand over her lap. “So, this isn’t even something you’re into. I have this on my body for no reason.”

“The fact that you got it, is what I’m into, you see?”

“The obedience?”

“Yes. This really isn’t about sex, Becky.”

“It has to be.” She leans back in her barstool and folds her arms over her lap.

“No, it doesn’t. Sex is just the playground. Control is the real incentive.”

“Then what about at the club? What’s orgasm, then?”

“It’s a tool. You need to quit grappling with these questions.” Black scans the bar, zeroing in on a few black couches grouped together in the corner.

“Well it’s difficult, because you don’t tell me anything.”

“And you should be content with that.” He winds away from the leather couches and settles back onto Becky. “But you’re not, because you can’t seem to tap into your submissive role.”

“So guide me.”

“Okay. I want you to do something for me, a test.”

Becky gets serious. She sits up straight in her stool. “Yes?”

He directs her to a leather couch near the dance area. “See those black couches over there in the corner?” Black asks.

“I do.”

“See the two women sitting on them?”

A redhead (the Spinner) is sitting on the couch next to a blonde (Shay).

“Yeah, with that guy in the baseball hat.”

“Who’s talking to the redhead, right?”

“Um.” Becky assesses the women on the couch. The Spinner is monopolizing the attention of a young, athletic-built guy with a beer in his hand. “It looks like it, why?”

“She’s here for ladies’ night, the redhead is.” Black persists. “She drug her friend along with her for company, but she’s here to find a man.”

“And how would you know that?” After a pondering beat, Becky asks, “Do you know them? You do, don’t you?”

Black picks up the tempo. “Watch the redhead’s body language.” He speaks quickly, keeping Becky engaged in his words. “She’s leaning into him, flirting, ignoring her friend. She just met that guy here, tonight.”

“Okay. So what?”

“Why’s the blonde here?”

Becky crunches her nose, flagrantly dumbfounded. “How would I know?”

“Because these are the things you need to pay attention to, to read people. I’m gonna guess she’s here for the ladies, or at least curious.”

“That’s reaching, Black.”

“Is it, Becky?” He bends in over the table towards her. “Look at her. She’s hiding behind her friend in the corner over there. She’s not jumping into the conversation. She’s not putting herself out there for a guy to hit on her. It’s ladies’ night at a predominantly male bar.”

“Maybe she’s just keeping her single friend company at the bar. What does any of this have to do with anything?”

“Your test is to find out whether or not I’m right about the blonde.”

“So you want me to hit on a woman?”

“Basically.”

The waitress shows up at the table with their cocktails. “Sorry about the wait.” She sets the drinks down on their respective coasters.

“Keep the change.” Black hands her cash.

The waitress winks in appreciation and moves along to the next table.

“You obviously know I’m straight.” Becky picks up her drink.

“It’s not like you’re taking her home. Just strike up a conversation.”

“How am I supposed to find out her sexual orientation?”

Black lets out an agitated sigh. “Figure it out. You work in sales for Christ’s sake.” He glances back at the couches. “Here’s your chance, the redhead’s going to dance with the guy right now.”

“I think you’re trying to trick me.” Becky homes in on the two women on the couch. The Spinner is dragging the guy in the baseball hat out onto the dance floor.

“If you wanna debate me on this, we can just call it a night. Or you can rise to the occasion. Your choice.”

Becky gives him a defiant smirk and slides off of her barstool.

***

After supper at Babe's family's farmhouse, Trip kicks back on a white wooden porch swing outside on the front porch. Crickets chirp in the distance.

"That didn't go so bad, huh?" Babe hands Trip a beer and sits down beside him.

"No, no it didn't go bad at all. I'm sure your dad thinks I'm worthless, but other than that."

"Nah, daddy's just that way." She insists. "You did fine." Babe pats Trip's thigh and rubs it a little to put him at ease. "Mama liked you and said you're welcome back tomorrow, if you care to."

"Speaking of 'mama', I have to admit, I noticed an interesting dynamic in there." Trip motions to the house.

"What's that?"

"For being what I would consider a traditional family unit, your mother is very assertive."

"Oh yeah, she totally runs the roost. She's a big personality."

"I found that interesting." He sets his unopened beer down on the porch.

"Hey, why don't I go grab a throw blanket and we can go sit back there, out in the woods." Babe enthusiastically offers. Off to the side of the house, there's a thick patch of trees.

"Sure." Trip stands up from the porch swing while Babe runs inside to get a blanket. She returns a few moments later with a black and red checkered throw in her hand and a cheerful glimmer on her face.

They walk down the porch steps and across the lawn to the woods.

"What was your high school like?" Trip asks her.

"The only high school 'round here is at the church."

"Is that right?"

"Unless you wanna take the bus to another town. Which we didn't, so we went to school at the church."

"Did you wear a uniform?"

"Uh yeah," Babe smiles, "I did." She leads him towards a clearing between two huge trees that are holding up thick branches full of leaves.

"I'd love to see it sometime," Trip tells her, barefaced.

"Whatever you say." Babe shakes her head at him and spreads the blanket out on the grass.

"I know I'm a little strange. It's just what I believe." Trip lowers himself down onto the blanket and lies on his back, resting his head on his hands.

"You believe in bein' strange?" She teases and sits cross-legged beside him.

Trip glances over at her. "I believe in being authentic, which can come off as strange." He gazes up at the sky. "We're raised to believe that repressing spares

us from being hurt. When in reality, it's resistance that causes the true pain."

Babe listens with wonder.

"So, it's a self-fulfilling prophecy if you let yourself get sucked into it."

"How do you avoid gettin' sucked into it?"

"Stop regretting, things in general, I mean." Trip bluntly responds.

"Ain't that kind of a cold way to be?"

"That depends on how much you have to regret in the first place. That's what makes you a cold person or not. Everything you do in life is representative of it."

"So then if you don't do much at all..." Babe retreats mid-sentence.

"Life is always changing, Babe. Don't ever think you have to get stuck in one spot for too long. It's a matter of staying true to yourself."

***

At Trudy's tavern, Becky's wearing a mask of confidence and closing in on the blonde. "Hey." She walks up to the arm of the black leather couch and beams at her.

"Hi." Shay appears amiable but curious. A '90s alternative song with subdued lyrics floats through the air.

"Mind if I sit with you for a minute?"

"No, I don't mind. My friend just ditched me."

"My name's Becky, by the way." She has a seat on the couch, clutching her drink.

"I'm Molly, nice to meet you." Shay notices Becky's eager energy.

"It's nice to meet you too. This is the first time I've been here."

"Oh yeah? Who are you here with?"

Becky signals across the bar at Black. "That guy over there."

Shay casually checks him out. "Is that your boyfriend?"

"Oh no, God forbid." Becky rolls her eyes. When she sees the mystified frown on Shay's face, she adds, "He's my brother."

"Huh. So, whose idea was it to come here, then?"

"Mine, actually." Becky exchanges a brief and awkward smile with Shay. She looks down at her drink. "Would it bother you if I told you that I was attracted to you?" Becky glimpses up to see Shay's unassuming reaction.

"No, it wouldn't bother me."

"I'm glad."

"I'm flattered," Shay tells her. "I've never been randomly approached before. By a woman, that is."

"Yeah I know what you mean. And you're okay with it?"

“Sure I am. So, tell me something about yourself.”

“Well.” Becky hesitates. She was so focused on getting to this stage of Black’s test that she’s unsure of what to say at this juncture. So she wings it with honesty. “I’m recently unemployed.”

Shay’s thin brows arc up. She reaches for her bottle of water on the end table next to the couch. “You’re kidding.”

“No, why?”

“So am I.”

Becky perks up in surprise. “Really?”

“Really. I just got fed up one day.” Waving her hand, Shay chugs some of her water before carrying on the performance.

***

Moonlight peeks through the leaves above Trip. He’s lying on the black and red checkered blanket, soaking in the peaceful surroundings while Babe sits next to him, fidgeting.

“I’m afraid I don’t know as much about those things as you do, though.” She chews her bottom lip in thought, exhibiting her desperation to come up with a story of her own to contribute to Trip’s worldly views. Babe stares off into the distance and just starts rambling. “But, have you ever just been sittin’ on the porch, your porch, or your neighbor’s, whoever’s– early on in the mornin’ cause you just couldn’t sleep past five?”

With wide eyes, Trip shakes his head no.

“And you’re drinkin’ coffee, the air is chilly and you’re watchin’ the sun come up. Grandpa, or the neighbors, whoever, give you some small talk and all, but they leave you be after a while cause they feel it too.”

“Feel what, Babe?”

“So good, to not have anybody expectin’ a damn thing from you that early on in the mornin’.”

Trip cracks up at her analogy. “What?”

“No, really. I know my words aren’t sophisticated but hear me out, Trip.”

“I’m listening.”

“It’s such a comfortable feelin’ a-and I know it’s somethin’ to do with nature and all, but it’s more than that to me. It’s havin’ this level of respect, with either Grandpa or Tom the neighbor, this understandin’ to mind your own and enjoy the moment. It just really feels good to me, you know?”

“Oh, I know all too well.” Trip nods empathetically. “That’s why I like you so much.”

“Why?”

“Because you’re genuine. You shouldn’t feel guilty for taking time out to feel good. That’s really important, because if a person can’t be honest with themselves, well?”

“How can you expect them to be honest with you, then, right?” Her drawl is slight, sweet and reeling Trip in.

“That’s exactly right.” He looks up at her.

“I knew there had to be some reason you were hangin’ out with a plain girl like me.”

“How could you say that? I still can’t believe you’re giving me the time of day.”

Babe studies his dark, child-like eyes. “I can tell you why.”

“Why?” His voice is low, and his vibe is soft.

“Because you’re genuine, too. And you’re takin’ time to get to know me.”

“It makes me feel good.”

She whispers, “Me too,” and bends down until her face is inches away from Trip’s. Crickets chirp in the woods around them.

“Kiss me.”

Daringly buoyant, she leans in further and touches her mouth to his.

Trip reaches up for Babe’s face, grazes her cheek with his fingers and shoves them into her shiny blonde hair. He grasps the back of Babe’s head in his hand. Increasing his intensity, he coerces her mouth open wider and pushes deeper in.

Babe panics and pulls out of the kiss. She breathily says, “Oh, Trip. I better go. Before I do somethin’ I shouldn’t.” She slaps her hand flat on his chest and pushes herself upright.

Trip puts his hand over hers. “No, I would never cross that line, believe me.” He sounds almost anxious. Trip runs his fingertips over the back of Babe’s hand.

“It’s just, uh,” she stammers in uncertainty, “if you feel anythin’ close to how I feel right now.”

“I do.” He guarantees her.

“Then we might both get caught up in the moment.” Babe watches Trip sit up and hold her hand in his. “Please don’t be mad.”

“I’m not mad. Don’t think that.” He kisses the back of her hand before letting it go. “Hey, if I’m lucky I’ll get to see you sometime tomorrow.”

Babe flashes him a kittenish smile. “Oh you’ll be lucky for sure. But I gotta go.”

“Okay.” Trip shrugs acceptingly, and they both stand up. He picks up the checkered blanket, shaking off the grass and leaves before handing it over to Babe.

“How ‘bout you lemme know when you get done at the hospital tomorrow?” She starts folding up the blanket.

“I’m not gonna go until Saturday. I called them earlier today and told them I was in town, though.”

“Called your family?”

“No, the hospital.”

“Oh.”

Trip hasn’t given her too many details about the situation he’s in, and she’s surely not going to pressure him. Instead she asks,

“So you’re free tomorrow, then?”

“Yeah.” He’s already arranged to push the inevitable until the day of his flight back to California. Since his father is an only child with no living parents, Trip has no reason to stick around for the informal memorial service being held by his father’s co-worker friends. He plans to fly home once the deed is done. Trip takes Babe’s hand and heads out of the woods. “I’ll walk you back to the house.”

***

Back at Trudy’s tavern, Becky moves across the hardwood floor in a bold stride, returning to Black’s table. “I got her number.” She smugly notifies him. “So go ahead and gloat. I was wrong.” Becky slides onto the barstool across from Black with her cocktail napkin and self-assurance.

Black takes the napkin from her and sees the name ‘Molly’ written above a phone number. He blows out a quiet snort of laughter. “Molly.” Crushing the napkin into his fist, Black watches Becky’s alarmed reaction.

“What are you doing? Give that back.”

“Oh, I’m sorry. Were you into her?”

“Well no.”

“Then what do you need with this?” Black drops the napkin ball onto the table in front of Becky.

“The least I could do is call her and be honest about it.” Becky picks up the napkin ball. She sees that Black is unhappy with her but clueless about what she did wrong.

“Are you ready to get out of here?”

“Uh, sure.”

“So what are you gonna tell her?” Black knocks back the last sip of his drink and stands up.

“That I was drinking, and I gave her the wrong impression.” Becky grabs her purse and hops off the barstool.

“Now why would you go and do that? The test is over.” He leads her to the green-lit exit sign.

“Well because. Because I think it’s the right thing to do.”

Black holds the door open for Becky. “Wrong answer,” he says as they step outside to the parking lot. “Besides, you can’t call her anyway.”

“What are you talking about?”

“Try the number.”

While walking to Black’s car, Becky is overcome with a stark wave of foolishness and frustration. “So you *do* know her.”

They stand by the passenger side door of his Mercedes.

“Of course I know her.” Black lectures Becky. “I would never put you in any uncontrolled situation with a stranger. We create illusions. That’s the mind game.” He opens the door for Becky, circles around to the other side and gets into his car. He starts the ignition and pulls out of the parking lot.

The tension between them surges inside the car.

“What was the point of it?” she asks sharply.

“It was a test to see if you can separate your actions from your emotions. And I’ve gotta tell you, it doesn’t look promising.”

They speak to each other in a way they never have. Black stays fixed on the road while Becky barks at his profile.

“Why would you say that? Is this what gets you off? Making an ass out of me?”

“It’s not even for me, it’s for you.”

“Oh, that is such bullshit. You CHOOSE to belittle me. And why is that?” Becky keeps lashing out, even though it’s obviously pissing him off. “Do you get some sick thrill off that, too?”

“NO BECKY, I resort to it.”

After a perplexed wince, she asks, “You and this game...what kind of people are you, anyway?”

“Hedonists.”

“Hedonists?”

“Yeah. The ‘kind of people’ who admit their innate truth and become it.” Black diverts his eyes from the road to glare at Becky for a moment. “Except we’re the ones who get commissioned by *other* hedonists who have day jobs, and we take their money. In return, we provide them with illusions. I make a living off my acting abilities and my imagination.”

“Is that so?” Becky replies, thick with sarcasm. “That’s a big jump for an actuary.”

“Haven’t you ever heard of an alter ego?”

“Of course I have.”

Black angrily belts out the question: “Who do you think Black is?”

This revelation and candor stuns Becky silent, but only for an instant. She rebuts furiously. “Ok. So, what, you all just nurture your alter egos by jacking around with other people’s lives?”

Black pulls up to Becky’s garage door and leaves the car running. Though he is still visibly livid, Black manages to end the conversation with his distinctive smooth logic. “I hate to break it to you, but like everyone else involved, you’re a willing participant.” He reaches across Becky’s lap and opens the passenger side door. “And they’re not hard to find.” Black gestures for Becky to get out of his car.

***

Later that night, Shay, Vienna and Geneva are gathered in the hot tub for a nighttime soak. A few pillar candles flicker away on the limestone decking around the three Tops. There is a silver wine bucket on the edge of the tub, and the bottle inside is turned upside down.

Shay has a partial glass of red wine in one hand. She places her other hand on the upside-down bottle in the bucket. “I seriously can’t believe that no one has noticed this empty and brought us a new bottle, yet.”

Black approaches the hot tub carrying a rolled towel in his hand.

“Tell me you have a bottle of Shiraz wrapped up in that towel, Black.” Geneva lifts her arm out of the warm water to aim a finger at his towel.

“I do not.”

“Damn.” She crunches her fist in the air with exaggerated disappointment. Her empty wine glass is on the edge of the tub behind her.

Black drops his towel and yanks down the zipper of his black sweatshirt. He tosses the sweatshirt down on his way into the tub. Shay notes his gloomy disposition.

“I think we’re gonna have to call somebody.” Vienna polishes off the last sip of her wine and sets her glass aside.

Black scopes out the bright blue light in the tub and the heavy layer of steam rising up from its surface. He sinks down into the bubbling water. “It feels different in here at night.” He settles into the seat between Geneva and Vienna, across from Shay.

“Well hi there.” Shay greets him through the haze. “Don’t usually see you in here after dark.”

“It was a bad night.”

“How come?” Vienna asks him.

“I don’t think Becky’s gonna work out, here.”

“What? I thought the scene at Trudy’s earlier went great.” Shay claims.

“It went to hell after we left. Her emotions got the best of her tonight.”

“Why, what happened?” Shay takes a sip of her wine.

“She wanted to straighten things out with you. She wouldn’t let it go, so I admitted that you were just a plant and she flipped.”

“Pretty bad, huh?”

“Oh yeah,” he tells Shay. “She lost it. Said she didn’t like being tricked and accused us all of nurturing our alter egos by jacking around with peoples’ lives.”

“Hmm.” Vienna stews on that while Black goes on.

“So I thought about it on the drive back here, and I don’t think it’s worth the effort to try and break her. Not for me, anyway.” He rationalizes to Vienna.

“Maybe you’re just still mad about what happened tonight.” She suggests.

“It’s more than that.” Black sets her straight. “The only sign of submission I see from her, is faking it for the sake of her own agenda.”

“Which is?”

“I don’t think she even knows.” Black huffs out a short laugh. He pulls his hand out of the water. “On top of that,” he points at the house, “her ex is living here under Hannah, thanks to some weird twist of fate.”

“Brian?” Shay blurts out, flabbergasted by the news.

Black nods at her and ducks his hand back down into the warm water.

Geneva turns to him with a percolating stare. “What do you do that gets to her the most?”

“I don’t know.” He looks down at the bright blue light illuminating the water. “Ignore her.” He shrugs at Geneva.

“Then ignore her and see how she reacts. Make your final call based on that.”

“Yeah, I guess that’s fair. I need a break from her anyway with Cade’s abduction coming up tomorrow.”

“Absolutely.” Shay affirms. “And you know it would feel like such a waste to just drop the investment you’ve made in her so far. At least make sure you’re really done with her.”

“You know what.” Vienna chimes in with her typical pragmatic idea. “You might even tell her that. Tell her you’re done with her. Regain the control that she sucked away from you tonight. For yourself even, not even for her.”

“That’s good.” Black lauds her. “That’s good advice, Vienna.”

Shay raises her wineglass up and tips it towards him. “After you ignore her.” She swallows the last sip.

“Of course.”

“And after you grab us a bottle of wine.” Geneva leisurely adds.

“Go get it yourself or shut up about it.”

Geneva stiffens up. “Who are you talking to?” She balks at Black, arching her brows.

He chuckles at her and relaxes into the steamy cerulean water.

***

Random steps into the sun-filled living room of Black’s suite and sees a spray of silky blonde hair hanging over the back of the grey couch. Stretching her bare arms out along the back cushion, Marsa is completely sunken down into the couch. Contemporary reggae music dances through the living room, but it’s not loud enough to drown out the buzzing sound coming from the couch.

Random hesitates before proceeding into the living room. “Where’s Reno? Is he around?”

Reno emerges up from the front cushion of the couch, facing Random with a detail trimmer in his hand. “Hey.” He turns off the trimmer momentarily to wipe it off on a white towel. Reno tosses the towel aside and disappears back down into Marsa’s crotch area. The trimmer buzzes.

Smiling, Random says, “That is definitely not what I thought was happening in here.”

Marsa peeks back over her shoulder at Random. “He’s carving me a monkey.”

“Shaving.” Reno corrects her from his squatted position.

“I know.”

“Out here on the couch?” Random punctuates his question with disgust.

Reno pulls back and studies his work, lightly scratching his jaw. “Bathroom wasn’t working out. Can’t beat natural light. Have a seat.” He dives back in and resumes sculpting.

“I’m not staying long.” Random wanders over to lean against the living room wall. His trademark visage of relaxed confidence rarely leaves his face. “All set for tonight?” he asks Reno about Cade’s game plan, which is going down later that day.

“Why?” Reno groans. “Does Cade want to get together again before we leave?”

“I don’t think so.”

“Good.” Reno’s dread dissolves in a snap. “Has anybody heard from Trip yet?”

“Nope,” Random answers with a slight headshake.

“Wonder what he’s up to.”

“We shall see.”

“So, have you figured out who’s going in Vienna’s suite when she leaves?”

Random, who’s overtly miffed that Reno would even bring up the topic in front of one of Black’s subordinates, doesn’t respond.

Reno’s head pops up from the couch. He notices Random’s frown of disapproval and wipes off the trimmer blade. “What?” He glances at Marsa. “Marsa? Everybody knows Vienna’s moving.”

“Yup,” Marsa says as Reno descends back down into the couch cushions, out of Random’s view.

“That’s not the point. Certain things just aren’t meant for open conversation.” He emphasizes to Reno before answering him. “Anyway, at the rate Black’s moving, I might have to think about leaving Vienna’s suite open for Becky.”

“I know. Who’d have guessed that one?”

“I’m kidding about the suite, of course.”

“No shit.” Reno blazes back at his needless clarification.

“But what is it about Black, anyway?” Random picks Marsa’s brain. “Do you know? You live with him.”

Marsa flings her head back dreamily. “He is so easy to be around, and yet exhilarating to be around at the same time.”

“Exhilarating?” With a confounded glower, Random folds his arms together in front of him. “In what way?”

“With certain types of people you know exactly what to expect for the most part.”

Reno’s head pops up briefly to wipe off the trimmer blade. He disappears back down into the cushion.

After that well-timed example, Marsa continues mooning. “But guys like Black are unpredictable, and you go into it having no idea what to expect. It turns out, you really shouldn’t expect anything from him but, even though he’s quiet, he’s intense. You can tell he really pays attention to you and it’s...”

“Creepy?” Random interjects at her lull.

“No. It’s like, flattering, and he really makes you want to try him out. But you can’t.”

“Unlike Reno.” Random quips.

“Well *why not*?” Reno asks through a free-spirited laugh.

“I just thought you were gonna say he was funny, to be honest.” Random looks at Marsa.

She tilts her head. “He’s actually not super funny.”

“You do realize he could walk in here any minute, right?” Reno points out. “This is his suite.”

***

Later that day, the baroque lamps on Hannah’s antique nightstands fill her tranquil master bedroom with an amber glow. The curtains are closed over her poolside windows. Sitting upright in her bed, Hannah rests back on a colorfully eclectic collection of pillows. Her legs are crossed at the ankles, and her laptop is on her thighs. She’s quite casual in a long-sleeved t-shirt and shorts.

Hanging up on the wall behind her is an abstract erotic painting of a nude woman facing off with a white lion, done on a black velvet canvas. It bears a resemblance to the one in Black’s office, but it’s quadruple the size.

Over by the bedroom door, the rich scent of jasmine wafts up from a burning stick of incense on her maple roll-top desk. The door opens up.

Cade slips into the bedroom and walks over to Hannah. He stands at the side of her bed. She ignores his presence, tapping on her keyboard. He slides his hands into his pant pockets. “Well, this is it.”

“Oh believe me.” She glances up at him. “I know.” Then she gets back to scrolling.

“Sorry I’ve been such a pain in the ass with this abduction, lately.”

“It’s all right.” Hannah reclines back. “Honestly,” she remarks to Cade in a frank manner, “I really hope this girl comes around for you. You’ve gone to a lot of trouble for her.”

Taken aback, Cade promptly returns an equally heartfelt response. “If you would have ever been an option, like *ever*, I’d have gone to just as much trouble for you, beautiful.”

Hannah shoots him an endearing smile. “Good luck tonight, Cade.”

“Thank you, Hannah.” He smiles back at her and turns to leave the bedroom.

***

Fifteen massage tables are scattered around the dimly lit activity room at the Community Health Center that evening. Each table holds a volunteer, who is receiving a massage from one of the fifteen students. Mindfully placed room dividers offer sufficient privacy to the partially undressed volunteers. The

delicate sound of a wind chime trickles through the air, courtesy of the meditation music playing in the room.

Jane Bostick bends sideways over her male volunteer's firm, bare back. She glides her thumbs up the sides of his neck and applies a light pressure at the base of his head. Sweeping her thumbs outward, she moves them back down to his neck and repeats the motion. Jane serenely works through the final phase of the massage. She's a coltish beauty in her late twenties with a lean build and dark glossy hair, which is up in a ponytail. Tonight, she's comfortably dressed for her clinical in a pale pink, zipped hoodie and black cotton pants.

The class instructor, a somewhat frumpy and mellow woman in her fifties, ambles over to the doorway. She reaches for the dimmer switch on the wall near the door. "All right, students and guests, this concludes our session." She bumps up the dimmer switch, gradually brightening the activity room lights. "I would like to thank all of our guests for volunteering your time for our clinical this evening. I hope that you all leave here feeling much more relaxed than when you arrived."

A buzz of positive reactions swarms through the room, settling down into a low murmur.

"Take your time and just get up slowly." Jane reaches for the shelf underneath the massage table. She pulls out a towel and wipes off her hands. Her 'guest' pushes himself up from the table.

He lifts his face up out of the head rest; it's Reno.

"I'll step away and give you some privacy to get dressed." Jane offers.

Reno rolls onto his side, blinking to readjust to the light. He casually says, "No you're fine." Reno runs his hand through his hair. He has a genial smile on his face. A white sheet is draped over his bottom half, but his tan, muscular chest and arms are exposed. "I feel like I owe you dinner, now."

Jane laughs at Reno, who pushes himself up into a sitting position. She discreetly inspects the tattoo on his chest while tossing her hand towel back down to the shelf below the massage table. "I'll take that to mean I did a good job for you, then."

"You could do me one better and hand me my clothes." Reno refers to the metal folding chair nearby, where his grey slacks and white button-down shirt are draped over the back.

"No problem." Jane turns to the folding chair and picks up his clothes. "I'm a little surprised that you volunteered for this in the first place."

Reno lifts a curious brow as Jane winds back around to him. "Thank you." He takes his clothing from her. "Why do you say that?" Reno lays his pants down on the table beside him.

“I was actually searching for some sign of tension but didn’t find any on you. You’re very relaxed.” She sits down in the metal folding chair and crosses her legs.

“Well, I got the tip to come here from one of my clients, Doctor Weaver.” He lies to her.

Jane lights up in recognition. “The school administrator?”

“That’s the one.” Reno starts putting on the white dress shirt.

“He’s a client of yours?” she asks.

“I manage his portfolio. Just met with him earlier in the week.” Reno pulls the shirt on over his shoulders and buttons it up.

“So, you handle investments?”

“Yes I do.”

Jane inquisitively scans up and down between Reno’s face and chest. She sees a very attractive, professional man sporting an obscure tattoo. The dichotomy compels her to ask him about it. “Travesty, huh?”

Remaining reticent, Reno finishes buttoning up his shirt. “Yeah, I have to keep it under wraps, though.”

The two of them lock eyes. Jane nods in understanding.

“So, I was obviously kidding about dinner earlier, but how about a glass of wine?” Reno buttons his cuffs. “I think I saw someplace a few doors down from here.”

“Uh yeah, you did. It’s called Between the Vines.”

“That sounds right.” He shrugs. “What do you think?”

“Sure.” Jane comfortably accepts Reno’s proposition. “Why not?”

***

Meanwhile, Black and Random are sitting in the corner booth below the stained-glass windows on Club Joy’s balcony level. Black’s phone is out on the table. A heavy techno melody throbs in the background.

Though he’s unwound, Random has an alert glint in his eyes. “This is a pretty elaborate plan for the lazy lawyer.”

“Well, when you’re aiming to abduct a congressman’s daughter, you know.” Black sips his drink.

“True. So, how’s it going with Becky?”

“I think I’m done with Becky,” he says ambiguously.

The glint in Random’s eyes turns flat. He picks up his drink and changes the subject. “Did you hear about the bust on I-five today?”

“No, what was it?”

“Something like ten pounds of coke.” Random swirls the ice around in his drink. “Dumbass got pulled over for driving on the shoulder.”

“You’re kidding. That kind of negligence never ceases to amaze me.”

“I know. What are runners responsible for? Getting the product from point A to B.”

“If I had ten pounds of coke in the car, my eyes would never leave the road.” Black’s phone starts flashing red. He answers it. “Yeah? We’re on our way.”

***

Travertine-tiled floors, wrought iron bistro tables and faux stone columns set the outdoor terrace atmosphere of Between the Vines. Its small seating area is nearly full of patrons, and the wooden stools at the bar are all occupied.

Reno and Jane are at a corner table. There’s a half-empty bottle of red wine in the middle of their little round table.

Clutching her glass of wine, Jane leans in over the table chattering away to Reno. “I’m only in my second trimester right now. The anatomy and physiology have been the most difficult so far.” She sips her wine.

Reno keys in on her intently. He appears completely invested in the conversation. “Just the terminology, or what?”

“Yeah.” Jane sets down her wineglass. “That too, but there’s just so much material to learn in general.” She gazes at Reno with a spark of fascination. “What about you, Josh? Where do you work?”

Reno eases back into his chair and picks up his wineglass. “I’ve been with Franklin Atwood for about seven years, now.” He takes a small drink.

“Oh okay, my dad has accounts there.”

“Yeah?” Reno sets his glass down. “What’s his name?”

“Oh, um.” Jane shies away. “Is it weird if I’d rather not say?”

Reno is quick to retort. “It’s about as weird as me not wanting to explain my tattoo.”

They exchange a quiet moment of amity.

“That’s only fair.” Jane looks up at him. “I guess we both have a little duality.” She smiles.

“Yes, I sensed that too.” Reno smiles back at her, competently holding up his end of the wordplay.

Jane fidgets with the stem of her wineglass and demurely adds, “That makes things interesting, though.”

“I fully agree.”

***

That night, Becky is stretched out on her living room couch watching a women's drama. It's the same thing she's been doing all afternoon and evening. Trite depictions of other women's struggles provide a temporary reprieve from her own.

The assortment on Becky's coffee table includes both of her phones, the remote, an empty wineglass and her half-eaten plate of linguini from dinner. Her old phone rings, so she picks up the remote to pause the movie. She checks the screen and answers her phone. "Hello Jackie."

"What are you doing?" she asks on the other line.

"I'm surprised it took you so long to call me."

"I kept thinking eventually you'd show up at work, today."

"I kind of thought I might too, to be honest," Becky says with a pensive lilt.

"So what happened?"

She rolls onto her back, holding the phone up to her ear. "I decided not to give up quite yet."

"Give up on what?"

"Just, turning a new leaf. A fresh start. I don't know."

"And you just decided this out of the blue? No two weeks' notice, nothing?"

Becky scowls at Jackie's criticism. "Yeah I know it's not my typical show of responsibility, but I've come to terms with that."

"You don't sound good." Jackie doles out an upfront comment. "This doesn't have anything to do with that guy, does it?"

"No." She scoffs. "Not anymore. I think I drove him away."

"Drove him away?"

"Yeah, I'm pretty sure."

"Okay, so if that guy is out of the picture now, then what are you thinking?" Jackie probes Becky, who's sprawled out on her back. The living room is dark and still.

"I don't know yet." She pushes herself upright into a sitting position on the couch. "I'm thinking I just need to clear my head and figure out what's going on up there."

"You think that's all it is?"

"I think so." She immediately doubts her confidence. "At least I hope so."

"I hope so, too."

Becky turns towards the TV. She reaches down to pick up the remote. "Do you want to meet up for lunch tomorrow?"

"Sure, touch base when you get up."

“Okay.” She ends the call and gets back to her movie, eyeballing the empty wineglass.

***

Back at Between the Vines, Jane tops off Reno’s wineglass before pouring the last of the merlot into her own glass. She sets the empty bottle down and peers across the table at Reno. He detects her serious gleam.

“What?”

“Can we maybe, avoid asking each other certain details, but get past the façade for a minute?” She quickly clarifies. “I’m not saying that I’m not enjoying myself, because I am.”

“No, I know what you mean,” he says with a mischievous nod. “I can give it a try.”

Jane’s face livens up. “Okay.” She takes a deep breath before spilling her story. “I am like the black sheep of my family. Because it’s either,” she holds out her left hand, “law,” then she holds out her right hand, “or law. There is no recognized alternative.” Jane brings her hands down to her lap and prattles on. “On top of that, I didn’t go to college right after high school because I wasn’t sure what I wanted to do.”

“Not law, I take it.”

“No.” She chuckles. “So here I am, in my late twenties, studying to be a massage therapist. And needless to say, it’s not going over very well. So I’m sort of, left out of certain things because of my life choices.”

“Hmm.” Reno rocks back in his chair and spins a story for her. “Oddly enough, I’m the black sheep in the exact opposite way you are.”

“Oh?” Interested, Jane curls her fingers around the stem of her wineglass and tunes in to Reno.

“Yeah. See I come from nothing, small town Wisconsin, to give you an idea. And I knew from a young age that I wanted out. So I’m the only one in my family who did go to school.”

“Ah,” Jane says through a nod before sipping her wine.

“And I’m the outcast because I think I’m ‘better’ than them. Or so they believe.”

“Mm-hmm.” She arches forward and sets her glass down on the table. “If you ask me, it’s better to just be the black sheep than to live a lie.”

“I hope that’s not just the wine talking.” Reno responds with an upbeat attitude.

***

Later on in Hannah's suite, she's still sitting back on her bed, staring down at the laptop on her thighs, when her phone rings. She puts it on speaker and answers the call cordially. "Well hi, Sam."

"Hi there. I see you're logged on."

"I am." She jumped onto Sam's message board a few minutes ago.

"So?" Sam's vague question hangs in the air.

"What?"

"Did Brian come home last night?"

"Yes!" Hannah boasts. "Yes, he did." She sheepishly adds, "I overreacted."

"Well, we are women. We're prone to that from time to time."

"He's just downstairs mingling right now. It's Friday, so there's a few extra members here tonight."

"And yet, you're logged onto my message board?"

"I haven't been on here in a while. I missed it." Hannah butters her up. "Are you just Amsterdomme?"

"I'm also RunawayFetus." Sam advises her.

"Huh." Hannah chortles. "I wondered about that one." She squints at the screen. "Wow, get a load of this Hater guy."

"Oh I have been." Sam assures her.

Hannah types a few lines and hits 'enter'. "I just went after him."

"I see that. Holy shit, Hannah."

Cracking a smile, Hannah points at her screen in delight. "But look, he's into it!" She gets back to typing.

"That's sick. And that's saying a lot, coming from me."

"Don't judge. Whatever gets the monkey dancing is what I always say."

Sam roars in amusement. "You're in a good mood today." She pokes a hole in the Domme's hardcore veneer.

"I am." Hannah agrees then says, "God, I hope it's temporary."

***

Outside of Between the Vines, Reno and Jane cut through the strip mall parking lot, back to the Community Health Center.

Jane is carrying a to-go coffee cup with a plastic lid. "So Josh, are you involved with anybody right now?"

He grins at her. "Why do you ask, Jane?"

“Because I feel like I want to hear more about you.” She stops mid-step. “Not right now, I don’t mean *right now*.”

Reno softly laughs at her bashfulness. They continue through the parking lot, where he gradually steers them towards Cade’s black SUV. It’s parked directly across from Reno’s Porsche, one of the few cars remaining in that area of the lot.

In front of the SUV, Cade crouches down with his hands on the grill of the truck. He silently listens in on them.

“I think I know what you mean,” Reno tells her.

“Do you now?” She responds playfully.

They arrive at the SUV and stand around by the passenger side.

“Well, at least I hope I do.” Reno keeps up the flirtatious banter.

Jane shoots him a modest smile. She pops the lid off of her coffee and blows off the steam.

Noticing her full cup of coffee, Reno motions to the SUV. “Oh here...” He slips his hand into his pocket and unlocks the doors. “Have a seat and finish your coffee before you drive.” Reno reaches forward to open the passenger side door for Jane. He glances at her coffee. “Here, let me take that so you can get in.” Reno graciously takes the coffee cup out of Jane’s hand.

“Thank you.” She smiles at him and tosses her purse inside on the floor mat.

In front of the SUV, Cade is still crouched down by the grill, inconspicuously moving around to the driver’s side door.

Inside the truck, down on the floor, a coiled black nylon strap slides out from under the passenger seat. Jane unknowingly steps into it. The nylon loop hovers around her left ankle, waiting for her right one...

Next: Volume 2

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